



The Carer's

Cookery Book

Nourishing recipes for exceptional care
Hamilton George Care | Carer Cookery Programme

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Hamilton George Care · The Carer's Cookery Book

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CHAPTER

Foreword

Fred Lloyd George, Co-founder, Hamilton George Care

When I started Hamilton George Care, I was struck again and again by how much a good meal matters. Not just for nutrition, though that is vital. But for dignity. For joy. For the quiet feeling that someone has taken care over you.

Cooking is one of the most intimate things a carer can do for a client. You are entering their home, using their kitchen, feeding them from memory and instinct. At its best, it is an act of love. A shepherd's pie that smells the way their mother's did. A bowl of rice pudding on a grey afternoon. A proper breakfast with the newspapers. These things matter enormously.

Our clients are people who have lived full, rich lives. Many have eaten well, cooked with care, and taken pleasure in food. As they age and need support, that relationship with food should not diminish. It should be protected, and where possible, deepened.

This book was born from a simple belief: that our carers deserve proper culinary training, and that our clients deserve food made with real skill and understanding. Not institutional food. Not shortcuts. Real cooking, made with thought and care.

We have drawn on the traditions of the great British cookery schools in putting this together, and we have worked carefully to connect every recipe to the health needs of the people being cared for. You will find guidance on nutrition, texture adaptation, dementia-sensitive cooking, and the art of making food feel like an occasion, because for many of our clients, mealtimes are among the most important moments of their day.

I hope this book becomes something you return to often. Something you feel proud to cook from. And I hope that the people you care for taste the difference.

Fred Lloyd George

Co-founder, Hamilton George Care
London

Introduction

How to use this book

This cookery book is designed specifically for live-in carers working with Hamilton George Care. It is a practical resource, a training companion, and we hope, something you genuinely enjoy cooking from.

It is structured to take you from the fundamentals through to a full repertoire of 200 recipes, each one chosen for its relevance to the clients in your care. You do not need to read it cover to cover. Use it as you would any good cookery book: dip in, explore, and build your confidence over time.

How the book is organised

The book opens with a set of foundation chapters covering everything you need before you start cooking. These are not optional reading. A carer who understands food safety, basic nutrition, and texture adaptation will cook more safely and more effectively than one who does not.

The recipe chapters that follow are organised by course and category, mirroring the structure of a classic British cookery school curriculum. Within each chapter, recipes progress from straightforward to more technically demanding, so you can build your skills gradually.

How each recipe works

Every recipe in this book follows the same format, so you will quickly learn to navigate it. Here is what to look for:

At the top

- Difficulty rating: Easy, Medium or Hard
- IDDSI texture level for the dish as served
- Health condition tags showing which client needs the dish supports
- A caution flag where allergens or clinical considerations apply

Texture adaptation

- A table showing how to adapt the dish for IDDSI levels 7 down to 4
- Precise instructions for each texture level
- Guidance on consistency, presentation, and safety

In the body

- About this dish: the story and nostalgia behind the recipe
- Ingredients: scaled to one person, with sub-headings where needed
- Method: clear, numbered steps with one action per step
- Health benefits: nutrients and conditions explained

Carer tips

- Nostalgia note: a conversation starter rooted in the dish's history
- Presentation tip: how to make the dish look as good as it tastes
- Watch out for: allergens and clinical cautions
- Make it easier: batch cooking and time-saving notes

A note on quantities

All recipes are written for one person. This reflects the reality of live-in care, where you are usually cooking for your client alone, or occasionally for a client and a family member. Most recipes can be doubled or tripled straightforwardly, and the batch cooking chapter gives specific guidance on scaling up for the freezer.

A note on skill level

Do not be put off by recipes marked Medium or Hard. These ratings reflect technical complexity, not the time required. A slow-cooked lamb shoulder is marked Easy because it largely looks after itself. A hollandaise sauce is marked Hard because it requires concentration and technique. Work through the Easy recipes first and your confidence will build naturally.

A word about the clients you cook for

The people in your care have lived long, full lives. Many have cooked themselves, eaten in good restaurants, and have firm opinions about food. Treat their preferences with respect. Ask questions. Learn what they love and what they dislike. A carer who takes the time to understand a client's relationship with food will provide something far beyond nutrition: they will provide genuine comfort and pleasure.

Hygiene and Kitchen Maintenance

Keeping the kitchen safe and well

Food safety in a care setting is not optional. The people in your care are likely to have reduced immunity, which means they are more vulnerable to foodborne illness than a healthy adult. A lapse in hygiene that might cause a healthy person mild discomfort can be serious for an elderly client. The standards in this chapter are the baseline: they are not negotiable.

Personal hygiene

- Wash your hands thoroughly with soap and warm water for at least 20 seconds before handling any food, after handling raw meat or fish, after using the bathroom, after touching your face or hair, and after handling rubbish or cleaning products.
- Tie back long hair and remove jewellery including rings before cooking.
- Do not cook if you are suffering from a gastrointestinal illness, vomiting or diarrhoea. Inform Hamilton George Care immediately and arrange cover.
- Keep any cuts or grazes on your hands covered with a blue waterproof plaster while cooking.
- Wear a clean apron when cooking and wash it regularly.

Safe food handling

- Always check use-by dates before using any ingredient. Never use food past its use-by date, even if it looks and smells fine.
- Store raw meat and fish on the bottom shelf of the fridge, in sealed containers, well away from cooked food and ready-to-eat ingredients.
- Use separate chopping boards for raw meat, raw fish, vegetables, and cooked food. Colour-coded boards are recommended: red for raw meat, blue for raw fish, green for vegetables, yellow for cooked food.
- Never wash raw chicken. It spreads bacteria across the sink and surrounding surfaces.
- Ensure meat and poultry are cooked through to a core temperature of 75°C or above. Use a probe thermometer: it is one of the most important tools in a care kitchen.
- Cool leftover food quickly (within 2 hours), cover, refrigerate, and consume within 2 days. Reheat only once, to piping hot throughout.

Cross-contamination

Cross-contamination occurs when harmful bacteria are transferred from one food to another, usually via hands, surfaces, or utensils. It is one of the most common causes of foodborne illness. Prevent it by:

- Washing all surfaces, boards, and utensils thoroughly between tasks, particularly when switching between raw and cooked food.

- Never using the same knife for raw meat and salad ingredients without washing it in between.
- Keeping the fridge clean and well-organised, with raw proteins always stored below cooked or ready-to-eat food.

Temperature control

The danger zone

Bacteria multiply most rapidly between 8°C and 63°C. Keep cold food cold (below 5°C) and hot food hot (above 63°C). Never leave cooked food sitting at room temperature for more than 2 hours.

- Check the fridge temperature regularly. It should sit between 1°C and 4°C.
- Check the freezer temperature. It should be at or below -18°C.
- Do not overfill the fridge, as this prevents cold air from circulating.
- Defrost frozen food in the fridge overnight, never on the worktop.

Kitchen maintenance

- Clean surfaces before and after every cooking session using an antibacterial spray and clean cloth or paper towel.
- Wash cloths and tea towels regularly at 60°C or above. Replace dishcloths frequently: a damp cloth left on the worktop is a breeding ground for bacteria.
- Keep the kitchen tidy and organised. A cluttered kitchen is harder to keep clean and increases the risk of accidents.
- Empty the bin regularly and keep the bin area clean.
- Defrost and clean the fridge at least once a month, or whenever spillages occur.
- Clean the oven, hob, and extractor fan regularly. Built-up grease is both a hygiene risk and a fire hazard.
- Keep cleaning products stored separately from food, ideally in a dedicated cupboard below the sink.

Allergens

You must be aware of your client's allergies and intolerances at all times. These should be documented in the client's care plan. The 14 major allergens to be aware of are:

Celery	Cereals containing gluten
Crustaceans	Eggs
Fish	Lupin
Milk	Molluscs
Mustard	Nuts (tree nuts)
Peanuts	Sesame
Soybeans	Sulphur dioxide and sulphites

If you are ever uncertain

If you are ever unsure whether an ingredient is safe for your client, do not use it. Contact the Hamilton George Care team or the client's GP for clarification. It is always better to ask than to assume.

Key Points on Nutrition

Feeding well in later life

The nutritional needs of an elderly person differ significantly from those of a younger adult. As we age, appetite often decreases, the ability to absorb certain nutrients diminishes, and the consequences of poor nutrition become more serious. Understanding these changes will help you make better choices in the kitchen every day.

The risk of malnutrition

Malnutrition is far more common in elderly people than is generally understood. Studies suggest that up to one in three older adults in care settings is malnourished or at risk. The causes are multiple: reduced appetite, difficulty chewing or swallowing, medication side effects, depression, loneliness, and cognitive decline. The consequences are serious: muscle wasting, weakened immunity, poor wound healing, increased falls risk, and faster cognitive decline.

Your role

As a carer, you are often the most important factor in a client's nutritional wellbeing. A meal made with care and presented well is far more likely to be eaten than something that looks uninviting. Small, frequent, calorie-dense meals are often more effective than three large ones. Eating together, or sitting with a client while they eat, significantly improves intake.

Protein

Protein is the single most important macronutrient for elderly clients. It maintains muscle mass, supports wound healing, and underpins immune function. Older adults need more protein per kilogram of body weight than younger adults, yet they often eat less.

- Prioritise protein at every meal: eggs, fish, meat, dairy, legumes.
- For clients with very small appetites, enrich dishes with protein: add full-fat milk or cream to mash, stir Greek yoghurt into soups, use eggs in sauces and puddings.
- Meat and fish are the richest sources. Do not automatically reduce these for elderly clients unless there is a specific clinical reason.

Calories and enrichment

Many elderly clients need more calories than they are consuming. This is counter-intuitive for carers who may associate good nutrition with low-calorie eating. In a care context, the priority is almost always to get enough calories in, not to restrict them.

- Use full-fat dairy: full-fat milk, butter, double cream, full-fat yoghurt.
- Add butter generously to vegetables, mash, and toast.
- Offer calorie-dense snacks: cheese and crackers, peanut butter on toast, full-fat yoghurt with honey.
- Small portions presented attractively are often more effective than large ones.

Key nutrients to prioritise

Calcium and vitamin D

Critical for bone health. Dairy, tinned fish with bones, and fortified foods are key sources. Vitamin D is rarely achieved through diet alone in elderly clients, and is almost never achieved through diet alone in clients with limited sun exposure, which includes most live-in care clients. A daily vitamin D supplement (typically 800-1000 IU, as recommended by the NHS for adults over 65) should be documented in the care plan. If no supplement is listed, flag this to the Hamilton George Care team.

Vitamin B12

Essential for neurological function and often poorly absorbed in older adults. Found in meat, fish, eggs, and dairy. Deficiency is common and linked to cognitive decline and anaemia.

Iron

Supports energy and immune function. Red meat, oily fish, and dark leafy greens are good sources. Haem iron from meat is absorbed far more readily than plant-based iron.

Fibre

Constipation is extremely common in elderly clients and causes significant distress. Adequate fibre from vegetables, fruit, wholegrains, and legumes is essential. Always ensure adequate fluid intake alongside fibre.

Fluids and hydration

Dehydration is endemic in elderly care. The sensation of thirst diminishes with age, so clients frequently do not drink enough. Offer fluids proactively throughout the day. Soups, stews, and high-water-content foods all contribute. Aim for at least 6-8 cups of fluid per day.

Potassium and sodium

Important for heart and kidney function. Clients with CKD require careful potassium management. Processed foods are high in sodium and should be minimised for clients with hypertension or heart failure. A practical guide for carers: when serving any dish containing sausages, bacon, ham, cured or smoked fish, tinned ingredients, or large quantities of hard cheese, always check the care plan for hypertension or heart failure before cooking. For these clients: use low-salt or homemade stock, season very lightly or not at all, and be mindful of portion size for high-sodium components. If in doubt, contact the Hamilton George Care team.

Gut health and probiotic foods

Gut microbiome health is increasingly recognised as important for immune function, mood, and general wellbeing in older adults. Live yoghurt, kefir, and naturally fermented foods such as live-culture yoghurt drinks are practical, accessible probiotic sources that can be included regularly. Where a client tolerates dairy, offering live natural yoghurt as a breakfast option or dessert base (topped with stewed fruit or honey) is a simple way to support gut health. Look for products labelled 'live cultures' or 'contains active cultures.'

Condition-specific considerations

The following are brief summaries only. Always defer to the client's care plan and any guidance from their GP or dietitian.

Dementia

Prioritise familiar, flavourful foods. Finger foods can help clients who struggle with cutlery. Eating together or in a calm environment significantly improves intake. The smell of cooking is itself a positive sensory stimulus.

Diabetes (Type 2)

Prioritise low-GI carbohydrates, increase vegetable content, and reduce added sugars. Do not eliminate carbohydrates entirely. Consistent meal timing matters. Do not restrict calories aggressively.

Dysphagia

Always follow the IDDSI level documented in the care plan. Never deviate from the prescribed texture without clinical guidance. Thickened fluids must be prepared to the correct consistency. See Chapter 5 for full IDDSI guidance.

Parkinson's disease

Timing meals around medication is important, as some medications interact with protein. Constipation is a major concern: prioritise fibre and fluids. Tremor may make self-feeding difficult: finger foods and adapted cutlery can help.

Parkinson's disease: levodopa and protein

Important: many clients with Parkinson's disease are prescribed levodopa or co-careldopa. High-protein meals taken close to medication times can significantly reduce levodopa absorption, causing the medication to be less effective. Where noted in the care plan, offer lower-protein options (porridge, toast, fruit, yoghurt) in the period immediately before and after medication, and reserve protein-rich meals (meat, fish, eggs, cheese) for other times of the day. This timing decision should always be confirmed with the client's GP or specialist nurse, and clearly documented in the care plan.

Vital Techniques

The foundations of good cooking

A small number of techniques underpin almost every recipe in this book. Master these and the rest will follow naturally. This chapter does not attempt to be a comprehensive cooking school: it focuses on the skills you will use every day in a care kitchen.

Knife skills

A sharp knife is safer than a blunt one. A blunt knife requires more force, slips more easily, and produces uneven cuts that cook unevenly. Invest in a good 20cm chef's knife and a small paring knife, and keep them sharp.

- Dice: cut into small, even cubes. For a fine dice (for soffritto or soup bases), aim for 3-5mm cubes.
- Slice: use a rocking motion, keeping the tip of the knife on the board and lifting only the heel.
- Julienne: thin matchstick strips, useful for stir-fries and salads.
- Chiffonade: fine ribbons of leafy herbs or greens. Stack the leaves, roll tightly, and slice across.
- The bridge grip: for cutting large items. Arch the thumb and forefinger over the item to form a bridge, and cut through the centre.
- The claw grip: for slicing. Curl the fingertips under and use the knuckles to guide the blade.

Making a good stock

A good stock is the foundation of soups, sauces, stews, and braises. It takes very little active work and transforms the flavour of everything it touches. The recipes in this book use chicken, lamb, beef, fish, and vegetable stock.

- Start with cold water: this produces a clearer stock.
- Bring slowly to a gentle simmer, never a rolling boil, which clouds the stock and makes it bitter.
- Skim regularly in the first 20 minutes to remove grey foam.
- Do not over-salt stock: reduce it first, then season.
- Strain through a fine sieve and cool quickly. Refrigerate for up to 3 days or freeze in portions.

A note on bought stock

Good-quality bought stock is an acceptable shortcut. Use low-sodium varieties where possible, particularly for clients with heart conditions or hypertension. Avoid stock cubes as the primary seasoning: they are very high in salt.

Sweating and softening vegetables

Sweating vegetables gently in fat is one of the most important techniques in cooking. It develops sweetness, softens texture, and builds the flavour base for soups, sauces, and stews.

- Use a wide, heavy-based pan over a low to medium heat.

- Add enough fat (butter, olive oil, or a combination) to coat the base of the pan.
- Add the vegetables with a pinch of salt, which draws out moisture and speeds softening.
- Cook slowly, stirring occasionally, until completely soft and translucent but not coloured. This takes 8-15 minutes depending on the vegetables.
- If the vegetables start to colour before they are soft, add a splash of water and reduce the heat.

Enriching and finishing

Enriching a dish at the end of cooking is one of the most effective ways to add calories and improve flavour: particularly important in a care kitchen where appetite may be limited.

- Butter: stir a knob of cold butter into a sauce or soup off the heat to add richness and gloss.
- Cream: a splash of double cream added at the end of cooking enriches soups, sauces, and mashes.
- Egg yolk: whisked into a sauce or soup off the heat, it adds richness and body without curdling.
- Cheese: stirred into mash, risotto, or soup adds protein, calcium, and flavour.
- Olive oil: drizzled over a finished dish adds calories and a clean, fresh flavour.

Texture modification

Adapting dishes for clients with dysphagia or chewing difficulties is a core skill in a care kitchen. Always follow the IDDSI level specified in the client's care plan. The following principles apply across all texture modification:

- IDDSI Level 7 (regular): serve as cooked, no adaptation required.
- IDDSI Level 6 (soft and bite-sized): all pieces must be no larger than 1.5cm. No hard, crunchy, or chewy elements. Ensure the dish is moist throughout.
- IDDSI Level 5 (minced and moist): food must be finely minced or chopped to 4mm pieces. Must hold together but not be dry or crumbly. Test by pressing: it should cohere but not be stiff.
- IDDSI Level 4 (puréed): completely smooth with no lumps, skin, seeds, or fibrous pieces. Should hold its shape briefly when spooned. Pass through a fine sieve if in doubt.
- IDDSI Levels 1-3 (fluids): follow the specific consistency guidance in the care plan. Thickening agents must be measured precisely.

Preparing thickened fluids safely

Thickened fluids appear across many recipes in this book. Getting the consistency right is a clinical safety requirement, not a preference. Incorrect thickened fluid consistency is one of the most common causes of aspiration in dysphagia care. Follow these rules without exception:

- Always use the specific thickening agent named in the client's care plan. Do not substitute with cornflour, gravy powder, or other thickeners, as these do not behave predictably and cannot be relied upon to achieve the correct IDDSI level.
- Measure precisely. Use the measurement specified in the product instructions, either by weight or volume. Never add thickener by eye.
- Allow the thickener to fully hydrate before serving. Most commercial thickeners require 1 to 2 minutes of stirring or standing to reach their full consistency. Check after this time.
- Test the consistency before serving using the IDDSI fork drip test (for Levels 1 to 4) or the spoon tilt test (for Level 4). Instructions for these tests are available at iddsi.org.
- If you are unsure whether the consistency is correct, contact the Hamilton George Care team before serving.

Presentation matters at every IDDSI level

Puréed food can be presented attractively using moulds, piping bags, and ramekins. A dish that looks like food, rather than a grey slurry, is far more likely to be eaten. Take the extra minute to present it well.

Reheating safely

- Reheat food to a core temperature of 75°C or above throughout.
- Reheat only once: never reheat the same food twice.
- Add a splash of stock, milk, or water when reheating to prevent drying out.
- Stir halfway through reheating to ensure even temperature throughout.
- Always check the temperature of the centre of the food with a probe thermometer before serving.
- Allow food to rest for 2-3 minutes after reheating before serving, and always check the temperature of what you are serving to avoid burns.

Menu Planning

Thinking ahead for better care

Good menu planning is one of the most practical skills a carer can develop. A week of meals thought through in advance is more nutritious, less wasteful, less stressful, and more enjoyable for both carer and client than deciding what to cook at the last minute.

Why plan ahead

- Shopping is more efficient and less expensive when you know what you need.
- Batch cooking becomes possible, saving significant time across the week.
- Nutritional balance is easier to achieve across a week than meal by meal.
- Variety is built in, avoiding the repetition that can deaden appetite.
- The client feels more involved and in control when asked about preferences in advance.

How to build a balanced week

A well-planned week of meals for an elderly client should include:

Protein every day

Aim for at least two substantial protein sources daily: breakfast eggs or smoked fish, a meat or fish lunch, a protein-rich dinner. Dairy snacks supplement this.

Oily fish twice a week

Salmon, mackerel, sardines, trout, and herring provide omega-3 fatty acids important for brain and heart health. These are particularly valuable for clients with dementia or cardiovascular conditions.

Vegetables at every meal

Aim for a variety of colours across the week. Frozen vegetables are nutritionally equivalent to fresh and reduce waste. Lightly cooked vegetables are often more easily eaten than raw.

One batch cook per week

Designate one session (Sunday is natural) to make a large batch of something that will serve across two or three lunches or dinners. A big pot of soup, a shepherd's pie, a bolognese, or a stew all freeze or keep well.

Pudding is not optional

A pudding adds calories, pleasure, and structure to a meal. For clients with reduced appetite, a small pudding is often eaten when the main course is not finished. Custard, rice pudding, stewed fruit, and cream-based desserts are calorie-dense and easy to eat.

Involve the client

Ask the client at the start of each week what they feel like eating. Present two or three options for each day if possible. Having some control over what you eat is important for dignity and wellbeing.

Shopping and kitchen organisation

- Write a shopping list from the weekly menu before you go. Group items by category: protein, dairy, vegetables, store cupboard.
- Keep a well-stocked store cupboard: tinned tomatoes, stock, dried pasta, rice, lentils, tinned fish, good olive oil, and a range of dried herbs and spices.
- Label and date everything stored in the fridge or freezer.
- Check use-by dates when unpacking shopping and rotate older items to the front.
- Keep the freezer stocked with batch-cooked portions for days when time is short or the client is unwell and needs something quickly.

Adapting for changing appetite

A client's appetite may change day by day depending on their health, medication, mood, and activity level. A good carer is responsive to this, not rigid.

- If a client is not hungry, offer something small and calorie-dense rather than a full meal: a boiled egg, a piece of cheese, a small bowl of soup.
- If a client is particularly hungry, take the opportunity to offer extra protein or a more substantial pudding.
- Never force a client to eat. Encourage, offer, and try again later.
- Keep a note of what the client eats and when. If you notice a consistent decline in intake over several days, inform Hamilton George Care.

Menu Plans

A week of meals for every client

The following menu plans are designed as starting points, not rigid prescriptions. Adapt them to your client's preferences, health conditions, and appetite. Each plan is built around the nutritional principles in Chapter 3, with variety, protein, and calorie density in mind.

Standard weekly menu plan

Suitable for most clients without significant dietary restrictions. All recipes are found in the recipe chapters.

	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Pudding
Monday	Porridge with honey and cream	Leek and potato soup with bread	Roast chicken with gravy and veg	Rice pudding
Tuesday	Boiled egg and toast soldiers	Coronation chicken salad	Shepherd's pie	Stewed pears with ginger
Wednesday	Smoked haddock kedgeree	Cream of mushroom soup	Baked cod with parsley sauce	Bread and butter pudding
Thursday	Yoghurt with stewed fruit	Egg mayonnaise sandwich	Beef stew and dumplings	Lemon posset
Friday	Soft poached eggs and salmon	Tomato soup with crusty bread	Pan-fried salmon, lemon butter	Fruit crumble and custard
Saturday	Full English (adapted)	Ploughman's lunch	Slow-cooked lamb shoulder	Eton mess
Sunday	Kippers with brown bread	Roast beef and Yorkshire pud	Cold meat, bubble and squeak	Treacle tart and cream

Menu plan: dementia focus

Familiar, flavourful dishes with strong nostalgic associations. Finger food options at lunch to support independence. Two portions of oily fish per week are included to support cognitive health.

	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Pudding
Monday	Porridge with honey	Soft boiled egg, toast fingers	Shepherd's pie	Rice pudding
Tuesday	Scrambled eggs on toast	Egg and cress sandwiches	Pan-fried salmon, lemon butter	Semolina pudding
Wednesday	Boiled egg and soldiers	Cheese and cracker bites	Toad in the hole, onion gravy	Bread and butter pudding
Thursday	Porridge with cream	Smoked salmon sandwiches	Fish pie	Baked egg custard

Friday	Live yoghurt with stewed fruit	Mini quiches	Liver and bacon, onion gravy	Spotted dick and custard
Saturday	French toast with banana	Welsh rarebit	Roast chicken with all trimmings	Fruit crumble and custard
Sunday	Kippers and brown bread	Potted shrimps	Slow-cooked lamb shoulder	Queen of puddings

Menu plan: dysphagia focus (IDDSI Level 4-5)

All dishes adapted to IDDSI Level 4 or 5. Refer to the texture adaptation table in each recipe for preparation guidance.

	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Pudding
Monday	Smooth porridge with cream	Blended chicken and veg dinner	Puréed fish in cream sauce	Smooth rice pudding
Tuesday	Soft scrambled egg with cream	Smooth leek and potato soup	Blended lamb and rosemary stew	Smooth fruit fool
Wednesday	Moist porridge, honey	Smooth carrot and lentil purée	Minced and moist chicken in gravy	Enriched milk pudding
Thursday	Yoghurt with stewed fruit	Smooth tomato soup	Blended beef stew with soft mash	Lemon posset
Friday	Smooth avocado with soft egg	Puréed fish in cream sauce	Smooth cauliflower cheese purée	Mango and coconut panna cotta
Saturday	Savoury egg custard with cheese	Smooth pea and mint purée	Tender pork with mash	Chocolate mousse
Sunday	Enriched milk (warm, with honey)	Smooth sweet potato purée	Blended lamb stew	Smooth rice pudding

Menu plan: high calorie enrichment

For clients at risk of malnutrition or with very small appetites. Dishes are enriched with butter, cream, and full-fat dairy at every opportunity.

	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Pudding
Monday	Porridge with cream and honey	Cream of mushroom soup and bread	Fish pie (extra cream in mash)	Rice pudding with cream
Tuesday	French toast with banana	Egg mayo on white bread	Shepherd's pie (enriched mash)	Bread and butter pudding
Wednesday	Full English with extra egg	Chicken liver pâté on toast	Beef stew and dumplings	Spotted dick and custard
Thursday	Scrambled eggs with cream	Potted shrimps on brown bread	Cauliflower cheese	Baked egg custard
Friday	Kippers and buttered toast	Coronation chicken sandwich	Pan-fried salmon, lemon butter	Lemon posset with cream
Saturday	Boiled egg and buttered soldiers	Cheese and cracker bites	Slow-cooked lamb shoulder	Syllabub

Sunday	Smoked haddock kedgeriee	Ploughman's with extra cheese	Roast beef and Yorkshire pudding	Treacle tart and cream
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Soups and Broths

The foundation of good care cooking

Soups and broths sit at the very heart of this book. They are among the most forgiving things to cook, the most nutritious, and the most comforting to receive. A good soup is warm, sustaining, and deeply familiar: for many older clients, a bowl of homemade soup will be more welcome than almost anything else you can offer.

In a care kitchen, soups serve a particular purpose beyond simple nourishment. They are naturally easy to eat, adaptable to almost any IDDSI level, gentle on digestive systems, and an outstanding vehicle for hidden nutrition. A soup enriched with cream, butter, lentils, or a beaten egg yolk delivers far more than it appears to. A thin, clear broth provides hydration as well as nourishment: vital for clients who do not drink enough.

The ten recipes in this chapter range from the simplest chicken broth to the more considered spiced carrot and coriander soup. All of them are worth making from scratch. None of them are complicated. The skill lies not in technique but in patience: in sweating your vegetables properly, using a good stock, and tasting as you go.

A note on stock

Every soup in this chapter will be significantly improved by a good homemade stock. The recipe for simple chicken stock is included in the Sauces and Stocks chapter, and a large batch takes very little active work. If you use bought stock, choose a good-quality, low-sodium variety and taste carefully before adding any additional salt.

A note on texture

Most soups in this chapter are naturally suited to clients with texture modification needs. A smooth soup passed through a fine sieve reaches IDDSI Level 4 without any significant additional effort. For clients on thickened fluids, the soup must be prepared to the correct IDDSI level and thickened if required: never assume a smooth soup is thin enough or thick enough without checking. Refer to the individual recipe texture tables and always confirm with the care plan.

Enrichment

For clients who need additional calories, soups are an ideal vehicle for enrichment. At the end of cooking, before serving, consider:

- A generous knob of butter stirred in off the heat.
- A swirl of double cream or crème fraîche.
- A beaten egg yolk whisked in off the heat for richness and protein.
- A spoonful of full-fat cream cheese blended in for creaminess and calories.
- A handful of grated Parmesan or mature cheddar stirred through.

Before the recipes

The ten recipes that follow are presented in order of simplicity. Begin with the chicken broth if you are new to soup-making: it requires almost no technique and produces something genuinely restorative. The recipes become progressively more involved as the chapter progresses, ending with the cream of mushroom soup, which requires a proper béchamel base. By the end of this chapter, you will have the foundations to make almost any soup you encounter.

Hamilton George Care | hamiltongeorgecare.com | Carer Cookery Programme



Chapter 8

Soups & Broths

Nourishing broths, hearty soups, and warming bowls

Classic Chicken Broth

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 1

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 2 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

COPD

ABOUT THIS DISH

Chicken broth is the oldest and most restorative dish in the canon. It has been made in British kitchens for centuries, prescribed by doctors and offered by mothers alike as the first response to illness, cold, and frailty. It is the most elemental thing a carer can make: warm, deeply nourishing, gentle on the stomach, and profoundly comforting. For clients who can manage little else, a cup of good broth is never nothing.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Free-range chicken carcass or 2 chicken thighs on the bone	<i>1 carcass / 2 thighs</i>
Brown onion, halved (skin on for colour)	<i>1 medium</i>
Carrot, scrubbed and halved	<i>1 large</i>
Celery sticks, roughly broken	<i>2 sticks</i>
Leek, roughly chopped	<i>1 small</i>
Flat-leaf parsley stalks	<i>A small bunch</i>
Bay leaves	<i>2</i>
Black peppercorns	<i>6-8</i>
Cold water	<i>1.5 litres</i>
Salt	<i>To taste</i>

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the chicken carcass or thighs in a large saucepan. Cover with the cold water. Bring slowly to a gentle simmer over a medium heat. As the liquid heats, grey foam will rise to the surface: skim this away carefully with a ladle or large spoon. This takes patience but makes a cleaner, clearer broth.
- Once the foam has subsided, add the onion, carrot, celery, leek, parsley stalks, bay leaves, and peppercorns. Do not add salt yet.
- Reduce the heat to the lowest possible simmer. The surface should tremble gently, not bubble vigorously. A hard boil makes a cloudy, bitter broth. Simmer uncovered for at least 1 hour 30 minutes, and up to 2 hours for a deeper flavour.
- Strain the broth through a fine sieve into a clean saucepan, pressing gently on the vegetables to extract all the liquid. Discard the solids. If using chicken thighs, pick the meat from the bones and set aside: it can be returned to the broth or used separately.
- Taste and season with salt. The broth should taste clean, golden, and deeply savoury. If it tastes thin, return to the heat and simmer uncovered for a further 20 minutes to concentrate.
- Serve warm in a cup or bowl, with or without the shredded chicken meat. A few drops of good olive oil on the surface add richness and calories.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Collagen and gelatine from the bones: supports joint health and gut lining integrity.
- Easily absorbed minerals including calcium, magnesium, and phosphorus extracted during the long simmer.
- High fluid content: one of the most effective ways to support hydration in clients who do not drink enough.
- Glycine from the connective tissue: supports sleep quality and muscle repair.
- Light on the digestive system: ideal for clients who are unwell, post-operative, or have very little appetite.

Good for these conditions

- Dementia: the smell of broth simmering is one of the most evocative of all cooking aromas. For many clients it will trigger strong, positive memories of childhood kitchens.
- Dysphagia: at IDDSI Level 1 (thin liquid) this is suitable for most clients with swallowing difficulties. For thickened fluid requirements, thicken to the prescribed level.
- COPD: warm, easily taken fluids reduce the effort of eating. Small, frequent cups of broth throughout the day support both hydration and calorie intake.
- Appetite: broth is one of the few things most clients will accept even when they feel too unwell or too low in appetite to eat anything else.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
1	Thin liquid	Serve as made. Strain thoroughly to ensure no particles remain. Suitable as a thin fluid for most dysphagia profiles.
2-3	Slightly thick / moderately thick	Add a measured amount of prescribed thickening agent to achieve the required consistency. Always measure precisely and stir thoroughly.

4	Puréed	Blend any returned chicken meat to a completely smooth paste and whisk into the broth. The result should be a smooth, slightly enriched broth. Pass through a fine sieve.
7	Regular	Return the picked chicken meat to the broth and serve as a simple, clear soup. Add soft-cooked noodles or pearl barley for a more substantial dish.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Chicken broth is one of the most universally comforting foods in British life. Many clients will associate it strongly with being cared for during childhood illness. Simply saying "I've made you some broth" carries a weight of reassurance that few other dishes can match. Offer it in a cup if a bowl feels too much.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed cup or small soup bowl. A few shreds of chicken meat and a single sprig of flat-leaf parsley make it look considered without fuss. For clients with very small appetites, offer a small cup first rather than a full bowl.

Watch out for

Broth is naturally low in sodium if made from scratch, but do watch for seasoning: clients with hypertension or heart failure should have very lightly salted broth. Ensure the broth is strained to a thin, clear liquid for dysphagia clients: any particles or fibres are a safety risk at IDDSI Level 1.

Make it easier

Make a large batch at the weekend and freeze in individual cup-sized portions. A good broth keeps in the fridge for 3 days and in the freezer for 3 months. Reheat gently in a small saucepan: do not boil, as this diminishes the flavour.

Leek and Potato Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Leek and potato soup is a cornerstone of British home cooking, simple in its ingredients and deeply satisfying in the bowl. It became a staple of the British kitchen in the mid-twentieth century and for many clients of a certain age it is the default soup, the one they think of first when the weather turns cold. Made properly, with good stock and a generous hand with the leeks, it is silky, sweet, and warming.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Leeks, white and pale green parts only, washed and sliced	<i>2 medium</i>
Maris Piper potatoes, peeled and roughly diced	<i>200g</i>
Brown onion, finely diced	<i>1 small</i>
Garlic clove, crushed	<i>1 clove</i>
Good chicken or vegetable stock	<i>500ml</i>
Unsalted butter	<i>25g</i>
Double cream (optional, for enrichment)	<i>2-3 tbsps</i>
Salt and white pepper	<i>To taste</i>
Chives or flat-leaf parsley to serve	<i>A few sprigs</i>

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt the butter in a large, heavy-based saucepan over a low heat. Add the onion and leeks with a pinch of salt. Cook very gently for 10-12 minutes, stirring occasionally, until completely soft and sweet but not coloured. Do not rush this step: the sweetness of the leeks is the foundation of the soup.
- Add the garlic and cook for a further minute. Add the diced potatoes and stir to coat in the buttery leeks.
- Pour in the stock, bring to a gentle simmer, and cook for 20-25 minutes until the potatoes are completely tender when pierced with a knife.
- Remove from the heat. Using a stick blender, blend the soup until completely smooth. Alternatively, ladle into a jug blender in batches, being careful with the hot liquid.
- Return to the heat, stir in the cream if using, and heat through gently. Taste and season carefully with salt and white pepper.
- Serve in a warmed bowl, finished with a swirl of cream and a few snipped chives.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Potassium from the leeks and potatoes: supports heart health and blood pressure regulation.
- Folate from the leeks: important for cell repair and reducing homocysteine levels.
- Vitamin C from both leeks and potatoes: supports immune function and iron absorption.
- Fibre: supports digestive health and constipation prevention.
- Calories from the butter and cream: an excellent vehicle for calorie enrichment.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: naturally low in saturated fat before the cream is added. Use a light touch with the cream and omit salt for clients with hypertension.
- Diabetes: the potato content raises blood sugar modestly. Reduce the potato and increase the leek ratio for clients who need tighter glucose control.
- Appetite: smooth and easy to eat, this soup is often accepted when solid food is not. Enrich generously with cream for clients at risk of malnutrition.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend until completely smooth and pass through a fine sieve for the cleanest result. The soup should fall slowly from a spoon and hold its shape briefly.
5	Minced and moist	Blend less thoroughly, leaving very small soft pieces of leek. Check no pieces exceed 4mm.
7	Regular	Serve as made, smooth and creamy. Offer a small piece of soft bread alongside if appropriate.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

For most clients over 70, leek and potato soup is among the most familiar of all dishes. It is associated strongly with autumn and winter, with mothers and grandmothers, and with the sense of being fed and looked after. Ask the client whether they prefer it smooth or with a little texture: the conversation itself is a pleasant one.

Presentation tip

A smooth, cream-coloured soup needs a considered finish. A thin swirl of cream, a few drops of green chive oil (blended chives with olive oil), or a scattering of snipped chives all add visual distinction without complexity. Serve in a warmed bowl.

Watch out for

Leeks are high in potassium: this soup should be avoided or modified for clients with chronic kidney disease (CKD). Omit the leek green tops entirely and reduce the potato portion for the most restricted CKD diets. Always check the care plan.

Make it easier

This soup keeps well in the fridge for 2-3 days and freezes for up to 3 months. Make a larger batch and freeze in individual portions. To reheat, warm gently in a saucepan with a splash of stock or milk to restore the smooth consistency.

Roasted Tomato and Basil Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 50 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Cancer support

Appetite/nutrition



High in potassium from the tomatoes: use with caution for clients with CKD. Reduce portion size or substitute with roasted red pepper for a lower-potassium version.

ABOUT THIS DISH

Roasting transforms tinned or fresh tomatoes, concentrating their natural sugars and producing a soup of a deeper, richer colour and flavour than the stovetop method alone achieves. This is a soup with a very British modern history: it became a household staple from the 1990s onwards and will be familiar to almost all clients. It is brighter and more vivid than many soups in this chapter, and works well as a starter for clients who need their appetite stimulated before a main course.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Ripe plum tomatoes, or 2 x 400g tins of good plum tomatoes	600g / 800g tinned
Brown onion, quartered	1 medium
Garlic cloves, unpeeled	4 cloves
Olive oil	3 tbsp
Good chicken or vegetable stock	400ml
Fresh basil leaves	A large handful
Caster sugar	1 tsp
Double cream (optional)	2 tbsp
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 200°C / 180°C fan / Gas 6.

- If using fresh tomatoes, halve them and place cut-side up on a large roasting tray. If using tinned tomatoes, pour them onto the tray and spread out. Add the onion quarters and unpeeled garlic cloves. Drizzle generously with olive oil and season with salt and pepper.
- Roast in the preheated oven for 35-40 minutes until the tomatoes are caramelised at the edges and the onion is soft and golden. The garlic should be soft inside its skin.
- Allow to cool slightly, then squeeze the roasted garlic from its skins directly into a large saucepan. Add all the roasted tomatoes and onion, scraping up any caramelised juices from the tray.
- Pour in the stock and add the sugar and most of the basil. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook for 5 minutes.
- Blend until completely smooth using a stick blender. Pass through a fine sieve, pressing firmly, to remove skin and seeds. Return to the pan.
- Taste and adjust seasoning. Add a little more sugar if the tomatoes are acidic. Stir in the cream if using. Serve hot, finished with the remaining basil leaves torn over the top.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Lycopene from the roasted tomatoes: a powerful antioxidant associated with reduced cancer risk, and better absorbed from cooked tomatoes than raw. • Vitamin C: supports immune function and iron absorption. • Vitamin K: important for bone health. • Potassium: supports heart health and blood pressure, though note the caution for CKD clients. • Olive oil provides heart-healthy monounsaturated fats and additional calories.	• Heart health: tomatoes and olive oil are both associated with cardiovascular benefit. Use without cream and with minimal salt for clients with hypertension. • Cancer support: lycopene from roasted tomatoes is one of the most studied anti-cancer nutrients. This soup is an easy and delicious way to include it regularly. • Appetite: the bright colour and vivid flavour of this soup can stimulate appetite in clients who are disinterested in food. Serve as a small starter portion if appetite is poor.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend thoroughly and pass through a fine sieve to remove all skin and seeds. The result should be completely smooth. Check consistency: it should fall slowly from a spoon.

5	Minced and moist	Blend less thoroughly, leaving very small soft pieces. Sieve to remove any skin. Check no pieces exceed 4mm.
7	Regular	Serve smooth with a swirl of cream and fresh basil. Offer a small piece of soft bread or a cheese straw alongside.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Tomato soup has an almost universal nostalgic resonance in Britain, partly through the tinned variety which was a staple of family lunches from the 1950s onwards. This homemade version is considerably superior and the comparison is often a pleasant conversation starter. Many clients will comment that it is "so much better than the tin" and that in itself is a small pleasure.

Presentation tip

The deep red-orange colour of this soup is its greatest visual asset. Serve in a white bowl to contrast. A thin swirl of cream, a single basil leaf, and a few drops of good olive oil are all that is needed. For clients who enjoy a little texture, a small crouton or a cheese straw alongside adds interest.

Watch out for

Tomatoes are moderately high in potassium: avoid for clients with CKD or modify with a smaller portion. Tinned tomatoes vary considerably in acidity and sweetness: taste before serving and adjust the sugar accordingly. The soup should not be sharp or acidic when served.

Make it easier

This soup can be made entirely from tinned tomatoes, which are actually superior to out-of-season fresh tomatoes and require no preparation. Make a large batch and freeze in individual portions. The roasting step can be done in advance and the roasted tomatoes stored in the fridge for up to 2 days before making the soup.

Mulligatawny Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Heart health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Mulligatawny is one of the great dishes of the British colonial kitchen, brought back from India and adapted by Victorian cooks into something entirely its own: spiced, rich, and deeply savoury. It appeared on the menus of London clubs and country house dining rooms throughout the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries and will be strongly remembered by clients who grew up in households where it was a regular feature. It is warming without being fiery, aromatic without being overpowering, and more interesting than most soups in a care setting.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chicken thighs, skinless and boneless, diced	150g
Brown onion, finely diced	1 medium
Carrot, finely diced	1 medium
Garlic cloves, crushed	2 cloves
Fresh ginger, finely grated	1 tsp
Mild curry powder	2 tsp
Ground cumin	1 tsp
Ground coriander	1 tsp
Turmeric	0.5 tsp
Tinned chopped tomatoes	200g
Good chicken stock	600ml
Red lentils, rinsed	50g
Coconut milk or double cream	50ml

Olive oil	1 tbsp
Salt and pepper	To taste
Fresh coriander to serve (optional)	A few leaves

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat the olive oil in a large, heavy-based saucepan over a medium heat. Add the onion and carrot with a pinch of salt. Cook for 8-10 minutes until softened and beginning to colour.
- Add the garlic and ginger and cook for a further 2 minutes, stirring, until fragrant.
- Add the curry powder, cumin, coriander, and turmeric. Stir well and cook the spices for 1-2 minutes until fragrant. This step is important: cooking the spices in the fat rather than adding them with the liquid makes a significant difference to the final depth of flavour.
- Add the diced chicken and stir to coat in the spice mixture. Cook for 3-4 minutes until sealed on all sides.
- Add the tinned tomatoes and stir well. Add the lentils and pour in the stock. Bring to a simmer and cook for 25-30 minutes until the lentils are completely soft and the chicken is cooked through.
- Remove from the heat. For a smooth soup, blend thoroughly with a stick blender. For a more textured finish, blend only half the soup and stir together. Stir in the coconut milk or cream.
- Return to the heat, taste, and season. The soup should be warmly spiced, rich, and golden. Serve with a little fresh coriander if the client enjoys it.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the chicken and lentils: excellent for muscle maintenance and wound healing.
- Fibre from the lentils: supports digestive health and constipation prevention.
- Curcumin from the turmeric: a powerful anti-inflammatory compound of particular interest for joint and neurological health.
- Iron from the lentils: supports energy and immune function.
- Coconut milk or cream adds important calories for clients at risk of malnutrition.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the aromatic spicing of mulligatawny stimulates appetite effectively. The familiar-but-interesting flavour profile often works well for clients who have grown bored of plainer soups.
- Dementia: many clients aged 75 and over will have a strong association with this dish from childhood or early adult life. The aroma of the spices is distinctive and memory-triggering.
- Heart health: lentils, turmeric, and lean chicken are all associated with cardiovascular benefit. Use coconut milk sparingly for clients with elevated cholesterol.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend until completely smooth and pass through a fine sieve. The spiced lentil base blends very smoothly. Check no fibrous pieces of chicken remain.
5	Minced and moist	Blend thoroughly but not completely, leaving very small moist pieces of chicken and soft lentil. Check all pieces are under 4mm.
7	Regular	Serve with texture: shreds of tender chicken, soft lentils, and a swirl of cream. Offer a small piece of soft naan or white bread alongside if appropriate.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Mulligatawny was a feature of British dining room life from the Victorian era through to the mid-twentieth century and many clients will have a strong association with it from childhood or from dining in clubs and hotels. It is worth mentioning the name before serving; the word itself often triggers a positive response. Ask whether the client has had it before and how.

Presentation tip

The golden-amber colour of this soup is striking. Serve in a warmed white bowl with a swirl of cream or coconut milk and a single small leaf of coriander. For clients who dislike coriander, omit entirely: a few drops of olive oil work equally well as a finish.

Watch out for

Keep the spicing mild: this is not a hot curry. Use a mild curry powder only and taste before serving. For clients who are sensitive to spice, reduce the curry powder to 1 teaspoon. Lentils are moderately high in potassium: reduce the quantity for clients with CKD.

Make it easier

The lentils thicken this soup naturally as it cools and reheats. Add an extra splash of stock when reheating to restore the correct consistency. The soup freezes very well and the flavour improves after a day in the fridge.

Butternut Squash and Ginger Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Dementia

Diabetes

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Butternut squash soup is a relative newcomer to the British table, becoming popular from the 1990s onwards, but it has quickly established itself as a modern classic. Its vivid orange colour, natural sweetness, and velvety texture make it one of the most visually appealing and easy-to-eat soups in this book. The ginger adds warmth and digestive benefit without sharpness. It is a particularly good choice for clients who need their appetite stimulated or who have been unwell.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Butternut squash, peeled, deseeded, and diced into 3cm cubes	400g
Brown onion, roughly diced	1 medium
Garlic cloves, unpeeled	3 cloves
Fresh ginger, peeled and roughly sliced	2cm piece
Good chicken or vegetable stock	500ml
Olive oil	2 tbsp
Ground cumin (optional)	0.5 tsp
Double cream or coconut milk to serve	2 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 200°C / 180°C fan / Gas 6.

- Place the squash cubes and onion on a large roasting tray. Tuck in the unpeeled garlic cloves and the ginger slices. Drizzle generously with olive oil and season with salt, pepper, and the cumin if using. Toss to coat.
- Roast for 30-35 minutes until the squash is golden at the edges, completely tender, and caramelised. The roasting is what gives this soup its depth of flavour: do not rush it.
- Squeeze the garlic from its skins into a large saucepan. Add all the roasted squash, onion, and ginger. Pour in the stock.
- Blend until completely smooth using a stick blender. The soup should be thick and velvety.
- Return to the heat. If the soup is very thick, add a little more stock to achieve a good pouring consistency. Taste and season.
- Serve in a warmed bowl, finished with a swirl of cream or coconut milk and a small grinding of black pepper.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Beta-carotene from the squash: a powerful antioxidant converted to vitamin A in the body. Important for immune function, vision, and skin health. • Gingerols from the fresh ginger: anti-inflammatory compounds that support digestive health and reduce nausea. • Vitamin C: supports immune function and collagen synthesis. • Potassium: supports heart health. Note the caution for CKD clients. • Fibre: the squash provides good dietary fibre to support digestive regularity.	• Dementia: the vivid orange colour of this soup is visually engaging and easy to identify. Strong visual contrast between food and bowl supports independence at mealtimes for clients with dementia. • Diabetes: butternut squash has a moderate glycaemic index and is much lower in starch than potato-based soups. A good choice for clients managing blood sugar, served without bread. • Cancer support: beta-carotene and vitamin C are both important antioxidants. The anti-inflammatory properties of ginger are of particular interest in cancer care.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	The roasted squash blends to an almost perfectly smooth consistency. Pass through a sieve for the cleanest result. Adjust consistency with extra warm stock.
5	Minced and moist	Blend less thoroughly, leaving very small soft pieces. Check no pieces exceed 4mm. Add extra stock to ensure the mixture is sufficiently moist.

7	Regular	Serve smooth with a swirl of cream. A few toasted pumpkin seeds on top add texture and visual interest for clients who can manage them safely.
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CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Butternut squash soup is more recent than many dishes in this book, but it has become widely familiar and is often associated with the pleasure of autumn. Many clients will have encountered it in good restaurants or made it themselves in their earlier years. The beautiful colour alone tends to provoke a positive response.

Presentation tip

The deep amber-orange of this soup is its greatest asset. Serve in a white bowl, finish with a spiral of cream or coconut milk, and perhaps a few drops of chilli oil for clients who enjoy a little heat. The colour contrast is inherently appetising.

Watch out for

Butternut squash is moderately high in potassium: modify or avoid for clients with CKD. The ginger is gentle but can occasionally cause heartburn in clients with gastric reflux: reduce or omit if this is a concern.

Make it easier

This soup improves overnight as the flavours deepen. Make a large batch on the weekend, freeze in portions, and reheat as needed. The roasting step can be done in advance and the squash kept in the fridge for up to 2 days before making the soup.

Bone Broth

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 1

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 4-6 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health	Appetite/nutrition	Parkinson's
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ABOUT THIS DISH

Bone broth is distinct from a simple chicken broth in both method and character. The long cooking time and the roasting of the bones before simmering produce a much darker, richer liquid with a depth of mineral content and collagen that a shorter broth cannot match. It has been made in British kitchens for centuries and is experiencing a well-founded revival in nutritional circles. For clients with bone density concerns, Parkinson's, or low appetite, it is one of the most nourishing things you can offer.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chicken, beef, or lamb bones (ask a butcher)	500g-1kg
Apple cider vinegar (helps extract minerals from the bones)	2 tbsp
Brown onion, halved	1
Carrot, halved	1 large
Celery sticks	2 sticks
Garlic cloves, crushed	4 cloves
Bay leaves	2
Black peppercorns	8
Fresh thyme or rosemary sprigs	3-4 sprigs
Cold water	2 litres
Salt	To taste at end only

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 220°C / 200°C fan / Gas 7.

- Spread the bones on a large roasting tray and roast in the preheated oven for 30-35 minutes until deeply golden and caramelised. This step is essential: it is what gives bone broth its dark colour and rich flavour. Do not skip it.
- Transfer the roasted bones to a large stockpot or slow cooker. Pour in the cold water and add the apple cider vinegar. Allow to stand for 30 minutes before heating: this acidic soak helps draw minerals from the bones.
- Add the onion, carrot, celery, garlic, bay leaves, peppercorns, and herbs. Bring very slowly to the gentlest possible simmer.
- Skim off any foam that rises in the first 20-30 minutes. Then leave to simmer, barely trembling, for a minimum of 4 hours and up to 6 hours. The longer it simmers, the richer and more gelatinous the result. A slow cooker on low overnight is ideal.
- Strain through a fine sieve into a clean saucepan or heatproof container. Discard the solids. Season with salt only at the end.
- Cool completely. When refrigerated, a good bone broth will set to a jelly: this is a sign of its high gelatine content and is exactly what you want. Skim the fat from the surface before reheating.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Collagen and gelatine: supports joint cartilage, gut lining integrity, and skin health. The long cooking time extracts far more than a short broth. • Calcium, magnesium, and phosphorus: extracted directly from the bones during the long acid simmer. Significant contribution to bone mineral density. • Glycine and proline: amino acids that support sleep quality, muscle repair, and gut health. • Glutamine: supports intestinal lining integrity, particularly important for clients on long-term medication. • Almost zero carbohydrate: suitable for diabetic clients without any blood sugar impact.	• Bone health: one of the most direct dietary sources of bone minerals. Particularly valuable for clients with osteoporosis or osteopenia. • Parkinson's: warm, easy-to-take liquids that require no chewing. The glycine content may support sleep quality. Can be sipped from a cup or taken through a straw. • Appetite: highly nourishing with very little volume. A small cup of enriched bone broth provides significant nutritional benefit even for clients who manage very little food.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
1	Thin liquid	Serve as strained, at a gentle warmth. Suitable for thin fluid IDDSI profiles. Thicken with a prescribed agent if required.

2-3	Slightly / moderately thick	Add a measured amount of prescribed thickening agent. Stir well and check consistency before serving.
7	Regular	Serve in a warmed cup or small bowl. A few soft-cooked noodles, soft vegetables, or shredded meat can be added for clients who want more substance.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Bone broth has a longer history in British kitchens than almost any other dish in this book. Many clients will remember their mothers or grandmothers making stock from the Sunday roast carcass as a matter of course, and the smell of bones roasting is deeply familiar. Frame it as "proper homemade stock" rather than the more contemporary term "bone broth" for clients who might find the latter unfamiliar.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed cup or small soup bowl. The dark, golden-brown colour is handsome. A single twist of lemon peel on the surface adds a fresh note. For clients who have difficulty holding a cup, a handled mug with a lid is practical and dignified.

Watch out for

Bone broth is naturally high in sodium from the bones themselves: season carefully and taste before adding any additional salt, particularly for clients with hypertension or heart failure. Ensure the broth is completely strained for dysphagia clients: no particles, skin, or bone fragments must remain.

Make it easier

A slow cooker is the ideal vessel for bone broth: set it on low before bed and strain in the morning. The broth can be frozen in ice cube trays for very small portions and defrosted individually as needed. Butchers are often happy to give or sell bones cheaply: chicken carcasses are the easiest to source.

Brown Windsor Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 1 hr 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Brown Windsor soup is one of the most quintessentially Victorian British dishes, appearing on the menus of gentlemen's clubs, railway dining cars, and country house tables throughout the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. It fell out of fashion in the mid-twentieth century and became something of a byword for institutional cooking at its worst, but a properly made Brown Windsor is a revelation: rich, deeply savoury, warming, and quite unlike the thin, tasteless version that earned it its unfortunate reputation. For clients of a certain age and background, serving it is an act of culinary archaeology.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Shin of beef or braising beef, diced small	150g
Brown onion, finely diced	1 medium
Carrot, finely diced	1 large
Celery, finely diced	1 stick
Turnip or swede, finely diced	80g
Good beef stock	600ml
Plain flour	1 tbsp
Unsalted butter	20g
Worcestershire sauce	1 tsp
Tomato puree	1 tbsp
Fresh thyme	2 sprigs
Bay leaf	1

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Season the beef pieces well with salt and pepper. Heat a heavy-based saucepan over a high heat, add a little oil, and brown the beef in batches until deeply caramelised on all sides. Do not crowd the pan. Remove and set aside.
- Reduce the heat to medium, add the butter, and cook the onion, carrot, celery, and turnip for 8-10 minutes until softened.
- Add the flour and tomato puree, stir well, and cook for 2 minutes. Return the beef to the pan.
- Pour in the stock, add the Worcestershire sauce, thyme, and bay leaf. Bring to a gentle simmer, cover, and cook for 1 hour to 1 hour 15 minutes until the beef is completely tender.
- Remove the thyme sprigs and bay leaf. For a traditional version, blend approximately two-thirds of the soup to give a thick, rich, slightly textured result. For a fully smooth soup, blend completely.
- Return to the heat, taste, and season carefully. The soup should be dark, rich, and deeply savoury.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein and iron from the beef: excellent for muscle maintenance, wound healing, and preventing anaemia.
- Collagen from the shin of beef: extracted during the long cooking, supports joint health.
- Zinc from the beef: supports immune function and wound healing.
- Vitamin B12: critical for neurological health, often poorly absorbed in older adults.
- Carrots provide beta-carotene; turnip and celery provide fibre and vitamin C.

Good for these conditions

- Dementia: one of the most powerfully nostalgic soups in this book for clients of a certain age and background. The name alone will often trigger a strong response. The rich, savoury aroma is unmistakable.
- Appetite: calorie-dense from the beef and deeply savoury. The long-cooked beef flavour is often more appetising than lighter soups for clients who have lost interest in food.
- Bone health: the collagen extracted from the beef shin during long cooking contributes to bone and joint support.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend completely until smooth and pass through a fine sieve. The beef must be completely tender before blending. Add extra warm stock if the purée is too thick.

5	Minced and moist	Ensure the beef is completely tender. Blend or finely mince to very small pieces under 4mm. The sauce must keep all pieces moist.
7	Regular	Serve with a partially blended texture: rich and thick with some small, very tender pieces of beef. Offer with soft bread for a more substantial meal.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Brown Windsor is one of the most nostalgically charged names in British culinary history. For clients who dined in clubs, hotels, or good restaurants in the mid-twentieth century it will be immediately familiar, often with a smile. It is worth telling the client you are making it by name in advance: it tends to produce a reaction. Ask whether they remember it and what they think of it.

Presentation tip

The deep mahogany colour is the defining characteristic of this soup. Serve in a warmed white bowl. A single small piece of toasted bread or a crouton floating in the centre, and perhaps a very small sprig of thyme, is all that is needed. Do not over-garnish.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies: substitute with a gluten-free alternative if required. The soup is moderately high in sodium from the stock and Worcestershire sauce: taste carefully before serving and use a low-sodium stock for clients with hypertension or heart failure.

Make it easier

This soup benefits enormously from being made a day ahead: the flavour deepens overnight. The beef can be cooked in a slow cooker on low for 6-8 hours, then the soup finished on the stovetop. It freezes well for up to 3 months.

Cream of Mushroom Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A good cream of mushroom soup is one of the finest soups in the British repertoire: deeply savoury, silky, and satisfying in a way that is hard to articulate. It became a staple of British home cooking from the mid-twentieth century, when the tinned version was ubiquitous, but the homemade version is in a different category entirely. The key is to cook the mushrooms until completely concentrated and golden before adding any liquid: this step takes patience but is the difference between a good soup and an extraordinary one.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chestnut or button mushrooms, cleaned and sliced	300g
Brown onion, finely diced	1 small
Garlic clove, crushed	1 clove
Unsalted butter	30g
Plain flour	1 tbsp
Good chicken or vegetable stock	400ml
Double cream	100ml
Fresh thyme leaves	1 tsp
A few drops of truffle oil (optional, for finishing)	To taste
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt the butter in a large, heavy-based saucepan over a medium heat. Add the onion with a pinch of salt and cook for 5-6 minutes until soft and translucent.
- Add the mushrooms and increase the heat to medium-high. Cook, stirring occasionally, for 10-12 minutes until all the moisture has evaporated and the mushrooms are concentrated, golden, and beginning to caramelise at the edges. This is the most important step: do not rush it and do not add liquid until the mushrooms are completely dry.
- Add the garlic and thyme, stir well, and cook for a further minute.
- Sprinkle over the flour and stir to coat all the mushrooms. Cook for 2 minutes to remove the raw flour taste.
- Pour in the stock gradually, stirring constantly to prevent lumps. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook for 10 minutes.
- Remove from the heat and blend until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve for the smoothest result. Return to the pan, add the cream, and heat gently. Do not boil after adding the cream. Taste and season generously with salt and white pepper.
- Serve in a warmed bowl with a swirl of cream and a few drops of truffle oil if using.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Beta-glucans from the mushrooms: a form of fibre associated with immune support and cholesterol regulation. • Vitamin D: mushrooms exposed to light are one of the few plant sources of vitamin D, of particular importance for clients with limited sun exposure. • B vitamins including B2, B3, and B5: support energy metabolism and neurological function. • Selenium: an important antioxidant mineral often low in elderly diets. • Cream adds significant calories: important for clients at risk of malnutrition.	• Dementia: the rich, deeply savoury aroma of concentrated mushrooms is among the most evocative of cooking smells. The familiar flavour profile of cream of mushroom soup will resonate strongly with most clients. • Appetite: the umami depth of this soup tends to stimulate appetite. The silky texture is easy to take and very satisfying. Enrich further with extra cream or a beaten egg yolk for clients who need more calories. • Dysphagia: at IDDSI Level 4 this is a naturally appropriate texture for most swallowing profiles. Ensure it is passed through a fine sieve for clients at Level 4 to remove any remaining mushroom fibres.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend thoroughly and pass through a fine sieve to remove any fibrous mushroom pieces. The result should be completely smooth. Check consistency: it should flow but hold its shape briefly.

5	Minced and moist	Blend less thoroughly, leaving very small pieces of mushroom under 4mm. The soup must be sufficiently saucy to keep all pieces moist.
7	Regular	Serve smooth and creamy with a swirl of cream. Some sliced sautéed mushrooms reserved before blending and placed on top add texture and visual interest.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Cream of mushroom soup has a particular place in the British middle-class consciousness through both the tinned version, which was a staple of the 1950s-70s kitchen, and the homemade version which was a feature of dinner party starters in that era. Many clients will say immediately that it reminds them of something. The difference in quality between this and the tinned version is a worthwhile talking point.

Presentation tip

A uniformly dark, velvety soup benefits from careful finishing. A swirl of double cream, a few very thinly sliced raw mushrooms or small sautéed pieces on top, and a few drops of truffle oil if available make this soup look as distinguished as it tastes. Serve in a white bowl.

Watch out for

This soup contains a significant amount of cream: use with caution for clients with very high cholesterol or advised to follow a low-fat diet. Reduce or substitute the cream with full-fat milk if needed. The soup thickens considerably as it cools: add extra stock when reheating.

Make it easier

The concentrated mushroom base can be made ahead and refrigerated for up to 2 days before adding the stock and cream. The finished soup keeps in the fridge for 2 days. It does not freeze well as the cream can split on reheating: add the cream fresh each time if freezing.

Cock-a-Leekie Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 1 hr 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Heart health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Cock-a-leekie is one of the oldest soups in the British Isles, with roots in Scottish cookery going back at least to the sixteenth century. It was a feature of formal Scottish dining and was well known throughout Britain by the nineteenth century. The traditional recipe includes prunes, which add a gentle sweetness and depth that balances the savoury chicken and leek perfectly. For clients of a certain background and age, this is a dish of considerable historical and personal resonance: refined, comforting, and deeply nourishing.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chicken thighs on the bone, skin removed	2 thighs
Leeks, washed and sliced into rounds	3 medium
Good chicken stock	700ml
Prunes, stoned and halved (traditional: do not omit)	6 prunes
Pearl barley (optional, for substance)	30g
Fresh thyme sprigs	3 sprigs
Bay leaf	1
Flat-leaf parsley, chopped	A small handful
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the chicken thighs in a large saucepan. Pour over the stock, add the thyme, bay leaf, and pearl barley if using. Bring slowly to a gentle simmer. Skim off any foam that rises.
- Add half the sliced leeks to the simmering pot. Cook gently for 1 hour until the chicken is completely tender and falling from the bone.
- Remove the chicken thighs and set aside to cool slightly. Remove and discard the thyme sprigs and bay leaf.
- Add the remaining fresh leeks and the prunes to the simmering broth. Cook for a further 15-20 minutes until the leeks are completely soft and the prunes have partially dissolved into the broth.
- Meanwhile, pick the chicken meat from the bones, discarding all skin and bone. Shred the meat into small, tender pieces.
- Return the shredded chicken to the soup. Taste and season carefully. Stir in the chopped parsley.
- Serve in a warmed bowl: a golden, fragrant broth with soft leeks, tender chicken, and the sweet note of the prunes.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Lean protein from the chicken thighs: excellent for muscle maintenance and wound healing.
- Fibre from the prunes: one of the most effective dietary interventions for constipation, which is endemic in elderly care.
- Potassium from the leeks: supports heart health and blood pressure.
- Sorbitol in prunes: a natural laxative effect that supports bowel regularity.
- Pearl barley adds fibre and a low-GI carbohydrate source, supporting sustained energy release.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the combination of chicken, leeks, and sweet prunes is unusual enough to be interesting without being unfamiliar. The golden broth is deeply appetising.
- Dementia: a dish of considerable historical resonance for clients of British and particularly Scottish heritage. Mentioning the name is often enough to trigger a response.
- Heart health: very low in saturated fat. The chicken, leeks, and barley are all associated with cardiovascular benefit.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend the entire soup until completely smooth, including the prunes which blend to a smooth, sweet enrichment. Pass through a fine sieve. The result is a rich, golden, sweet-savoury purée.
5	Minced and moist	Finely shred the chicken into very small pieces under 4mm. Chop the leeks finely. The prunes will be very soft: chop finely. Ensure plenty of broth to keep everything moist.
7	Regular	Serve as made: a clear, golden broth with tender shreds of chicken, soft leeks, and plump prunes. A classic and beautiful soup.

Nostalgia note

Cock-a-leekie has a particularly strong resonance for clients of Scottish heritage but is widely known across Britain. The inclusion of prunes often surprises clients who do not remember this detail: it is always worth mentioning and tends to prompt a discussion about whether they have encountered the traditional version before. Many clients will not have tasted it in decades.

Presentation tip

Serve as a clear broth with visible pieces of tender chicken, soft leeks, and soft, dark prunes. It is a handsome soup that needs no garnish beyond a little flat-leaf parsley. Serve in a warmed wide bowl so the broth and its contents can be seen clearly.

Watch out for

The prunes have a laxative effect and should be used with some awareness if the client already has digestive sensitivity. Reduce to 3 prunes for clients who are prone to loose stools. Pearl barley contains gluten: omit for clients with coeliac disease or gluten intolerance.

Make it easier

This soup is ideally made in a slow cooker: place all ingredients together and cook on low for 6-8 hours. The chicken will be falling from the bone. It keeps in the fridge for 3 days and freezes very well for up to 3 months.

Spiced Carrot and Coriander Soup

Soups and Broths | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Carrot and coriander soup became one of the most popular homemade soups in Britain during the 1980s and 1990s and is likely to be one of the most familiar dishes in this chapter for clients in their 70s and 80s. It is bright, warming, naturally sweet, and beautifully coloured. The coriander adds a gentle aromatic quality that lifts the sweetness of the carrots without overpowering them. It is among the simplest soups to make well, and it rarely fails to please.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Carrots, peeled and roughly diced	350g
Brown onion, diced	1 medium
Garlic clove, crushed	1 clove
Ground coriander	2 tsp
Ground cumin	0.5 tsp
Good chicken or vegetable stock	600ml
Unsalted butter or olive oil	20g / 1.5 tbsp
Fresh coriander leaves and stalks, roughly chopped	A small bunch
Double cream (optional)	2 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat the butter or oil in a large saucepan over a medium heat. Add the onion with a pinch of salt and cook for 6-8 minutes until soft and translucent.
- Add the garlic, ground coriander, and cumin. Stir and cook for 2 minutes until fragrant.
- Add the diced carrots and stir to coat in the spiced onion mixture.
- Pour in the stock. Bring to a simmer and cook for 20-25 minutes until the carrots are completely tender when pierced with a knife.
- Add the fresh coriander, stalks and all. Remove from the heat and blend until completely smooth.
- Return to the heat, stir in the cream if using, and heat through gently. Taste and season with salt and white pepper.
- Serve in a warmed bowl with a swirl of cream and a few small fresh coriander leaves if the client enjoys them.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Beta-carotene from the carrots: converted to vitamin A in the body, important for immune function, vision, and skin health. One of the richest vegetable sources available. • Anti-inflammatory compounds from the coriander and cumin: support digestive health and reduce systemic inflammation. • Vitamin K from the carrots and fresh coriander: supports bone health and blood clotting. • Fibre: supports digestive regularity and feeds beneficial gut bacteria. • Naturally low in fat and calories before cream is added: suitable for clients monitoring calorie intake.	• Heart health: carrots, coriander, and cumin are all associated with cardiovascular benefit. A naturally low-fat soup before cream is added. Use olive oil rather than butter for clients with elevated cholesterol. • Diabetes: carrots have a low glycaemic load in soup form. The fibre content slows sugar absorption. A good choice for clients managing blood sugar, particularly served without bread. • Cancer support: the beta-carotene content of carrots is among the highest of any vegetable. Anti-inflammatory spices contribute additional protective compounds.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	The carrots blend to a very smooth consistency. Pass through a fine sieve for the smoothest result. Adjust consistency with extra warm stock as needed.
5	Minced and moist	Blend less thoroughly, ensuring all pieces are under 4mm. The soup should be well sauced to keep the pieces moist.

7	Regular	Serve smooth and vivid orange. A swirl of cream and a few coriander leaves finish it well. Offer a small piece of warm crusty bread alongside for clients who can manage it.
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CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Carrot and coriander soup became fashionable in the 1980s alongside the broader interest in fresh, homemade cooking that characterised that era. Many clients will have made it themselves or encountered it in restaurants and dinner parties. It has the particular quality of feeling both familiar and slightly special, which makes it an ideal choice for a simple lunch that nonetheless feels considered.

Presentation tip

The vivid orange colour of this soup is its greatest visual asset. Serve in a white bowl to contrast. A swirl of cream, a few fresh coriander leaves (for clients who enjoy them), and a few drops of olive oil make a clean, attractive finish. The soup should be smooth and glossy.

Watch out for

Some clients dislike fresh coriander intensely: always check before serving. Ground coriander (the spice) is milder and less divisive than the fresh herb, so the soup can be made without the fresh herb if preferred. Carrots are relatively low in potassium compared to other vegetables and are generally safe for clients with mild CKD, but check the care plan.

Make it easier

This is one of the quickest soups in the chapter to make from start to finish. It keeps in the fridge for 3 days and freezes for up to 3 months. The flavour improves overnight. Reheat gently, adding a splash of stock to restore the smooth consistency.



Chapter 9

Starters

Elegant beginnings and small plates

Potted Shrimps with Brown Bread

Starters | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Potted shrimps are one of the great British seaside delicacies, with roots in the eighteenth century and a strong association with Morecambe Bay. Tiny brown shrimps set in spiced clarified butter, served with brown bread: a dish of absolute simplicity and considerable refinement. For clients who ate well throughout their lives, this is a starter of real pleasure. It requires almost no cooking and can be prepared quickly on any day.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooked brown shrimps, peeled	100g
Unsalted butter	60g
Ground mace	A pinch
Ground cayenne pepper	A pinch
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Lemon juice	A few drops
Brown bread, thinly sliced and buttered	2 slices
Lemon wedge to serve	1

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt the butter in a small saucepan over a gentle heat. Add the mace, cayenne, and nutmeg. Stir gently.
- Add the shrimps and warm through for 1-2 minutes only. Do not overheat. Add a few drops of lemon juice and taste.
- Spoon into a small ramekin, pressing the shrimps down gently. Pour the spiced butter over to just cover. Refrigerate for at least 30 minutes until set.
- Remove from the fridge 10 minutes before serving. Serve with thin brown bread and butter and a wedge of lemon.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the shrimps: a lean, complete protein source supporting muscle maintenance.
- Iodine: shrimps are one of the richest dietary sources, important for thyroid function.
- Vitamin B12: supports neurological function.
- Butter provides fat-soluble vitamins A, D, E and K and significant calories.
- Low carbohydrate: suitable for clients managing blood sugar.

Good for these conditions

- Dementia: potted shrimps are associated strongly with seaside holidays and formal dining. The name and presentation both tend to provoke a warm response.
- Appetite: rich and buttery, served in a small portion. Ideal before a main course for clients with limited appetite.
- Heart health: shrimps are low in saturated fat. Use a slightly lighter hand with the butter for clients with cardiovascular concerns.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with brown bread.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Shrimps are already very small. Serve on soft bread without crusts.
5	Minced and moist	Finely chop the shrimps and mix with the spiced butter. Serve on very soft moistened bread.
4	Puréed	Blend the shrimps and spiced butter until completely smooth. Pass through a sieve. Serve as a smooth pate.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Potted shrimps are associated with a certain style of British dining: seaside hotels, gentlemen's clubs, the kind of lunch once taken seriously. Many clients will not have encountered them in years. Placing a small ramekin on the table is itself an event.

Presentation tip

Serve the ramekin on a small plate with a wedge of lemon and two thin slices of brown bread and butter, crusts removed and cut into triangles.

Watch out for

Check for shellfish allergy. Cayenne and mace are very mild here but omit for clients with sensitive digestion. Ensure the butter has come to room temperature before serving or it will be too firm.

Make it easier

Keeps in the fridge for up to 3 days once set. Make in the morning and serve at lunch with no further work.

Avocado and Prawn Cocktail

Starters | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes



High in potassium from the avocado: avoid or reduce for clients with chronic kidney disease (CKD).

ABOUT THIS DISH

Prawn cocktail was the defining British dinner party starter from the 1960s through the 1980s, appearing on virtually every celebration table. With avocado, fashionable since the 1970s, it becomes more substantial and nutritionally valuable. For clients of this generation it carries very strong nostalgic associations with occasions and celebrations.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooked king prawns, peeled	80g
Ripe avocado, halved	Half
Little gem lettuce leaves	A few
Good mayonnaise	2 tbsp
Tomato ketchup	1 tsp
Worcestershire sauce	A dash
Lemon juice	A squeeze
Paprika to finish	A pinch
Brown bread and butter	1 slice

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the Marie Rose sauce: mix the mayonnaise, ketchup, Worcestershire sauce, and lemon juice. Taste and adjust.
- Shred the lettuce and arrange in a small glass or bowl.
- Fan or dice the avocado and arrange alongside the lettuce.
- Toss the prawns in half the Marie Rose sauce and spoon over. Drizzle the remaining sauce over.
- Dust with paprika. Serve with thin brown bread and butter.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Monounsaturated fats from the avocado: strongly associated with heart health. • Potassium from the avocado: supports blood pressure regulation. • Protein from the prawns: lean and complete. • Vitamin E from the avocado: a powerful antioxidant. • Folate: important for cell repair.	Good for these conditions • Heart health: avocado and prawns both associated with cardiovascular benefit. • Diabetes: a low-carbohydrate starter. The avocado provides healthy fats that slow glucose absorption.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Prawns are tender and avocado naturally soft.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut prawns and avocado into small pieces under 1.5cm.
5	Minced and moist	Finely chop prawns and mash avocado. Combine with sauce to a moist mixture.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Few dishes carry as much nostalgic weight for this generation as prawn cocktail. Many clients will associate it immediately with Christmas dinner or a special restaurant. The glass presentation is important: it signals occasion.

Presentation tip

Serve in a stemmed glass if possible. Prawns visible on top, paprika dusting, lemon on the rim.

Watch out for

Check for shellfish allergy. Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. Avocado must be ripe: check the day before.

Make it easier

Marie Rose sauce keeps in the fridge for 2 days. Do not slice the avocado until just before serving.

Chicken Liver Pate on Toast

Starters | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Chicken liver pate is one of the most underrated dishes in British cookery: quick, extraordinarily nutritious, and of a richness that belies its simplicity. It was a staple of the British dinner party from the 1960s onwards. The keys are not overcooking the livers and using enough butter.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chicken livers, cleaned and trimmed	150g
Unsalted butter	60g
Shallot, finely diced	1 small
Garlic clove, crushed	1 clove
Fresh thyme leaves	1 tsp
Brandy or port (optional)	1 tbsp
Double cream	2 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Toast or soft bread to serve	2 slices
Cornichons to serve	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt half the butter in a frying pan. Cook the shallot for 3-4 minutes until soft. Add the garlic and thyme.
- Increase the heat. Add the livers and cook 2-3 minutes each side. They should be browned outside but slightly pink within. Do not overcook.
- Add the brandy if using and allow to bubble for 30 seconds.
- Transfer to a blender with the cream and remaining butter. Blend until smooth. Season well.
- Pass through a sieve, spoon into a ramekin, refrigerate for at least 1 hour. Serve with toast and cornichons.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Iron: one of the single richest dietary sources available, far exceeding red meat. • Vitamin A: liver is the most concentrated food source. • Vitamin B12: extremely rich. One serving provides several times the daily requirement. • Folate: important for cell repair and reducing cognitive decline risk. • Zinc: supports immune function and wound healing.	• Appetite: richness and depth of flavour very effective at stimulating appetite. A small amount is nutritionally significant. • Dementia: familiar from dinner parties and entertaining. The smell of the livers cooking is itself a positive trigger. • Cancer support: extraordinary nutrient density makes liver one of the most valuable foods in cancer care.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve spread on hot toast. Offer cornichons alongside.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Serve a generous spoonful on soft bread without crusts, cut small.
4	Puréed	The pate is already smooth if passed through a sieve. Thin with a little cream to achieve correct IDDSI 4 consistency.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Chicken liver pate is associated with the careful home entertaining of the 1960s-70s, often from a Robert Carrier or Elizabeth David recipe. Ask if the client has a recipe they used to use.

Presentation tip

Serve in a small ramekin, hot toast cut into soldiers, two or three cornichons alongside.

Watch out for

Very high in vitamin A: check for clients on high-dose supplements. Do not serve to clients who dislike offal without asking first.

Make it easier

Keeps in the fridge for 4 days sealed with butter. Freezes for 1 month.

Soft Boiled Egg with Soldiers

Starters | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 2 mins | Cook 6 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

A perfectly soft-boiled egg with buttered soldiers is one of the most elemental pleasures of British breakfast and lunch culture. For many elderly clients it is deeply associated with childhood: a Sunday morning, a sick day in bed, a grandmother's kitchen. It requires almost no skill but considerable attention to timing.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Large free-range egg, at room temperature	1 egg
White or brown bread	1 slice
Unsalted butter	A generous knob
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Bring a small saucepan of water to a rolling boil. Gently lower the egg in. Set a timer for exactly 6 minutes for a runny yolk, or 7 minutes for a slightly firmer yolk.
- While the egg cooks, toast the bread and butter it generously while hot. Cut into soldiers approximately 2cm wide.
- When the timer sounds, remove the egg and place in an egg cup. Cut the top off.

- Season the yolk lightly. Serve immediately with the soldiers.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein: eggs contain all essential amino acids in near-perfect proportions.
- Vitamin D: one of the few reliable food sources. Important for bone health.
- Choline: essential for brain health. Eggs are the richest dietary source.
- Lutein and zeaxanthin: support eye health.
- B vitamins including B2, B12, and folate.

Good for these conditions

- Dementia: few dishes carry more nostalgic weight. Associated universally with being looked after. The tactile pleasure of dipping the soldier is valuable.
- Appetite: small, complete, and manageable. An excellent choice for clients not hungry enough for a full meal.
- Bone health: vitamin D and protein both contribute to bone density maintenance.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Scoop the egg from the shell and serve in a small bowl. Cut bread small.
5	Minced and moist	Scramble the egg softly. Serve on very soft well-buttered bread without crusts.
4	Puréed	Blend a softly scrambled egg with butter and a little cream until smooth.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

There is almost no client for whom a boiled egg and soldiers will not produce an immediate warm response. Ask how they like their egg: 6 minutes or 7. That small act of asking gives them control and signals attentiveness.

Presentation tip

Use a proper egg cup. Soldiers cut neatly alongside. A small pinch of paprika on the yolk is a nice touch.

Watch out for

Timing is everything. Use a timer without exception. Ensure the egg white is fully set for clients with compromised immune systems.

Make it easier

Once you know the client's preference, entirely reliable. A phone timer every time removes all uncertainty.

Smooth Mackerel Pate with Cucumber

Starters | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Smoked mackerel pate is one of the most effortless things a carer can make, requiring no cooking whatsoever. Smoked mackerel has a deep savoury intensity that cream cheese smooths into something spreadable and elegant. It became fashionable in British home cooking in the 1970s and 80s and will be immediately familiar to most clients.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Smoked mackerel fillets, skinned and flaked	150g
Full-fat cream cheese	80g
Horseradish sauce	1 tsp
Lemon juice	1 tbsp
Black pepper	A grind
Cucumber, thinly sliced	A few slices
Toast or oatcakes to serve	2-3
Fresh dill (optional)	A little

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Check the mackerel carefully for bones. Place in a food processor with the cream cheese, horseradish, and lemon juice.
- Blend until smooth but with a little texture remaining. Taste and adjust lemon and pepper.
- For a completely smooth result, pass through a sieve.
- Spoon into a small dish. Refrigerate for 20 minutes. Serve with cucumber, toast or oatcakes, and dill.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 fatty acids: mackerel is among the richest fish sources, strongly associated with brain and heart health.
- Protein from both the mackerel and cream cheese.
- Vitamin D: oily fish is one of the best dietary sources.
- Calcium from the cream cheese.
- Iodine from the fish: supports thyroid function.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: omega-3 rich oily fish is one of the most evidence-based dietary interventions for cardiovascular health.
- Dementia: omega-3 DHA is strongly associated with brain health and reduced dementia risk.
- Bone health: vitamin D from the mackerel and calcium from the cream cheese support bone density.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with toast or oatcakes and cucumber.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Serve on soft bread without crusts, cut small. Slice cucumber very thinly or omit.
4	Puréed	Blend completely smooth and pass through a fine sieve. Thin with a little cream if needed.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Smoked mackerel pate became a fixture of the British kitchen in the 1970s when smoked fish became more available. Many clients will have made it themselves or encountered it at dinner parties.

Presentation tip

Serve in a small ramekin with cucumber alongside, a few sprigs of dill, and oatcakes or toast triangles.

Watch out for

Check for fish allergy. Horseradish can cause gastric irritation: reduce or omit for clients with reflux. Ensure all bones are removed before blending.

Make it easier

No cooking required. Takes under 10 minutes. Keeps in the fridge for 3 days.

Angels on Horseback

Starters | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Heart health



High in sodium from the bacon. Contains molluscs: check for shellfish allergy.

ABOUT THIS DISH

Angels on horseback are among the most quintessentially British of all savouries: oysters wrapped in bacon and grilled, served on toast. They appeared on Victorian and Edwardian dinner tables as a savoury course after pudding. For clients of a certain background, they carry an almost ceremonial quality and tend to provoke both surprise and pleasure.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Fresh oysters, shucked, or tinned smoked oysters	4 oysters
Streaky bacon rashers, rind removed	4 rashers
White bread, toasted	1 slice
Butter	A little
Black pepper	A grind
Flat-leaf parsley to serve	A little

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Pat the oysters dry. Season with black pepper.
- Wrap each oyster in a rasher of streaky bacon. Secure with a cocktail stick if needed.

- Place on a baking tray under a very hot grill. Cook for 3-4 minutes, turning once, until the bacon is golden.
- Butter the toast and cut into small squares. Remove the cocktail sticks.
- Arrange on the toast. Serve immediately, very hot.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Zinc from the oysters: one of the richest dietary sources. Critical for immune function.
- Vitamin B12: oysters are extraordinarily rich, supporting neurological health.
- Iron and selenium: important for energy and immune function.
- Protein from both the oysters and bacon.

Good for these conditions

- Dementia: a dish of strong cultural resonance for clients from backgrounds where formal dining was part of life.
- Appetite: savoury, rich, and served in small individual pieces. The contrast of crisp bacon and soft oyster is stimulating.
- Heart health: the oysters are excellent for heart health. Use leaner back bacon for clients with cardiovascular concerns.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Both oyster and well-cooked bacon should be tender enough for most clients.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure bacon is very well cooked until completely soft. Cut into small pieces under 1.5cm.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Angels on horseback represent a world of British dining that has largely vanished: the savoury course, served after the pudding on a starched tablecloth. Many clients from certain backgrounds will have a vivid fond memory of them.

Presentation tip

Serve neatly arranged on buttered toast. Must be served immediately.

Watch out for

Both dishes are high in sodium from the bacon. Limit frequency for clients with hypertension or heart failure. The bacon must be cooked until fully tender, not crispy. Crispy or chewy bacon is a choking risk for clients with any dental difficulty or reduced chewing ability. These dishes are suitable at IDDSI Level 7 only and should not be offered to clients below this level. Serve immediately from the grill.

Make it easier

Can be prepared (wrapped) up to 2 hours ahead and kept in the fridge. Grill just before serving.
Tinned smoked oysters work very well.

Devils on Horseback

Starters | Serves 1 | Autumn and winter

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Devils on horseback are the prune-filled cousin of angels on horseback: the sweetness of the prune against the salty, smoky bacon is a combination of real sophistication. Like angels on horseback, they were served as a Victorian savoury course. The prunes also provide one of the most effective dietary interventions for constipation in elderly clients.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Ready-to-eat prunes, stoned	4 prunes
Streaky bacon rashers, rind removed	4 rashers
White bread, toasted	1 slice
Butter	A little
Cayenne pepper	A pinch (optional)

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Wrap each prune tightly in a rasher of streaky bacon. Secure with a cocktail stick if needed.
- Place on a baking tray under a very hot grill. Cook for 3-4 minutes, turning once, until the bacon is golden.
- Butter the toast and cut into small squares. Remove the cocktail sticks.
- Arrange on the toast. Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Fibre from the prunes: highly effective for relieving constipation. Prunes contain sorbitol, a natural laxative, and high levels of soluble fibre.
- Potassium from the prunes: supports heart health.
- Vitamin K: important for bone health.
- Iron from the prunes.
- Protein from the bacon.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the sweet-savoury combination is unusual and stimulating to the palate.
- Dementia: the name alone tends to produce a reaction of delight.
- Bone health: vitamin K from the prunes contributes to bone density maintenance.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Prunes are naturally soft.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure bacon is very well cooked and soft. Cut into small pieces under 1.5cm.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Devils on horseback carry the same ceremonial quality as angels on horseback. The sweet prune and salty bacon combination surprises and delights most clients.

Presentation tip

Arranged neatly on buttered toast, served immediately and very hot. A pinch of cayenne is the traditional finish.

Watch out for

Both dishes are high in sodium from the bacon. Limit frequency for clients with hypertension or heart failure. The bacon must be cooked until fully tender, not crispy. Crispy or chewy bacon is a choking risk for clients with any dental difficulty or reduced chewing ability. These dishes are suitable at IDDSI Level 7 only and should not be offered to clients below this level. High in sodium from the bacon: limit for clients with hypertension.

Make it easier

Can be prepared ahead and grilled to order.

Potted Beef with Toast

Starters | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 2 hrs 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Potted beef is one of the oldest British preserves: slow-cooked beef pounded with butter and spices, sealed with clarified butter and served cold. It appears in British cookery books from the seventeenth century onwards. The result is something between a pate and a spreadable beef paste: intensely savoury and richly buttered. It is rarely seen today, which makes it all the more worth making.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Braising or shin of beef, diced	200g
Unsalted butter	80g
Ground mace	A pinch
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Ground cloves	A very small pinch
Worcestershire sauce	1 tsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Toast or crusty bread to serve	2 slices

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the beef in a small ovenproof dish with a tight-fitting lid. Add 20g butter, the spices, Worcestershire sauce, and seasoning. Add just enough water to barely cover.

- Cover and cook at 150°C / 130°C fan for 2-2.5 hours until the beef is completely tender.
- Drain the beef, reserving the cooking liquid. Cool slightly.
- Shred the beef finely, then beat or pulse in a processor until fibres break down. Do not over-process.
- Beat in remaining softened butter. Add a little cooking liquid. Season generously.
- Pack into small ramekins. Seal with clarified butter. Refrigerate for at least 2 hours. Serve with hot toast.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the beef: excellent for muscle maintenance and wound healing.
- Iron and zinc: beef is one of the richest sources of both.
- Vitamin B12: critical for neurological health.
- Collagen from the slow cooking: supports joint health.
- Significant calories from the butter.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: intensely flavoured and rich. A small amount is nutritionally significant.
- Dementia: potted beef is associated with a now-rare tradition of British larder cooking.
- Bone health: collagen from the long cooking contributes to joint and bone support.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve slightly softened on hot toast.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Serve a generous spoonful on soft bread without crusts.
4	Puréed	Process more thoroughly until completely smooth. Add extra butter and a little warm cooking liquid. Pass through a sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Potted beef represents a world of British domestic cooking that has almost entirely disappeared: the larder, the preserving tradition, the careful use of every cut. Many clients from rural backgrounds will have strong memories of potted meats.

Presentation tip

Serve in the ramekin with a clarified butter seal on top. Hot toast alongside. Simple and considered.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. Allow to come fully to room temperature before serving or it will be very firm.

Make it easier

Makes a large batch: keeps in the fridge for 5 days, sealed with butter. Freezes for 2 months.

Smoked Salmon with Brown Bread and Butter

Starters | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Smoked salmon with brown bread and butter is a British classic of the highest order: effortless, elegant, and deeply pleasurable. It has been a staple of the British celebration table since the nineteenth century and remains associated with occasions and special treatment. For clients who ate well, this is a dish that signals consideration and respect. It requires no cooking, only good ingredients.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Good quality smoked salmon slices	60-80g
Brown bread, thinly sliced	1-2 slices
Unsalted butter, softened	A generous amount
Lemon wedge	1
Black pepper, freshly ground	A grind
Capers (optional)	A few
Fresh dill or watercress to serve	A little

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Remove the smoked salmon from the fridge 5 minutes before serving.
- Butter the brown bread generously. Remove crusts if preferred. Cut into small triangles.
- Drape the salmon loosely over one side of the plate. It should look relaxed, not flat.
- Arrange the bread alongside. Add lemon, black pepper, and capers or dill.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 fatty acids: smoked salmon is one of the richest sources, supporting brain and heart health.
- Protein: complete and easily absorbed.
- Vitamin D: one of the best dietary sources.
- Vitamin B12: critical for neurological function.
- Calcium from the bread.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: omega-3 fatty acids from salmon are strongly cardioprotective.
- Dementia: omega-3 DHA from oily fish is consistently associated with reduced cognitive decline.
- Bone health: vitamin D from the salmon and calcium from the bread both contribute.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Smoked salmon is naturally soft and tender.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut into very small pieces under 1.5cm. Serve on soft bread without crusts.
5	Minced and moist	Finely chop the salmon and mix with softened butter and lemon juice to a moist mixture.
4	Puréed	Blend with cream cheese and lemon juice until completely smooth. Thin with a little cream if needed.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Smoked salmon has been a marker of occasion and generosity in British life for generations. Serving it on a weekday, unexpectedly, as a small act of generosity, is particularly effective at lifting a client's day.

Presentation tip

White plate. Salmon draped loosely, bread triangles neatly arranged, lemon wedge, a small amount of greenery. Simplicity.

Watch out for

Very high in sodium: limit for clients with hypertension, heart failure, or CKD. Buy the best quality available.

Make it easier

No cooking required. 5 minutes preparation. An ideal option when time is very short.



Chapter 10

Fish

From the simple to the celebratory

Pan-Fried Salmon with Lemon Butter

Fish | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 12 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Dementia

Bone health

Diabetes

ABOUT THIS DISH

A perfectly pan-fried salmon fillet with a simple lemon butter sauce is one of the finest quick fish dishes in British cooking. The key is a very hot pan, dry fish, and the confidence to leave it alone while it cooks. The skin should be golden and crisp, the flesh just cooked through with the faintest trace of pink at the centre. The lemon butter takes seconds and transforms the dish.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Salmon fillet, skin on, pin-boned	130-150g
Unsalted butter	20g
Olive oil	1 tbsp
Lemon, juiced	Half
Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped	1 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Remove the salmon from the fridge 10 minutes before cooking. Pat completely dry with kitchen paper.

- Season the flesh side generously. Heat a pan over a high heat until very hot. Add the olive oil.
- Place the salmon skin-side down. Press gently for 30 seconds. Do not move it. Cook for 5-6 minutes until the skin is deeply golden and the flesh has turned opaque two-thirds of the way up.
- Flip carefully. Cook for 1-2 further minutes. Remove and rest on a warm plate.
- Reduce heat. Add the butter to the same pan, allow to foam and turn golden. Add the lemon juice, swirl, and add the parsley.
- Pour the lemon butter over the resting salmon. Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 fatty acids: salmon is one of the richest sources. DHA and EPA support brain, heart, and reduce inflammation.
- Vitamin D: salmon provides more per serving than almost any other food.
- Protein: complete and highly bioavailable.
- Vitamin B12 and B6: important for neurological function.
- Selenium: an important antioxidant mineral.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: one of the most evidence-based dietary choices for cardiovascular health.
- Dementia: regular oily fish consistently associated with reduced cognitive decline.
- Bone health: vitamin D content supports calcium absorption and bone density.
- Diabetes: very low carbohydrate with minimal blood sugar impact.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with crisp skin. Ensure all pin bones removed.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Remove the skin. Flake into small pieces under 1.5cm. Moisten with lemon butter.
5	Minced and moist	Flake finely and mix with lemon butter until cohesive and moist. All pieces under 4mm.
4	Puréed	Blend with lemon butter and a little cream until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Pan-fried salmon became fashionable in Britain from the 1980s as fresh salmon became widely available. Many clients will have eaten it regularly in good restaurants or cooked it themselves.

Presentation tip

Serve skin-side up so the golden skin remains crisp. Lemon butter poured over. A lemon wedge on the side, a few new potatoes, and some wilted spinach.

Watch out for

Check carefully for pin bones before cooking. The lemon butter spatters when juice hits the hot butter: stand back slightly.

Make it easier

The lemon butter can be made ahead and kept in the fridge. Reheat gently before serving.

Baked Cod with Parsley Sauce

Fish | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Kidney friendly

Diabetes

ABOUT THIS DISH

Baked cod with parsley sauce is one of the most traditional and enduring British fish dishes, appearing in cookery books from the Victorian era and remaining on family tables throughout the twentieth century. It is gentle, nutritious, and deeply familiar. The parsley sauce, a simple bechamel with fresh parsley, is one of the classic British sauces and transforms a piece of white fish into something complete and satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cod fillet, skinless and pin-boned	130-150g
Unsalted butter	10g
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Unsalted butter (for sauce)	20g
Plain flour	20g
Full-fat milk	200ml
Fresh flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped	2 tbsp
Salt, white pepper and nutmeg	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 180°C / 160°C fan / Gas 4.

- Place the cod in a small ovenproof dish. Dot with butter, season lightly. Cover with foil.
- Bake for 15-18 minutes until just opaque throughout and flaking easily. Do not overcook.
- Make the sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes stirring. Add the milk gradually, stirring constantly. Bring to a simmer until the sauce thickens and coats the back of a spoon, about 5-6 minutes.
- Remove from heat. Stir in the parsley and season with salt, white pepper, and nutmeg.
- Serve the cod with the parsley sauce poured over.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Protein from the cod: very lean, complete protein. Excellent for clients who need protein without additional fat. • Iodine: white fish is one of the richest dietary sources, important for thyroid function. • Calcium from the milk in the sauce. • B vitamins including B6 and B12. • Phosphorus: supports bone health.	• Heart health: cod is very low in saturated fat. A genuinely heart-friendly dish. • Kidney friendly: white fish like cod is lower in potassium and phosphorus than oily fish. Always check the care plan for specific restrictions. • Diabetes: high protein, very low carbohydrate from the fish.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with parsley sauce poured over.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cod is naturally flaky. Ensure all pieces under 1.5cm and well-moistened with the sauce.
5	Minced and moist	Flake the cod very finely and mix thoroughly with the parsley sauce until cohesive throughout.
4	Puréed	Blend the flaked cod with the parsley sauce and extra milk until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Baked cod with parsley sauce is one of the most universally recognised British fish dishes of the twentieth century. Associated strongly with school dinners, hospital meals, and home cooking of a certain era. Comforting precisely because it is so familiar.
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Presentation tip

The parsley sauce should be vivid green-flecked white. Pour generously. Boiled new potatoes and buttered peas alongside.

Watch out for

Cod overcooks quickly. Check at 15 minutes. Check carefully for pin bones. The parsley sauce must be well-seasoned.

Make it easier

The parsley sauce can be made ahead and reheated gently with a splash of extra milk. Good-quality frozen cod works perfectly.

Fish Pie

Fish | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 25 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Fish pie is one of the great British comfort dishes: creamy, warming, and deeply satisfying, with a golden mashed potato crust concealing a filling of tender fish in a rich sauce. It appears in British cookery books from the Victorian era and has remained a household staple ever since. It is also one of the most adaptable dishes in this book.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cod or haddock fillet, skinless	100g
Smoked haddock fillet, skinless	60g
Raw king prawns, peeled (optional)	40g
Full-fat milk	250ml
Bay leaf	1
Unsalted butter	25g
Plain flour	25g
Double cream	2 tbsp
Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped	1 tbsp
Salt, white pepper and nutmeg	To taste
Maris Piper potatoes, peeled	250g
Butter and milk for mash	25g butter, 2 tbsp milk

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Place the fish in a saucepan with the milk and bay leaf. Bring to a gentle simmer and poach for 5 minutes. Remove the fish and reserve the milk. Discard the bay leaf.
- Make the sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes. Add the reserved milk gradually until a smooth sauce forms. Simmer for 5 minutes. Stir in the cream and parsley. Season well.
- Flake the cooked fish into large pieces, checking carefully for bones. Add to the sauce with the prawns if using. Pour into an ovenproof dish.
- Cook the potatoes until tender. Drain and mash with butter and milk until smooth. Season well.
- Spoon the mash over the fish filling, spreading evenly and creating a ridged surface with a fork.
- Bake for 25-30 minutes until golden and bubbling. Rest for 5 minutes before serving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Protein from multiple fish sources: white fish and smoked fish together provide excellent complete protein. • Calcium and vitamin D from the milk and fish. • Iodine: white fish and smoked fish are excellent sources. • Significant calories from the cream, butter, and mash: excellent for clients needing enrichment.	• Bone health: milk, cream, and fish all contribute calcium and vitamin D. • Heart health: use less cream and butter for clients with cardiovascular concerns. • Appetite: one of the most comforting and well-received dishes in elderly care.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Ensure all fish bones removed before baking.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure all fish flaked to small pieces under 1.5cm. The mash and sauce keep everything moist.
5	Minced and moist	Blend or finely chop all fish to very small pieces under 4mm. Mix with extra sauce.
4	Puréed	Blend the filling with extra sauce until completely smooth. Blend the mash separately. Pass each through a sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Fish pie is a dish of almost universal nostalgic warmth in Britain. Associated with family Sunday lunches and school term-time suppers. Many clients will say it is one of their favourite dishes.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was baked in. The golden mash surface should arrive intact.

Watch out for

Check very carefully for pin bones before adding fish to the sauce. Smoked haddock is high in sodium: use sparingly for hypertensive clients.

Make it easier

The filling can be made a day ahead and kept in the fridge. Top with mash and bake when needed. Freezes well in individual portions.

Kedgeree

Fish | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

Diabetes

ABOUT THIS DISH

Kedgeree is the great Anglo-Indian breakfast dish: flaked smoked haddock, basmati rice, soft-boiled eggs, butter, and a gentle warmth of curry spice. It appears in British cookery books from the mid-nineteenth century and was a fixture of the Victorian breakfast sideboard. It is one of the most distinctively British dishes in existence.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Smoked haddock fillet, undyed	150g
Basmati rice	75g
Full-fat milk	200ml
Unsalted butter	25g
Onion, finely diced	Half a small onion
Mild curry powder	1 tsp
Ground turmeric	0.5 tsp
Eggs, softly boiled and halved	2 eggs
Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped	1 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Lemon wedge to serve	1

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Poach the smoked haddock in the milk with a bay leaf for 8-10 minutes. Remove, reserving the milk. Flake carefully, removing all skin and bones.
- Cook the rice in salted water until just tender. Drain.
- Melt the butter in a large pan. Cook the onion gently for 6-8 minutes. Add the curry powder and turmeric, cook for 2 minutes.
- Add the drained rice and stir to coat. Add a few tablespoons of the reserved poaching milk to loosen.
- Fold in the flaked haddock gently. Taste and season carefully.
- Serve topped with the soft-boiled egg halves, parsley, and a wedge of lemon.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Protein from both the fish and the eggs: complete and highly bioavailable. • Iodine from the smoked haddock: one of the richest dietary sources. • Turmeric: contains curcumin, a powerful anti-inflammatory compound. • B vitamins from the eggs and fish. • Carbohydrate from the rice: sustained energy release.	• Dementia: kedgerree is one of the most culturally distinctive British dishes, carrying very strong associations for clients of certain backgrounds. • Appetite: the combination of warm spice, creamy fish, and soft egg is deeply comforting. • Diabetes: basmati rice has a lower glycaemic index than other varieties.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Ensure all skin and bones removed.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Flake the haddock very finely. Ensure rice is very soft. Cut egg into very small pieces. Moisten with extra poaching milk.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Kedgerree occupies a unique place in British culinary history. For clients from certain backgrounds it is strongly associated with weekend breakfasts and country house visits. The smell of the curry spice warming in the butter is itself evocative.	Presentation tip
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Serve in a wide, shallow bowl. Yellow turmeric-stained rice, white flakes of fish, golden egg halves. A wedge of lemon and a scattering of green herb.

Watch out for

Smoked haddock is high in sodium: use undyed where possible. Check very carefully for bones.

Make it easier

The rice can be cooked ahead. The whole dish comes together in under 30 minutes.

Sardines on Toast

Fish | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Bone health

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Sardines on toast is one of the simplest and most nutritionally valuable dishes a carer can make. Tinned sardines are extraordinarily rich in omega-3 fatty acids, calcium from the edible bones, vitamin D, and protein. A single tin packs more nutritional value than many far more complicated dishes. Many clients will have eaten them regularly throughout their lives.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Tinned sardines in olive oil, drained	1 tin (120g)
Thick-cut white or brown bread	1-2 slices
Unsalted butter	A little
Lemon juice	A squeeze
Worcestershire sauce	A dash
Black pepper	A grind
Flat-leaf parsley or watercress to serve	A little

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Toast the bread and butter it while still hot.
- Drain the sardines and lay them on the toast. Press gently with a fork.
- Add a squeeze of lemon juice, a dash of Worcestershire sauce, and a grind of black pepper.

- Serve immediately with parsley or watercress alongside.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 fatty acids: tinned sardines are among the very richest dietary sources of EPA and DHA.
- Calcium: the soft, edible bones provide more calcium per serving than a glass of milk.
- Vitamin D: one of the best dietary sources available.
- Protein: complete and very easily absorbed.
- Vitamin B12: extremely high content.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: sardines are one of the most cardioprotective foods available.
- Bone health: calcium from the sardine bones, combined with vitamin D, makes this one of the best bone-health dishes in the book.
- Dementia: regular oily fish consistently associated with reduced cognitive decline. The high B12 content also supports neurological function.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made on toast.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Mash the sardines with a fork and serve on soft bread without crusts, moistened with olive oil and lemon juice.
5	Minced and moist	Mash thoroughly until no large pieces remain. Mix with lemon juice and olive oil. Serve on very soft bread.
4	Puréed	Blend with cream cheese and lemon juice until completely smooth. Thin with olive oil. Serve on puréed bread.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Tinned sardines on toast is associated with a very British tradition of simple, honest larder cooking. Many clients will have eaten it regularly for lunch throughout their lives.

Presentation tip

Two sardines laid neatly on buttered toast, a squeeze of lemon, a grind of pepper, a few leaves of watercress. Simple and honest.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. Sardines in oil are high in sodium: use sardines in spring water for clients with hypertension.

Make it easier

Keep tinned sardines in the store cupboard at all times. They have a long shelf life and provide instant nutritional value.

Fishcakes with Tartare Sauce

Fish | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A good fishcake is one of the great pleasures of British cookery: crisp on the outside, yielding within. They have been made in British kitchens since at least the eighteenth century and are associated with careful, resourceful home cooking. The tartare sauce alongside is simple to make and far superior to the bottled variety.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooked white fish (cod or haddock), flaked	150g
Mashed potato, well-seasoned	150g
Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped	1 tbsp
Lemon zest	Half a lemon
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Plain flour for dusting	2 tbsp
Egg, beaten	1 egg
Breadcrumbs (optional)	3 tbsp
Olive oil for frying	2 tbsp
Good mayonnaise (for tartare)	3 tbsp
Capers, chopped	1 tsp
Gherkins, finely diced	1 tsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the tartare sauce: mix the mayonnaise with the capers, gherkins, and lemon juice. Refrigerate until needed.
- Combine the flaked fish, mashed potato, parsley, and lemon zest. Season well.
- Divide into two portions and shape into round patties about 2cm thick. Dust with flour, dip in beaten egg, coat in breadcrumbs if using.
- Refrigerate for 15 minutes to help them hold together.
- Heat olive oil in a non-stick pan over a medium heat. Cook the fishcakes for 4-5 minutes on each side until deeply golden.
- Drain on kitchen paper. Serve with the tartare sauce and a wedge of lemon.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the fish and egg: complete and highly bioavailable.
- Iodine from the white fish: supports thyroid function.
- Potassium from the potato: supports heart health.
- Vitamin C from the parsley.
- Healthy fats from the olive oil and mayonnaise.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: white fish is very low in saturated fat. The olive oil used for cooking adds heart-healthy monounsaturated fat.
- Appetite: the crisp exterior and yielding interior, combined with the tangy tartare sauce, make fishcakes one of the most palatable dishes in the fish chapter.
- Dementia: fishcakes are strongly associated with British home cooking and school dinners.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with tartare sauce.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure the fishcake is cooked through and soft inside. Cut into small pieces and moisten with extra tartare sauce.
5	Minced and moist	Make without the breadcrumb coating. Cook gently in butter. Serve in soft moist pieces with plenty of tartare sauce.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Fishcakes are one of the most universally recognised British dishes across all social backgrounds, associated with school dinners, Friday lunch, and resourceful home cooking.

Presentation tip

Two golden fishcakes on a warm plate, a spoonful of tartare sauce alongside, a wedge of lemon, and some watercress.

Watch out for

Check very carefully for fish bones before combining with mashed potato. Refrigerate before frying or they will fall apart.

Make it easier

Make a larger batch and freeze uncooked between sheets of baking paper. Cook from frozen at 180°C for 25-30 minutes.

Smoked Haddock with Poached Egg

Fish | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Smoked haddock with a poached egg is one of the most satisfying and complete quick dishes in British cooking. The combination of gently poached smoked fish, a perfectly poached egg with a running yolk, is both elegant and deeply nourishing. A staple of the Victorian and Edwardian breakfast table.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Smoked haddock fillet, undyed, skinless	130-150g
Full-fat milk	200ml
Bay leaf	1
Egg, very fresh	1 egg
White wine vinegar	1 tsp
Unsalted butter	15g
Baby spinach (optional)	A handful
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Fresh chives to serve	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Poach the smoked haddock in the milk with the bay leaf for 8-10 minutes until just cooked. Remove and keep warm.
- Bring a medium saucepan of water to a gentle simmer. Add the vinegar. Crack the egg into a small cup.
- Create a gentle swirl. Slide the egg in. Poach for 3-4 minutes until the white is just set and the yolk remains runny.
- If using spinach, wilt briefly in the butter. Season.
- Place the haddock on a warmed plate, on the wilted spinach if using. Top with the poached egg. Season with white pepper and chives.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein from both the fish and egg.
- Iodine: smoked haddock and eggs are both excellent sources.
- Vitamin D: one of the best dietary combinations for this vitamin.
- Choline from the egg yolk: critical for brain health.
- Omega-3 from the haddock.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: low-saturated-fat dish. Omega-3 from the haddock and choline from the egg both contribute to cardiovascular health.
- Bone health: vitamin D from both fish and egg, with calcium from the milk, makes this an excellent bone-health dish.
- Appetite: the running yolk when broken over the fish provides both visual pleasure and a natural sauce.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. The running yolk naturally sauces the fish.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Flake the haddock into small pieces. Chop the egg white small. Allow the yolk to run over everything.
5	Minced and moist	Finely flake the haddock. Scramble the egg softly. Combine with a little cream.
4	Puréed	Blend the poached haddock with the scrambled egg and a little cream until completely smooth.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Smoked haddock with poached egg was a fixture of the Victorian and Edwardian breakfast sideboard. For clients who stayed in good hotels or who breakfasted seriously, it carries a strong association with quality and comfort.

Presentation tip

Poached egg placed carefully on top of white, flaked haddock. A few snipped chives, a grind of white pepper, and nothing else.

Watch out for

Smoked haddock varies significantly in saltiness: undyed is milder and preferable. Eggs must be very fresh for poaching.

Make it easier

The haddock poaches in 10 minutes and can be kept warm in its milk. The egg takes 4 minutes. An ideal weekday lunch.

Prawn Bisque

Fish | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Hard

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Heart health



Contains crustaceans: check for shellfish allergy before serving.

ABOUT THIS DISH

Prawn bisque is a dish of the highest culinary ambition: a rich, deeply flavoured soup made from the shells of prawns, thickened with cream and finished with brandy. A feature of the best British hotel menus throughout the twentieth century. Technically more demanding than most soups but the result is extraordinary.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Raw shell-on prawns, or prawn shells	300g
Unsalted butter	30g
Shallots, finely diced	2
Carrot, finely diced	1 small
Celery stick, finely diced	1 stick
Garlic cloves, crushed	2 cloves
Tomato puree	1 tbsp
Brandy	2 tbsp
Fish or chicken stock	500ml
Double cream	100ml
Cayenne pepper	A pinch
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- If using whole shell-on prawns, peel and set the meat aside. Reserve all shells and heads.
- Melt the butter in a large saucepan over a high heat. Add the prawn shells and heads. Cook for 5-6 minutes until the shells have turned deep pink and are beginning to caramelise. This step is essential.
- Add the shallot, carrot, celery, and garlic. Cook for 5 minutes until softened.
- Add the tomato puree. Add the brandy and allow to bubble for 1 minute. Add the stock. Simmer for 25 minutes.
- Strain through a fine sieve, pressing firmly on the shells. Discard the solids.
- Return to the pan. Add the cream and cayenne. Simmer gently for 5 minutes. Season carefully.
- If using reserved prawn meat, add and warm through for 2 minutes before serving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Protein from the prawns: lean and complete. • Iodine: shellfish are among the richest sources. • Zinc and selenium from the prawns: support immune function. • Significant calories from the cream and butter.	Good for these conditions • Appetite: the richness and depth of a proper bisque is extraordinarily effective at stimulating appetite. • Dementia: prawn bisque is associated with the finest end of British dining: hotel restaurants and celebration lunches. • Heart health: prawns are low in saturated fat. The cream content is significant: use a lighter hand for clients with cardiovascular concerns.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	The bisque is naturally smooth when strained. This is a naturally IDDSI 4 dish when made correctly.
5	Minced and moist	Add finely chopped prawn meat (under 4mm) to the smooth bisque.
7	Regular	Serve smooth with a few small prawns floating in the centre. A swirl of cream and a pinch of cayenne.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Prawn bisque represents the pinnacle of a certain kind of British formal dining. For clients who ate in good restaurants throughout their lives, it carries associations of real occasion.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed white bowl. A small swirl of cream, a pinch of cayenne, perhaps a single small prawn in the centre. The deep terracotta colour is beautiful.

Watch out for

Do not rush the shell caramelisation step. Contains shellfish: always check for allergy. High in sodium from the shellfish.

Make it easier

Can be made a day ahead up to the point of adding the cream. Refrigerate and finish with cream when reheating.

Grilled Dover Sole with Lemon

Fish | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Kidney friendly

Diabetes

ABOUT THIS DISH

Dover sole is the most prized of all British flatfish: tender, delicate, and of a mild sweetness that no other fish can match. Grilled simply with butter and lemon, it is a dish of absolute distinction requiring minimal intervention. It was the fish of choice in the grandest British restaurants for most of the twentieth century.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Dover sole, on the bone, skin scored	<i>1 whole (approximately 300-350g)</i>
Unsalted butter, melted	<i>30g</i>
Salt and white pepper	<i>To taste</i>
Lemon, halved	<i>1</i>
Flat-leaf parsley, chopped	<i>1 tbsp</i>
Capers (optional)	<i>1 tsp</i>

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Preheat the grill to its highest setting.

- Score the skin diagonally. Brush generously on both sides with melted butter. Season.
- Grill for 4-5 minutes on the first side until the skin is golden.
- Turn carefully. Brush again with butter. Grill for a further 3-4 minutes until the flesh can be lifted easily from the bone.
- Transfer to a warm plate. Squeeze half the lemon over, scatter with parsley and capers if using. Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Lean protein: Dover sole is exceptionally lean white fish, very high in protein and very low in fat.
- Iodine: white fish is one of the best dietary sources.
- Phosphorus and selenium: important for bone and immune health.
- Vitamin B12 and B6.
- The butter provides fat-soluble vitamins and calories.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: one of the leanest fish dishes in the book.
- Kidney friendly: Dover sole is low in potassium and phosphorus relative to other fish. Always confirm with the care plan.
- Diabetes: very high protein, very low carbohydrate.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve on the bone, or fillet at the table before serving.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Fillet completely before serving. Cut the tender flesh into small pieces under 1.5cm. Moisten with extra lemon butter.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Dover sole at its best is associated with the grandest British dining: Rules, The Savoy Grill, a proper seaside restaurant. For clients who ate in these places, serving Dover sole at home is an act of real generosity.

Presentation tip

Serve whole on an oval plate if you have one. The golden skin, the butter pooling, the wedge of lemon.

Watch out for

Dover sole must be served immediately: it deteriorates quickly. Ensure the client is aware there are bones before serving.

Make it easier

The sole itself requires no preparation beyond scoring and buttering. 10 minutes cooking. One of the quickest dishes despite its sophistication.

Haddock and Spinach Gratin

Fish | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 25 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Heart health

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

A gratin of haddock and spinach in a creamy cheese sauce, golden and bubbling from the oven, combines the nutritional power of white fish, iron-rich spinach, and calcium-rich dairy in a single bake. It is warming, elegant, and entirely manageable for clients with most dietary needs.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Haddock fillet, skinless	130-150g
Baby spinach, washed	80g
Unsalted butter	20g
Plain flour	20g
Full-fat milk	200ml
Mature cheddar or gruyere, grated	40g
Dijon mustard	0.5 tsp
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Breadcrumbs for topping (optional)	1 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Wilt the spinach in a pan with a tiny knob of butter for 1-2 minutes. Squeeze out thoroughly. Chop roughly and season.
- Make the cheese sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes. Add the milk gradually, stirring. Simmer until thick. Off the heat, stir in most of the cheese, mustard, and nutmeg. Season well.
- Spread the wilted spinach in the base of a small ovenproof dish. Lay the haddock on top. Pour the cheese sauce over.
- Scatter remaining cheese and breadcrumbs if using over the surface.
- Bake for 20-25 minutes until golden, bubbling, and the haddock is just cooked through.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Iron from the spinach: one of the best plant sources. Vitamin C in the spinach enhances absorption. • Vitamin K from the spinach: important for bone health. • Calcium from the milk and cheese: strongly supports bone density. • Protein from both the fish and dairy. • Vitamin D from the haddock.	Good for these conditions • Bone health: calcium from the cheese sauce and vitamin D from the haddock makes this one of the best bone-health dishes. • Heart health: haddock is very lean. Use a lighter cheese sauce for clients with elevated cholesterol. • Cancer support: spinach is rich in folate, vitamins C and K, and antioxidant compounds.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure all fish is flaked into small pieces under 1.5cm. Chop the spinach very finely.
5	Minced and moist	Flake the haddock very finely and chop the spinach to very small pieces. Mix with extra sauce.
4	Puréed	Blend all components with the sauce until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Fish gratin in various forms has been part of British cookery since the Victorian era when French culinary influences introduced the technique. The combination of golden cheese crust and creamy fish beneath is universally appealing.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was baked in. The golden cheese crust should arrive intact.

Watch out for

Check carefully for pin bones before baking. Squeeze the spinach very thoroughly or the dish will be watery.

Make it easier

The cheese sauce and wilted spinach can be prepared ahead. The whole dish can be assembled the day before, refrigerated, and baked from cold.

Tuna Pasta Bake

Fish | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Tuna pasta bake became one of the most popular family dishes in Britain from the 1970s onwards, combining the convenience of tinned tuna with the comfort of pasta in a creamy sauce. Not a grand dish but a genuinely good one when made with care: well-seasoned, properly sauced, and finished with a golden cheese crust.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Dried pasta (penne or rigatoni)	100g
Tinned tuna in spring water, drained	1 x 145g tin
Tinned sweetcorn, drained	3 tbsp
Unsalted butter	20g
Plain flour	20g
Full-fat milk	300ml
Mature cheddar, grated	50g
Dijon mustard	0.5 tsp
Salt, white pepper and nutmeg	To taste
Cherry tomatoes, halved (optional)	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Cook the pasta in well-salted boiling water until al dente, 1-2 minutes less than the packet suggests. Drain.
- Make the cheese sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes. Add the milk gradually until smooth and thick. Off the heat, stir in most of the cheese and the mustard. Season.
- Combine the pasta, tuna, and sweetcorn. Pour the sauce over and mix gently. Transfer to an ovenproof dish.
- Scatter remaining cheese and tomatoes over the top.
- Bake for 20-25 minutes until golden and bubbling.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Protein from the tuna: very lean and complete. • Omega-3 fatty acids: tinned tuna contains useful quantities supporting heart and brain health. • Calcium from the cheese and milk sauce. • Carbohydrate from the pasta: sustained energy. • Iodine from the tuna.	• Heart health: tuna is a lean, omega-3-rich fish. • Appetite: substantial, warming, and familiar. One of the most reliably well-received dishes for clients who find lighter food insufficient. • Cancer support: tuna, tomatoes, and cheese together provide protein, lycopene, and calcium.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use a small pasta shape. Ensure pasta is very well cooked. The sauce keeps everything moist.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Tuna pasta bake is associated with a certain era of British family cooking: the 1970s and 80s when convenience and home cooking combined. Many clients will have made it themselves.
Presentation tip Serve in the dish it was baked in. The golden cheese crust is the visual centrepiece.

Watch out for

Use tuna in spring water rather than brine to reduce sodium. The pasta must not be overcooked before baking or it will become mushy.

Make it easier

Can be assembled ahead and refrigerated. Leftovers reheat well with a splash of milk.



Chapter 11

Meat

Roasts, stews, and the great British classics

Shepherd's Pie

Meat | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 55 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Diabetes

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Shepherd's pie has been at the heart of British home cooking since at least the 1870s, born from the practical tradition of stretching leftover roast lamb with a golden mashed potato crust. For most clients aged 75 and over, this dish will carry the warmth of a Sunday kitchen, a mother's cooking, or a school dinner remembered fondly. Unlike cottage pie, which uses beef, shepherd's pie is always made with lamb. This is a distinction many older clients will know and care about.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Minced lamb (20% fat for flavour)	150g
Brown onion, finely diced	1 small
Carrot, finely diced	1 medium
Celery, finely diced	1 stick
Garlic clove, crushed	1 clove
Tomato puree	1 tbsp
Worcestershire sauce	1 tsp
Beef or lamb stock	150ml
Fresh rosemary, finely chopped	1 sprig
Fresh thyme leaves	3-4 sprigs
Plain flour	1 tsp
Olive oil	1 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Maris Piper potatoes, peeled	200g
Unsalted butter	25g
Whole milk or double cream	2-3 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Peel and quarter the potatoes. Place in cold salted water, bring to the boil, simmer for 18-20 minutes until completely tender. Drain and steam-dry.
- Heat the olive oil in a heavy pan over medium heat. Add the onion, carrot, and celery with a pinch of salt. Cook gently for 8-10 minutes until softened.
- Add the garlic and cook for 1 minute. Add the minced lamb and cook over higher heat until browned, around 6-8 minutes. Drain off excess fat.
- Stir in the tomato puree and flour. Cook for 2 minutes. Add the Worcestershire sauce, herbs, and stock. Simmer uncovered for 15-20 minutes until the sauce has thickened. Season well.
- Mash the potatoes with the butter and cream until smooth and rich. Season well.
- Transfer the filling to an ovenproof dish. Spoon the mash over and spread to the edges. Fork the surface to create ridges.
- Bake for 25-30 minutes until golden and bubbling. Rest for 5 minutes before serving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the lamb: essential for muscle maintenance and wound healing.
- Haem iron: lamb is a rich source, more readily absorbed than plant-based iron.
- Zinc: supports immune function and wound healing.
- Vitamin B12: critical for neurological health.
- Calcium and vitamin D from the dairy in the mash.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: calorie-dense with fat from the lamb and butter. One of the most reliably eaten dishes in elderly care.
- Diabetes: use a smaller potato portion and increase the vegetable content for clients managing blood sugar.
- Dementia: one of the most powerfully nostalgic dishes in the book. The smell of lamb and onion cooking is a strong positive sensory trigger.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked.

6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut into small spoonfuls under 1.5cm. Check carrots are fully tender.
5	Minced and moist	Remove the mash crust. Finely mince the filling. Combine with mash and extra stock until cohesive and moist.
4	Puréed	Blend filling and mash together with warm stock or cream until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Shepherd's pie is likely one of the most familiar dishes of your client's life. Mention it in the morning; the anticipation is itself a pleasure. Ask the client how their mother used to make it.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was cooked in. A small knob of butter melting into the mash at the last moment signals care.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies: check for allergies. High in potassium from the potato: reduce for clients with CKD. Rest at least 5 minutes before serving.

Make it easier

The filling freezes well. Make a large batch and freeze. Defrost overnight, top with fresh mash, and bake.

Roast Chicken with Gravy

Meat | Serves 2-3 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 1 hr 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

A well-roasted chicken is one of the most important things a carer can cook. It is the centrepiece of the British Sunday table, the source of leftovers for several days, and the stock for the week's soups. Few smells are as universally comforting as a chicken roasting in the oven, and few dishes produce as consistent a response of pleasure and gratitude.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Free-range chicken (whole)	1.2-1.5kg
Unsalted butter, softened	40g
Lemon, halved	1
Garlic bulb, halved	1 bulb
Fresh thyme and rosemary	Several sprigs
Olive oil	1 tbsp
Salt and black pepper	Generous seasoning
Chicken stock (for gravy)	300ml
Plain flour (for gravy)	1 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 220°C / 200°C fan / Gas 7.

- Remove the chicken from the fridge 30 minutes before cooking. Pat completely dry with kitchen paper.
- Rub softened butter all over the skin and underneath. Season very generously. Stuff the cavity with the lemon halves, half the garlic, and the herbs.
- Place in a roasting tin. Drizzle with olive oil. Roast at 220°C for 15 minutes, then reduce to 180°C for 50-60 minutes, basting once or twice. Done when juices run clear when the thigh is pierced.
- Rest the chicken, tented with foil, for at least 20 minutes.
- Make the gravy: pour off most of the fat from the tin, leaving dark juices. Add flour, cook over medium heat scraping up caramelised bits. Add the stock gradually. Simmer until glossy. Season and strain.
- Carve and serve with the gravy poured over.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein: all essential amino acids.
- B vitamins, particularly niacin and B6: support energy metabolism.
- Selenium and zinc: important for immune function.
- Iron: particularly in the darker thigh meat.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the smell of a roasting chicken is one of the most powerful appetite stimulants. Cook with enough time for the aroma to fill the house before lunch.
- Dementia: the Sunday roast chicken is perhaps the single most powerful nostalgic dish in British culture.
- Cancer support: complete protein supports tissue repair.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve carved, with gravy. Offer both breast and thigh meat: thigh is more tender.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use thigh meat only. Cut into small pieces under 1.5cm. Moisten generously with gravy.
5	Minced and moist	Finely shred thigh meat. Mix thoroughly with gravy until very moist and cohesive.
4	Puréed	Blend thigh meat with warm gravy until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

A roast chicken on a Sunday is one of the most powerful memories in British domestic life. If possible, eat with the client or sit with them during the meal. The occasion matters as much as the food.

Presentation tip

Bring the chicken to the table whole if possible, even if to be carved immediately. The visual of a whole golden bird is one of the most appetising in cooking.

Watch out for

The chicken must be cooked through: juices must run completely clear. Use a probe thermometer: 75°C at the thickest part of the thigh. Rest fully before carving.

Make it easier

A roast chicken produces leftovers for 2-3 further meals. Keep the carcass for stock.

Beef Stew and Dumplings

Meat | Serves 2 | Autumn and winter

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 25 mins | Cook 2 hrs 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Bone health

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Beef stew and suet dumplings is a dish of the highest comfort: slow-cooked beef in a rich dark gravy with tender vegetables and pillowy dumplings absorbing every drop of flavour. It is one of the most ancient forms of British cookery. The dumplings in particular carry extraordinary nostalgic resonance.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Braising or shin beef, cut into 3-4cm cubes	200g
Brown onion, diced	1 medium
Carrots, diced	2 medium
Celery sticks, diced	2 sticks
Swede, diced	100g
Garlic cloves, crushed	2 cloves
Plain flour	2 tbsp
Tomato puree	1 tbsp
Beef stock	400ml
Bay leaves and thyme	2 bay leaves, 4 sprigs
Self-raising flour (for dumplings)	100g
Shredded suet	50g
Water (for dumplings)	75ml approximately

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Season the beef. Brown in batches in a heavy casserole over high heat until deeply caramelised. Remove and set aside.
- Cook the onion, carrot, celery, and swede for 8-10 minutes. Add the garlic and tomato puree.
- Return the beef. Add the flour and stir. Add the stock, bay leaves, and thyme. Bring to a simmer.
- Cover and cook in the oven at 160°C / 140°C fan for 1 hour 30 minutes to 2 hours until the beef is completely tender.
- Make dumplings: combine self-raising flour, suet, and a pinch of salt. Add cold water to form a soft, slightly sticky dough. Roll into small balls.
- Remove the lid from the stew. Place dumplings on the surface. Return to the oven uncovered for 20-25 minutes until puffed and golden.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Protein from the beef: complete and excellent for muscle maintenance. • Collagen from the slow-cooked shin beef: supports joint health. • Iron and zinc from the beef. • Fibre and vitamin C from the vegetables.	Good for these conditions • Appetite: one of the most satisfying and substantial dishes in the book. Tends to be eaten completely. • Bone health: collagen from the slow-cooked beef supports joint and bone health. • Dementia: beef stew and dumplings is associated with the deepest level of domestic comfort.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Shin beef becomes very tender after long cooking.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure beef is completely tender. Cut into pieces under 1.5cm. Serve a dampened dumpling rather than a crisp-topped one.
5	Minced and moist	Break beef into very fine shreds. Finely chop vegetables. Mix with gravy. Skip the dumplings.
4	Puréed	Blend stew filling and gravy until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Beef stew and dumplings is one of the great winter dishes of British domestic life. The dumplings carry an almost universal nostalgic resonance. Ask the client about their parent or grandparent's version.

Presentation tip

Serve in a deep bowl with dumplings placed on top, clearly visible. A sprig of thyme and a generous ladle of gravy.

Watch out for

The beef must be browned in batches: crowding the pan causes steaming rather than searing. The dumplings must not be stirred once added.

Make it easier

An ideal slow cooker dish. Brown on the hob, transfer to slow cooker for 6-8 hours on low. Add dumplings for the final 30 minutes on high.

Liver and Bacon with Onion Gravy

Meat | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Liver and bacon with onion gravy is one of the most nutritionally powerful and nostalgically resonant dishes in British cooking. It was a staple of British home cooking throughout the mid-twentieth century. Its nutritional credentials are extraordinary. It has fallen out of fashion entirely, which is a nutritional mistake.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Calf's liver or lamb's liver, sliced 1cm thick	120-150g
Streaky bacon rashers	2 rashers
Brown onions, thinly sliced	2 medium
Unsalted butter	20g
Plain flour	1 tbsp
Beef stock	200ml
Fresh thyme	2 sprigs
Salt and black pepper	To taste
Olive oil	1 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the onion gravy first: melt the butter in a wide saucepan. Add the onions with a pinch of salt. Cook very slowly for 20-25 minutes until deeply golden and sweet.
- Add the flour, stir well, and cook for 2 minutes. Add the stock and thyme. Simmer for 10 minutes until the gravy has reduced to a glossy consistency. Season well.
- Season the liver. Heat a frying pan over high heat with a little oil. Cook the bacon for 2-3 minutes until golden. Remove and keep warm.
- In the same pan, cook the liver for 1.5-2 minutes on each side. It should be browned outside and just slightly pink within. Do not overcook.
- Serve the liver topped with the bacon and onion gravy poured over.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Iron: the single richest dietary source. A single serving provides more than the daily requirement.
- Vitamin A: liver is the most concentrated food source.
- Vitamin B12: extraordinarily rich.
- Folate: exceptionally high content.
- Zinc and copper: important for immune function and wound healing.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the rich savoury smell of liver and bacon is among the most evocative of cooking aromas.
- Dementia: liver and bacon with onion gravy is strongly associated with mid-twentieth century British home cooking.
- Bone health: vitamin K, calcium, and phosphorus in liver support bone density.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with onion gravy poured over.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Slice the liver thinly. Cut into small pieces under 1.5cm. Finely chop the bacon. Moisten well with onion gravy.
5	Minced and moist	Finely mince the liver and bacon. Mix with onion gravy until cohesive and moist.
4	Puréed	Blend the liver, bacon, and onion gravy until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Liver and bacon is a dish that divides opinion sharply: clients either love it deeply or have a strong aversion. Check beforehand. For those who love it, it produces the comment that nobody makes it any more. You are making something genuinely rare.

Presentation tip

Serve on a warmed plate. Onion gravy should be generous and glossy. Bacon across the liver, gravy poured over. Mashed potato alongside.

Watch out for

Never overcook liver: it becomes tough and bitter. 1.5-2 minutes per side. Very high in vitamin A: not suitable for clients on high-dose vitamin A supplements.

Make it easier

The onion gravy can be made ahead and kept in the fridge for 3 days. The liver takes less than 5 minutes: make it last.

Toad in the Hole

Meat | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 40 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Toad in the hole is one of the most beloved and idiosyncratic of all British dishes: good sausages baked in a risen Yorkshire pudding batter, served with onion gravy. It has appeared in British cookery books since the eighteenth century. Few dishes produce as instant and warm a response in elderly clients.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Good quality pork sausages	3-4 sausages
Plain flour	100g
Eggs	2 large eggs
Full-fat milk	150ml
Salt	A pinch
Lard or dripping (or vegetable oil)	2 tbsp
Onion gravy to serve	As made in sauces chapter

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 220°C / 200°C fan / Gas 7.

- Make the batter first: whisk the flour and salt in a bowl. Make a well and add the eggs. Beat until smooth. Gradually add the milk, whisking constantly, until a smooth lump-free batter forms. Rest for at least 30 minutes.

- Place the sausages in a roasting tin with the lard or oil. Cook in the preheated oven for 15 minutes until the sausages are beginning to brown and the fat is very hot.
- Working quickly, pull the tin from the oven and pour the batter around the sausages. Return immediately to the oven. Do not open the door for 20-25 minutes.
- The batter should have risen dramatically and be deeply golden. Serve immediately.
- Serve with onion gravy poured generously over.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the sausages and eggs.
- Carbohydrate from the batter: provides energy.
- Calcium from the milk.
- B vitamins from the eggs and meat.
- Iron from the sausage meat.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: toad in the hole is one of the most visually impressive dishes in the book. The puffed golden batter tends to produce delight.
- Dementia: one of the most powerfully nostalgic British dishes. Its distinctive name and appearance make it immediately recognisable.
- Bone health: the combination of milk in the batter and eggs provides calcium and vitamin D.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve immediately from the oven before the batter deflates. Onion gravy is essential.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut the sausage into very small pieces. The batter softens quickly with gravy: serve with extra gravy.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Toad in the hole is one of the great eccentric pleasures of British cooking. Its name delights children and adults alike. For clients of all backgrounds, it tends to produce an immediate warm response.

Presentation tip

Serve in the tin it was cooked in. Speed is important: it deflates quickly. A generous jug of onion gravy alongside.

Watch out for

The oven and fat must be very hot before the batter goes in. Sausages should be of good quality. The batter must be rested for at least 30 minutes.

Make it easier

The batter can be made up to 24 hours ahead and kept in the fridge. Give it a quick stir before using.

Lamb Hotpot

Meat | Serves 2 | Autumn and winter

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 2 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Lancashire hotpot is one of the most enduring and beloved of all regional British dishes: layers of lamb neck chops and sliced potatoes cooked slowly in the oven until the lamb is falling from the bone and the potato top has turned golden and crisp. It is associated strongly with the north of England but loved throughout Britain.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Lamb neck chops or diced lamb shoulder	200g
Brown onion, thinly sliced	1 large
Carrot, thinly sliced	1 large
Maris Piper potatoes, peeled and thinly sliced	250g
Lamb or chicken stock	250ml
Fresh thyme sprigs	3-4 sprigs
Bay leaf	1
Unsalted butter	20g
Salt and black pepper	To taste
Worcestershire sauce	1 tsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 170°C / 150°C fan / Gas 3.

- Season the lamb. Brown in a heavy casserole over high heat. Remove and set aside.
- Soften the onion for 5-6 minutes in the same dish. Add the carrot and cook for 3 minutes.
- Return the lamb. Add the thyme, bay leaf, Worcestershire sauce, and enough stock to come halfway up.
- Arrange sliced potatoes in overlapping layers across the top. Brush generously with melted butter and season.
- Cover and cook for 1 hour 30 minutes. Remove the lid, increase to 200°C for 20-30 minutes until the potato top is golden and crisp.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Protein from the lamb: excellent quality and easily absorbed. • Collagen from the lamb neck: supports joint and bone health. • Potassium from the potatoes: supports heart health. • Fibre and vitamins from the vegetables. • Iron and zinc from the lamb.	• Appetite: lamb hotpot is deeply warming and satisfying. • Dementia: Lancashire hotpot is one of the iconic regional dishes of British cooking and carries very strong nostalgic associations. • Bone health: collagen from the slow-cooked lamb neck contributes to joint and bone support.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. The lamb should be falling from the bone.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure the lamb is completely tender. Cut into pieces under 1.5cm. Ensure potato slices are very soft.
5	Minced and moist	Shred the lamb very finely. Mash the potato topping into the gravy. Combine until cohesive and moist.
4	Puréed	Blend the lamb and vegetable filling with stock until completely smooth. Blend the potato with butter and milk separately.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Lancashire hotpot has a depth of regional identity that few British dishes can match. The golden potato crust is its defining characteristic.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was cooked in. The golden potato top should be presented intact. Red cabbage or buttered greens alongside.

Watch out for

Potatoes are relatively high in potassium: reduce for clients with CKD. Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. Allow to rest 5 minutes before serving.

Make it easier

An ideal set-and-forget dish. Assemble, place in the oven, return 2 hours later. Reheats beautifully the following day.

Slow-Cooked Lamb Shoulder

Meat | Serves 3-4 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 4 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Slow-cooked lamb shoulder is one of the great dishes of the British table: a whole shoulder cooked at a low temperature for many hours until the meat falls from the bone in tender, flavour-rich shreds. It requires almost no skill, only patience. Lamb shoulder has far more flavour than leg and becomes incomparably tender when cooked long and slow.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Lamb shoulder, bone-in	800g-1kg
Garlic cloves, sliced	4 cloves
Fresh rosemary sprigs	4-5 sprigs
Anchovy fillets (optional but recommended)	4 fillets
Olive oil	2 tbsp
Lamb or chicken stock	200ml
Salt and black pepper	Generous seasoning

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 170°C / 150°C fan / Gas 3.

- Score the lamb shoulder all over with a sharp knife. Push slices of garlic, small sprigs of rosemary, and pieces of anchovy into the cuts.
- Rub the surface generously with olive oil. Season very well.
- Place in a roasting tin. Pour the stock around the base. Cover tightly with a double layer of foil.
- Roast for 3 hours 30 minutes to 4 hours until the meat is completely tender and pulling away from the bone.
- Remove the foil for the final 30 minutes to colour the surface.
- Rest for at least 20 minutes. Shred or carve. Strain the cooking juices and serve as a simple gravy.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the lamb: excellent for muscle maintenance.
- Collagen from the slow cooking: supports joint and bone health.
- Iron and zinc from the lamb.
- B vitamins including B12.

Good for these conditions

- Dementia: the smell of lamb roasting slowly over several hours is one of the most powerful positive sensory experiences in a care kitchen.
- Appetite: the falling tender meat is easy to eat and enormously satisfying.
- Bone health: collagen from the long cooking supports joint and bone support.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Shred and serve with the cooking juices.
6	Soft and bite-sized	The slow-cooked lamb shreds naturally into very small tender pieces. Moisten generously.
5	Minced and moist	Shred very finely with two forks. Mix with the cooking juices until completely moist.
4	Puréed	Blend the shredded lamb with cooking juices and a little cream until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

A slow-roasted lamb shoulder is associated with the best Sunday lunches. Make it on a Sunday and serve it as the centrepiece of a proper meal.

Presentation tip

Bring the whole shoulder to the table if possible and shred it there: the theatre is significant. Serve with roast potatoes, green beans, and mint sauce.

Watch out for

The anchovies dissolve completely during cooking and add no fishy flavour: they are there as seasoning. Check for anchovy allergy if relevant.

Make it easier

15 minutes of preparation and 4 hours of unattended cooking. Place in the oven in the morning and it is ready for lunch.

Boiled Bacon with Parsley Sauce

Meat | Serves 2-3 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 1 hr 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

! Very high in sodium. Parboil for 30 minutes and discard the first water for clients with hypertension or heart failure.

ABOUT THIS DISH

Boiled bacon with parsley sauce is one of the oldest and most English of all dishes: a rolled joint of bacon simmered gently until tender and served with a generous parsley sauce. It appears in British cookery books from the eighteenth century. Straightforward, sustaining, and producing a dish of considerable depth when made well.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Rolled bacon joint or gammon	500g
Brown onion, halved	1
Carrot, halved	1
Celery sticks	2 sticks
Bay leaves	2
Black peppercorns	8
Unsalted butter (for sauce)	25g
Plain flour	25g
Full-fat milk	250ml

Flat-leaf parsley, very finely chopped	4 tbsp
Salt, white pepper, nutmeg	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the bacon in a large saucepan and cover with cold water. Bring to the boil, then drain and discard the water.
- Return the bacon to the pan with fresh cold water. Add the onion, carrot, celery, bay leaves, and peppercorns. Bring to a gentle simmer. Cook for 25 minutes per 500g.
- Remove the bacon and allow to rest for 10 minutes. Remove the skin if present.
- Make the parsley sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes. Add the milk gradually until a smooth thick sauce forms. Simmer for 5 minutes. Off the heat, add the parsley generously. Season with salt, white pepper, and nutmeg.
- Carve into thick slices. Serve with the parsley sauce poured generously over.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the bacon: complete and highly satisfying.
- B vitamins particularly thiamine: pork is one of the richest sources.
- Zinc and selenium from the pork.
- Calcium from the milk in the sauce.
- Parsley provides vitamin C, vitamin K, and iron.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: deeply satisfying and substantial.
- Dementia: boiled bacon is associated with a tradition of English farmhouse cooking many clients of a certain age will remember.
- Bone health: calcium from the milk sauce and vitamin K from the parsley both contribute.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Carve thickly and serve with parsley sauce.
6	Soft and bite-sized	The bacon is naturally tender after long simmering. Cut into small pieces under 1.5cm. Moisten generously with parsley sauce.
5	Minced and moist	Finely chop the bacon into very small pieces under 4mm. Mix with parsley sauce until cohesive.
4	Puréed	Blend the bacon with the parsley sauce until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

Nostalgia note

Boiled bacon with parsley sauce represents a form of British cooking that is now quite rare. Many clients from rural backgrounds will have strong memories of it.

Presentation tip

Thick slices of pale tender bacon, the vivid green parsley sauce poured over, boiled potatoes and a green vegetable alongside.

Watch out for

Always discard the first cooking water. For clients with hypertension reduce the portion significantly. The parsley must be added off the heat to preserve its vivid green colour.

Make it easier

The bacon joint can be simmered ahead and kept warm in its cooking liquid. The parsley sauce takes 10 minutes.



Chapter 12

Vegetarian

Vegetable dishes of substance and pleasure

Cauliflower Cheese

Vegetarian | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Cauliflower cheese is one of the most comforting and universally loved of all British vegetable dishes: tender cauliflower florets baked in a rich, well-seasoned cheese sauce with a golden crust on top. It has been made in British kitchens since the Victorian era. As a main course for a light lunch it is a dish of great reliability and genuine pleasure.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cauliflower, broken into florets	Half a small head (about 300g)
Unsalted butter	25g
Plain flour	25g
Full-fat milk	250ml
Mature cheddar, grated	75g
Dijon mustard	0.5 tsp
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Cook the cauliflower in well-salted boiling water for 5-6 minutes until just tender. Drain well and transfer to a small ovenproof dish.
- Make the cheese sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes. Add the milk gradually until a smooth sauce forms. Simmer for 5 minutes. Off the heat, stir in most of the cheese, the mustard, and nutmeg. Season well.
- Pour the sauce over the cauliflower.
- Scatter the remaining cheese over the top.
- Bake for 20-25 minutes until golden and bubbling.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk and cheese: one of the best sources in the vegetarian chapter.
- Vitamin C from the cauliflower: supports immune function and iron absorption.
- Folate from the cauliflower: important for cell repair.
- Protein from the cheese and milk.
- Significant calories from the cheese sauce.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the combination of calcium from the cheese and vitamin D from the milk supports bone density.
- Appetite: the golden cheese crust and creamy sauce are extremely effective at stimulating appetite.
- Dementia: cauliflower cheese is associated strongly with school dinners and family meals.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure florets are very well cooked and completely tender. Cut into pieces under 1.5cm.
5	Minced and moist	Break down cauliflower into very small pieces under 4mm. Mix with extra cheese sauce.
4	Puréed	Blend the cauliflower and cheese sauce together until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Cauliflower cheese occupies a special place in the British culinary consciousness as a dish that is simultaneously modest and deeply satisfying.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was baked in. The golden cheese crust is the visual centrepiece.

Watch out for

The cheese sauce must be well-seasoned: bland sauce ruins the dish. Use a mature well-flavoured cheddar. The cauliflower must be well-drained before adding the sauce.

Make it easier

The cheese sauce can be made ahead. Reheat gently with a splash of milk, pour over the just-cooked cauliflower, and bake.

Macaroni Cheese

Vegetarian | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Macaroni cheese is one of the great British comfort dishes. It has been made in Britain since at least the eighteenth century, appearing in the earliest edition of Mrs Beeton's household management book. For elderly clients it is associated with comfort, warmth, and nourishing cooking. Made with good cheese and properly seasoned it is a dish of considerable satisfaction.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Dried macaroni	100g
Unsalted butter	30g
Plain flour	30g
Full-fat milk	400ml
Mature cheddar, grated	100g
Dijon or English mustard	1 tsp
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Breadcrumbs (optional)	2 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Cook the macaroni in well-salted boiling water until al dente, about 2 minutes less than the packet suggests. Drain.
- Make the cheese sauce: melt the butter, add the flour, cook for 2 minutes. Add the milk gradually until a smooth sauce forms. Simmer for 5 minutes. Off the heat, stir in most of the cheese, the mustard, and nutmeg. Season generously.
- Combine the pasta with the sauce. Transfer to an ovenproof dish.
- Scatter the remaining cheese and breadcrumbs over the top.
- Bake for 20-25 minutes until golden and bubbling.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk and cheese: supports bone density.
- Protein from the cheese.
- Carbohydrate from the pasta: sustained energy.
- B vitamins from the cheese.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: cheese and milk provide excellent calcium and protein.
- Appetite: one of the most reliably eaten dishes across all ages and backgrounds.
- Dementia: among the most universally familiar of British dishes.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure pasta is very well cooked and soft. The cheese sauce keeps everything moist.
5	Minced and moist	Cook pasta until very soft then cut into very small pieces. Mix with extra cheese sauce.
4	Puréed	Blend the cooked pasta and cheese sauce until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Macaroni cheese seems to belong to everyone. Ask the client how they like theirs: with a crispy crust or without, extra cheese or less. The conversation is part of the enjoyment.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was baked in. The golden top should be preserved.

Watch out for

Do not undercook the pasta: it continues to absorb liquid during baking. The cheese sauce must be well-seasoned.

Make it easier

Can be assembled ahead and refrigerated. Bake when needed, adding 10 minutes if cooking from cold.

Welsh Rarebit

Vegetarian | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Welsh rarebit is one of the oldest and most distinctively British of all savoury dishes: a rich, well-seasoned cheese sauce made with ale or stout, spread on toast and grilled until golden and bubbling. It has been made in Britain since at least the eighteenth century. Made properly, it is in a completely different category from ordinary cheese on toast.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Mature cheddar, grated	75g
Pale ale, stout, or milk	2 tbsp
English mustard	1 tsp
Worcestershire sauce	1 tsp
Egg yolk	1 yolk
Salt and black pepper	To taste
Thick white bread, toasted	1-2 slices

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt the cheese slowly in a small saucepan with the ale over a very low heat, stirring constantly. Do not overheat.
- Remove from the heat. Beat in the mustard, Worcestershire sauce, and egg yolk. Season well. The mixture should be smooth, thick, and glossy.

- Toast the bread and place on a grill tray. Spread the cheese mixture thickly over the toast, right to the edges.
- Grill under a very hot grill for 3-4 minutes until golden, bubbling, and beginning to char at the edges.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cheese: substantial contribution to bone density.
- Protein from the cheese and egg yolk.
- B vitamins from the cheese.
- Choline from the egg yolk: supports brain health.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the cheese provides excellent calcium.
- Appetite: the intense savoury flavour of a proper Welsh rarebit is very effective at stimulating appetite.
- Dementia: associated strongly with a tradition of British savoury cooking many clients will remember fondly.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve immediately from the grill on thick toast.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use soft white bread rather than toast. Grill briefly and serve on soft bread in small pieces.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Welsh rarebit occupies a significant place in British savoury cooking history. The distinction between a proper rarebit and simple cheese on toast is worth making: explain what you are making and why it is different.

Presentation tip

Serve directly from the grill. The golden, slightly blistered top is its visual signature. A few drops of Worcestershire sauce across the top before serving is the traditional finish.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. The ale also contains gluten: use milk for clients with coeliac disease. Keep the temperature very low and stir constantly to avoid the cheese splitting.

Make it easier

The cheese mixture can be made ahead and kept in the fridge for 2 days. Spread on toast and grill when needed.

Bubble and Squeak

Vegetarian | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Bubble and squeak is one of the most essentially British of all dishes: leftover mashed potato and cooked cabbage pressed into a cake and fried until golden and crisp. It has been made in Britain since the early nineteenth century and represents the best of the British tradition of using leftovers well. Quick, economical, and producing a dish of surprising quality from the humblest ingredients.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Mashed potato, leftover or freshly made	150g
Cooked cabbage, sprouts, or kale, roughly chopped	80g
Cooked peas or other leftover vegetables (optional)	30g
Salt and black pepper	To taste
Butter or dripping for frying	20g

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Combine the mashed potato with the chopped cooked cabbage and any other vegetables. Season well.
- Shape into a round cake or smaller individual cakes approximately 2cm thick.
- Melt the butter or dripping in a non-stick frying pan over a medium heat.
- Fry for 4-5 minutes on the first side until a dark golden crust has formed. Turn carefully and cook for a further 4-5 minutes.

- The exterior should be crisp and golden; the interior soft and yielding. Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Fibre from the cabbage: supports digestive health.
- Vitamin C from the cabbage: supports immune function.
- Potassium from the potato.
- Calcium from the mashed potato if made with milk and butter.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the golden crust and soft warming interior make bubble and squeak one of the most satisfying quick vegetable dishes.
- Dementia: strongly associated with the day after Sunday lunch and the resourceful tradition of British home cooking.
- Bone health: the mash made with milk and butter provides calcium.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with a golden crust.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Skip the crust. Press the mixture into a ramekin and heat through in the oven. Serve in soft moist spoonfuls.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Bubble and squeak is quintessentially associated with the day after roast dinner. For clients who cooked throughout their lives it may prompt a memory of their own kitchen.

Presentation tip

A golden cake on a warmed plate with cold meat alongside, or a poached egg on top.

Watch out for

The potato must not be too wet or the cake will not hold together. If the mash is very soft, add a tablespoon of flour to help it bind.

Make it easier

The definition of an easy leftover dish. Takes 15 minutes and requires no fresh shopping.

Mushroom Risotto

Vegetarian | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A good mushroom risotto is one of the most satisfying and nutritious of vegetarian dishes: arborio rice cooked slowly in stock, enriched with the concentrated flavour of mushrooms and finished with butter and parmesan. It became fashionable in British cooking from the 1980s onwards. The technique requires attention and patience: risotto cannot be rushed and cannot be left alone.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Arborio or carnaroli rice	80g
Chestnut mushrooms, sliced	150g
Dried porcini mushrooms (optional)	10g
Shallot or small onion, finely diced	1
Garlic clove, crushed	1 clove
Good vegetable or chicken stock, hot	500-600ml
Dry white wine (optional)	50ml
Unsalted butter	30g
Parmesan, finely grated	30g
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- If using dried porcini, soak in 100ml boiling water for 15 minutes. Drain, reserving the liquid. Add the strained liquid to the stock.
- Heat a wide heavy-based saucepan over a medium heat. Add half the butter. Cook the shallot for 5 minutes until soft. Add the garlic and cook for 1 minute.
- Add the sliced mushrooms and increase the heat. Cook until all moisture has evaporated and the mushrooms are golden.
- Add the rice and stir to coat. Add the wine if using and stir until absorbed. Begin adding hot stock, one ladleful at a time, stirring constantly and waiting until each addition is absorbed before adding the next.
- Continue for 18-20 minutes until the rice is creamy and just al dente. The risotto should flow gently when the pan is shaken.
- Remove from the heat. Beat in the remaining butter and the parmesan. Cover and rest for 2 minutes. Season well and serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Beta-glucans from the mushrooms: supports immune function and cholesterol regulation.
- Vitamin D from the mushrooms (particularly if exposed to light).
- Carbohydrate from the arborio rice: sustained energy.
- Calcium and protein from the parmesan.
- B vitamins from both the mushrooms and the rice.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: mushrooms associated with cardiovascular benefit.
- Diabetes: arborio rice has a moderate glycaemic index. A portion-controlled serving with plenty of mushroom is a reasonable choice.
- Dementia: risotto is associated with careful, attentive cooking: the kind of meal that signals someone has taken care.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve immediately, flowing and creamy.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure the rice is very well cooked. The creamy moist nature of risotto is naturally appropriate.
5	Minced and moist	Cook the rice until very soft, almost breaking down. Finely chop the mushrooms. The risotto consistency naturally supports this level.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Risotto arrived in British kitchens through Italian restaurants and food writers from the 1980s onwards. For clients who cooked with interest and ate in good restaurants, it will be familiar and pleasurable.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed wide bowl. A few shavings of parmesan, a drizzle of good olive oil.

Watch out for

Risotto must be served immediately: it stiffens quickly. Have warm bowls and everything ready before the final stages. The stock must be hot when added.

Make it easier

The mushrooms can be cooked ahead and added when making the risotto. Good-quality stock is essential.



Chapter 13

Sauces & Stocks

The foundations of a care kitchen

Simple Chicken Stock

Sauces and stocks | Makes 1.5-2 litres | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 1

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 2 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A good chicken stock is the foundation of almost every soup, sauce, and braise in this book. It takes very little active work, costs almost nothing, and transforms the flavour of everything it touches. The habit of making stock from the carcass of a roast chicken is one of the most valuable things a carer can establish.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chicken carcass from a roast, or raw chicken wings	1 carcass / 500g wings
Brown onion, halved	1
Carrot, roughly broken	1 large
Celery sticks, roughly broken	2 sticks
Bay leaves	2
Black peppercorns	8
Fresh thyme and parsley stalks	A few sprigs
Cold water	2 litres

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the carcass in a large pot. Cover with cold water. Bring slowly to a gentle simmer and skim any foam for the first 20 minutes.

- Add all the vegetables and aromatics. Do not add salt.
- Simmer gently, uncovered, for 1 hour 30 minutes to 2 hours. The surface should tremble, never boil hard.
- Strain through a fine sieve. Press gently on the solids. Discard the solids.
- Cool completely. Refrigerate. Skim off any solidified fat before using.
- Use within 3 days or freeze in labelled portions for up to 3 months.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Collagen and gelatine: supports gut and joint health.
- Minerals extracted from the bones: calcium, magnesium, phosphorus.
- Glycine and proline: amino acids supporting sleep and gut integrity.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: a base for soups, sauces, and braises that add significant nutritional value.
- Dementia: the smell of stock simmering is one of the most comforting and familiar of all kitchen aromas.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
1	Thin liquid	Strain thoroughly and serve as a thin clear broth.
2-3	Slightly to moderately thick	Add a prescribed thickening agent measured precisely.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The stock pot simmering on the hob is one of the most ancient images in the history of domestic cooking. Many clients will remember it from their parents' kitchens.

Presentation tip

Decant into clearly labelled containers. A good stock should be golden and, when refrigerated, should set to a soft jelly.

Watch out for

Never boil stock hard. Never salt stock before it has been reduced to its final use.

Make it easier

A slow cooker is ideal for stock: fill with carcass, vegetables, and cold water and cook on low overnight.

Bechamel Sauce

Sauces and stocks | Makes approximately 300ml | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Bechamel is one of the five French mother sauces and the foundation of some of the most important dishes in the British kitchen: macaroni cheese, cauliflower cheese, fish pie, and many more. It is nothing more than butter, flour, and milk, but made with care it produces a sauce of smooth richness that transforms everything it touches.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Unsalted butter	30g
Plain flour	30g
Full-fat milk, warm	300ml
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Bay leaf (optional, infused in the milk)	1

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- If using a bay leaf, warm the milk gently with it for 5 minutes. Remove.
- Melt the butter in a heavy-based saucepan. Add the flour and stir constantly to form a smooth paste. Cook for 2-3 minutes, stirring: the roux should smell biscuity, not raw.
- Add the warm milk a little at a time, whisking vigorously after each addition until completely smooth before adding the next.

- Bring to a gentle simmer, stirring constantly, until the sauce thickens and coats the back of a spoon. This takes 5-8 minutes.
- Season with salt, white pepper, and nutmeg. Use immediately or press cling film directly onto the surface to prevent a skin forming.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk: a significant source supporting bone density.
- Protein from the milk.
- Vitamin D if using fortified milk.
- B vitamins from the milk.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: bechamel provides an excellent vehicle for delivering calcium in an easily eaten form.
- Appetite: the creaminess and richness of bechamel-based dishes is very effective at making food more acceptable.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Bechamel naturally achieves IDDSI Level 4 at standard coating consistency. Thin with extra warm milk if needed.
3	Liquidised	Thin with additional warm milk, whisking well, until it flows freely from a spoon.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Bechamel is invisible in the dishes it underpins. The client experiences its richness without identifying the sauce itself. Making it well elevates every dish it supports.

Presentation tip

A component sauce, not a finished dish. Use immediately or keep warm over a very low heat.

Watch out for

Lumps form if the milk is added too quickly. If lumps do form, beat vigorously with a whisk and if necessary pass through a fine sieve.

Make it easier

Can be made in advance and kept in the fridge for 2 days with cling film pressed to the surface. Reheat very gently with a little extra milk.

Onion Gravy

Sauces and stocks | Makes approximately 250ml | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Heart health

ABOUT THIS DISH

A proper onion gravy is one of the most useful sauces in a care kitchen: rich, dark, sweet from the slow-cooked onions, and versatile enough to accompany sausages, liver, mashed potato, and toad in the hole. The secret is patience: the onions must cook very slowly for at least 25 minutes until completely soft, golden, and sweet.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Brown onions, thinly sliced	3 large
Unsalted butter	25g
Olive oil	1 tbsp
Plain flour	1 tbsp
Beef or vegetable stock	300ml
Worcestershire sauce	1 tsp
Fresh thyme sprigs	2 sprigs
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat the butter and oil in a wide, heavy-based saucepan over a low heat. Add the onions and thyme with a pinch of salt.

- Cook over a low to medium heat for 25-30 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the onions are completely soft, golden, and sweet.
- Add the flour and stir well. Cook for 2 minutes.
- Add the Worcestershire sauce and the stock gradually, stirring. Bring to a simmer.
- Cook for 8-10 minutes until the gravy has reduced to a glossy, well-flavoured consistency. Remove the thyme. Season well.
- For a smooth gravy, blend and pass through a sieve. For a textured gravy, serve as is.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Quercetin and antioxidants from the onions: associated with anti-inflammatory and cardiovascular benefit.
- Prebiotic fibre from the onions: supports beneficial gut bacteria.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: one of the most effective sauce additions for making a plain dish more appetising.
- Dementia: the smell of onions caramelising slowly is one of the most powerful and positive kitchen aromas.
- Heart health: quercetin from the slow-cooked onions has cardiovascular benefit.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend thoroughly and pass through a fine sieve until completely smooth.
7	Regular	Serve with texture: soft golden onion pieces in a rich gravy.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Onion gravy is associated with a range of quintessentially British dishes: sausages and mash, toad in the hole, liver and bacon. Its deep sweet savouriness is one of the most comforting smells in British home cooking.

Presentation tip

Pour generously over the dish it accompanies. Serve hot and glossy.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. Do not rush the onion cooking.

Make it easier

Improves with reheating. Keeps in the fridge for 4 days. Freezes for up to 3 months.

Custard

Sauces and stocks | Makes approximately 300ml | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Proper pouring custard, made with egg yolks and cream, is one of the great achievements of British pudding cookery. It accompanies crumbles, puddings, tarts, and stewed fruit, and is an important vehicle for calories and nourishment. The technique requires attention: custard must be cooked gently and stirred constantly or it will curdle. Made well, it is silky, rich, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Full-fat milk	200ml
Double cream	100ml
Egg yolks	3 yolks
Caster sugar	2 tbsp
Vanilla extract or a vanilla pod	1 tsp or 1 pod

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat the milk and cream together with the vanilla until just below simmering point. Do not boil.
- Whisk the egg yolks and sugar together until pale and slightly thickened.
- Pour the hot milk mixture over the egg yolks gradually, whisking constantly.
- Return to a clean saucepan over a very low heat. Stir constantly with a wooden spoon until the custard thickens enough to coat the back of the spoon, 8-10 minutes. Do not allow to boil.

- Remove immediately from the heat. Strain through a fine sieve into a warm jug. Serve immediately or keep warm over a bowl of hot water.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk and cream.
- Protein from the egg yolks.
- Choline from the egg yolks: critical for brain health.
- Significant calories from the cream.
- Vitamin A and D from the cream and egg yolks.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: milk and cream provide calcium and vitamin D.
- Appetite: poured over a crumble or pudding, custard adds both calories and appeal.
- Dementia: proper custard is strongly associated with British pudding culture across all backgrounds.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	A standard pouring custard naturally achieves IDDSI Level 4. It should coat the back of a spoon and fall slowly.
3	Liquidised	Thin with a little extra warm milk until it flows freely.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Proper custard is one of those dishes that prompts an immediate and enthusiastic response: the comment that nobody makes it properly any more. That reaction is its own reward.

Presentation tip

Pour from a warmed jug at the table. Serve immediately: custard forms a skin quickly if left to stand.

Watch out for

If the custard begins to look lumpy or steam heavily, remove immediately from the heat and beat vigorously. Never let it boil.

Make it easier

Can be kept warm in a heatproof jug over a bowl of hot water, covered, for up to 30 minutes.

Bread Sauce

Sauces and stocks | Makes approximately 300ml | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Bread sauce is one of the oldest British sauces, made by infusing milk with spices and onion and thickening it with crumbled white bread. It appears in British cookery books from the sixteenth century and has been the traditional accompaniment to roast chicken and turkey throughout British history. It is deeply, unusually British in character.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Full-fat milk	300ml
Small onion, halved, studded with cloves	1
Whole cloves	4
Bay leaf	1
Black peppercorns	6
Ground mace or nutmeg	A pinch
White bread, crusts removed, crumbled	60g
Unsalted butter	20g
Double cream (optional)	2 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the milk in a saucepan with the clove-studded onion, bay leaf, peppercorns, and mace. Bring slowly to a gentle simmer. Remove from the heat, cover, and leave to infuse for 15 minutes.
- Strain the milk into a clean saucepan, discarding the onion and aromatics.
- Add the crumbled white bread to the infused milk. Stir over a gentle heat until the bread has absorbed the milk and the sauce is thick and smooth.
- Beat in the butter and cream if using. Season carefully.
- Serve warm alongside roast chicken or turkey.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk and cream.
- Carbohydrate from the bread: provides energy.
- B vitamins from the milk.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the milk provides calcium in an easily eaten form.
- Appetite: bread sauce adds richness and warmth to a roast dinner plate.
- Dementia: strongly associated with the Christmas and Sunday roast table.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
5	Minced and moist	The natural consistency of bread sauce is close to IDDSI Level 5 when made correctly.
4	Puréed	Blend until completely smooth and pass through a sieve. Add extra warm milk to adjust.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Bread sauce is one of those very British sauces almost entirely unknown outside the country. For clients it is inseparable from the roast chicken or turkey table.

Presentation tip

Serve in a small warmed dish alongside the roast. A small grating of nutmeg across the top is the traditional finish.

Watch out for

Bread sauce thickens considerably as it cools: make it slightly thinner than you think you need.

Make it easier

The infused milk can be made ahead. Add the bread and butter when reheating.

Rich Tomato Sauce

Sauces and stocks | Makes approximately 400ml | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Cancer support

Diabetes

ABOUT THIS DISH

A good tomato sauce is one of the most versatile and useful things a carer can have in the fridge or freezer. It forms the base of pasta dishes, braised meatballs, and much more. Made with good tinned tomatoes, olive oil, and plenty of time, it develops a depth that no jar can match. It is also one of the most lycopene-rich preparations available.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Good quality tinned plum tomatoes	2 x 400g tins
Olive oil	3 tbsp
Garlic cloves, thinly sliced	3 cloves
Brown onion, finely diced	1 medium
Fresh basil leaves (optional)	A handful
Caster sugar	1 tsp
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat the olive oil in a wide saucepan over a medium heat. Add the onion and cook for 8-10 minutes until soft and beginning to colour.
- Add the garlic and cook for 2 minutes. Do not let it brown.

- Add the tinned tomatoes, crushing them as they go in. Add the sugar and season.
- Simmer uncovered over a low heat for 20-25 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the sauce has darkened and reduced by about a third.
- Add the basil if using. Taste and adjust seasoning. For a smooth sauce, blend and pass through a sieve.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Lycopene from cooked tomatoes: one of the most powerful dietary antioxidants, associated with reduced cancer risk and cardiovascular benefit.
- Vitamin C from the tomatoes.
- Heart-healthy monounsaturated fat from the olive oil.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: olive oil and tomatoes both associated with cardiovascular benefit.
- Cancer support: the lycopene content of cooked tomatoes is one of the most studied anti-cancer nutrients.
- Diabetes: a low-glycaemic sauce that adds flavour without significant sugar or refined carbohydrate.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend until completely smooth and pass through a fine sieve.
7	Regular	Serve with texture, or partially blended for a rustic consistency.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

A good tomato sauce has been part of British cooking since Mediterranean influences began to be felt from the 1950s onwards. Now thoroughly embedded in British domestic cooking.

Presentation tip

Use as a base for pasta, as a sauce for meatballs, or for braised dishes. Deep dark red with a glossy surface.

Watch out for

Tinned tomatoes vary in quality: use good-quality San Marzano or similar for the best result. High in potassium: limit for clients with CKD.

Make it easier

Freezes perfectly for up to 3 months. Make a large batch and freeze in portions.



Chapter 14

Salads

Fresh, light, and full of flavour

A note on salads in care settings

Salads are most appropriate as starters, lighter lunches for clients with a good appetite, or accompaniments to protein-rich main courses. For clients at risk of malnutrition or with a reduced appetite, always ensure a salad-based meal contains a substantial protein component: egg, fish, chicken, or cheese. Never serve a vegetable-only salad as a main meal for a client with a poor appetite. If in doubt, add a protein source and follow with a calorie-dense pudding.

Carer Cookery Programme

Coronation Chicken Salad

Salads | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Heart health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Coronation chicken was created in 1953 for the Coronation banquet of Queen Elizabeth II by Constance Spry and Rosemary Hume, and rapidly became one of the defining dishes of post-war British cooking. It has been made at every garden party, summer lunch, and celebration buffet since. A dish of genuine historical significance.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooked chicken breast or thigh, diced or shredded	150g
Good mayonnaise	3 tbsp
Mild curry powder	1 tsp
Mango chutney	1 tbsp
Lemon juice	1 tsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Toasted flaked almonds (optional)	1 tbsp

Fresh coriander or flat-leaf parsley	<i>A little</i>
Lettuce leaves to serve	<i>A few</i>

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Mix the mayonnaise with the curry powder, mango chutney, and lemon juice. Taste and adjust.
- Fold the chicken gently into the sauce until evenly coated. Season well.
- Arrange the lettuce leaves on a plate.
- Spoon the coronation chicken onto the lettuce.
- Scatter the almonds and herbs over the top.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein from the chicken.
- Anti-inflammatory compounds from the curry powder.
- Healthy fats from the mayonnaise and almonds.
- B vitamins from the chicken.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the sweet, mildly spiced flavour is consistently well-received.
- Dementia: associated with one of the most significant national events of the twentieth century. For clients who remember the Coronation, it tends to prompt conversation.
- Heart health: a lean protein dish. Use a light mayonnaise for clients with elevated cholesterol.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made on lettuce leaves.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Shred the chicken very finely. Omit the almonds. Serve on very finely shredded lettuce.
5	Minced and moist	Shred or very finely chop the chicken to under 4mm. Mix with extra sauce.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Coronation chicken has a specific, dateable history: June 2, 1953. For clients who were adults at the time, it carries an extraordinary weight of memory. Ask about where they were on Coronation Day.

Presentation tip

Serve in a bowl or on a plate with lettuce. Toasted almonds scattered over, a sprig of coriander, the golden sauce visible through the chicken.

Watch out for

Almonds are a tree nut: check for allergy. The curry powder should be mild.

Make it easier

Keeps in the fridge for 2 days. Can be made entirely from leftover roast chicken. No cooking required.

Egg Mayonnaise Salad

Salads | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Egg mayonnaise is one of the simplest and most reliable of all British salad dishes: hard-boiled eggs coated with good mayonnaise, served on a bed of crisp lettuce. It appears at every British buffet table and has done so for most of the twentieth century. Quick to make, deeply familiar, and nutritionally excellent.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Eggs	2 large eggs
Good mayonnaise	2 tbsp
Dijon mustard	A small amount
Lemon juice	A squeeze
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Paprika to finish	A pinch
Lettuce leaves and cress to serve	A handful
Brown bread and butter	1 slice

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Cook the eggs in simmering water for 10 minutes. Cool completely in cold water. Peel carefully.
- Halve the eggs. Remove the yolks and place in a bowl.

- Mash the yolks with the mayonnaise, mustard, and lemon juice until smooth. Season well.
- Spoon the yolk mixture back into the egg whites.
- Arrange on a bed of lettuce and cress. Dust with paprika. Serve with brown bread and butter.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein from the eggs: all essential amino acids.
- Choline from the egg yolks: critical for brain health.
- Vitamin D from the eggs.
- Lutein and zeaxanthin: support eye health.
- B vitamins including B12 and folate.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: eggs provide vitamin D and protein for bone density.
- Appetite: egg mayonnaise is one of those dishes that is always eaten because it is always pleasant.
- Dementia: associated with every British social occasion of the twentieth century.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as devilled eggs with lettuce and bread.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut the filled eggs into small pieces under 1.5cm.
5	Minced and moist	Mash the whole eggs with the mayonnaise mixture. Serve as a thick moist egg salad.
4	Puréed	Blend the egg and mayonnaise mixture until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Devilled eggs and egg mayonnaise have been a fixture of the British buffet table for generations, associated with a pleasant variety of happy social memories.

Presentation tip

Two or three filled egg halves on a bed of lettuce and cress, a dusting of paprika across each.

Watch out for

Eggs must be fully hard-boiled for clients with compromised immune systems. The mayonnaise must be fresh and well within its use-by date.

Make it easier

Eggs can be boiled ahead and kept in the fridge unpeeled for up to 5 days. One of the quickest options for a nutritious lunch.

Waldorf Salad

Salads | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Waldorf salad was created at the Waldorf Astoria Hotel in New York in the 1890s and became popular in Britain through the first half of the twentieth century. In its original form it is simply apples, celery, and mayonnaise. It is associated with a certain style of elegant hotel and club dining that many clients of the older generation will remember with pleasure.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Red or green apple, cored and diced	1 medium
Celery sticks, thinly sliced	2 sticks
Walnut halves, roughly broken	30g
Good mayonnaise	3 tbsp
Lemon juice	1 tsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Little gem lettuce to serve	A few leaves

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Toss the diced apple immediately in the lemon juice to prevent browning.
- Combine the apple, celery, and walnuts in a bowl.
- Add the mayonnaise and fold gently until everything is coated. Season well.

- Serve on lettuce leaves.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Healthy fats from the walnuts: particularly rich in omega-3 ALA.
- Fibre from the apple and celery.
- Vitamin C from the apple.
- Potassium from the celery.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: walnuts and olive oil-based mayonnaise both associated with cardiovascular benefit.
- Appetite: the contrast of textures and the clean fresh flavour is effective at stimulating appetite.
- Dementia: associated with a certain style of hotel and club dining that many older clients will remember.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Dice the apple small if the client has difficulty chewing.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Dice everything very small under 1.5cm. Omit the walnuts or finely chop them. Ensure apple is very ripe and tender.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The Waldorf salad became well known in Britain through Basil Fawlty, which many clients will remember with amusement. Its real history is as a dish of the grandest hotel dining.

Presentation tip

Serve in a small bowl or on lettuce leaves on a plate. The pale cream mayonnaise against the green of the apple and celery is naturally attractive.

Watch out for

Walnuts are a tree nut; check for allergy. The apple must be tossed immediately in lemon juice or it will discolour. For clients with difficulty chewing, omit the walnuts entirely.

Make it easier

Can be prepared 30 minutes ahead and kept in the fridge. Do not prepare much further ahead or the apple will soften.

Prawn Marie Rose Salad

Salads | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia



Contains crustaceans: check for shellfish allergy.

ABOUT THIS DISH

A classic Marie Rose prawn salad is the simpler, everyday cousin of the prawn cocktail starter: generous prawns on crisp lettuce with the classic pink sauce and a wedge of lemon. It became a staple of British lunch menus from the 1960s onwards and carries very strong associations with summer, light eating, and a certain cheerful informality.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooked king prawns, peeled	100g
Little gem lettuce, shredded	A handful
Good mayonnaise	2 tbsp
Tomato ketchup	1 tsp
Worcestershire sauce	A dash
Lemon juice	A squeeze
Paprika	A pinch
Brown bread and butter to serve	1 slice

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the Marie Rose sauce: mix the mayonnaise, ketchup, Worcestershire sauce, and lemon juice.
- Arrange the shredded lettuce in a bowl or on a plate.
- Toss the prawns in the sauce and spoon over the lettuce.
- Dust with paprika. Serve with brown bread and butter.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the prawns: lean and complete.
- Iodine: shellfish are among the richest sources.
- Zinc and selenium: support immune function.
- Vitamin B12 from the prawns.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: prawns are low in saturated fat. The Marie Rose sauce adds modest calories.
- Appetite: light, fresh, and visually appealing. Effective as a summer starter or light lunch.
- Dementia: the Marie Rose prawn salad is associated strongly with summer meals, beach restaurants, and a certain lighthearted informality.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut the prawns into small pieces under 1.5cm. Finely shred the lettuce.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The Marie Rose prawn salad is inseparable from the British summer table of the 1960s-80s: a light lunch in the garden, a seaside restaurant, a simple supper on a warm evening.

Presentation tip

Serve in a bowl or on a plate with lettuce visible beneath. A dusting of paprika, a wedge of lemon, and brown bread alongside.

Watch out for

Check for shellfish allergy. Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. The prawns must be fresh and well within their use-by date.

Make it easier

The Marie Rose sauce keeps in the fridge for 2 days. Do not dress the salad until just before serving.

Nicoise Salad

Salads | Serves 1 | Summer

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

A Nicoise salad is the most substantial of all salads: tuna, hard-boiled eggs, green beans, olives, tomatoes, and potatoes dressed with a simple vinaigrette. It became popular in British cooking through the influence of Elizabeth David and the enthusiasm for French provincial cooking from the 1960s onwards. For clients who are interested in food and travel, it carries pleasant associations with France and good summer eating.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Tinned tuna in olive oil, drained	Half a tin (70g)
Egg, hard-boiled	1
Small new potatoes, cooked	80g
Fine green beans, cooked	60g
Cherry tomatoes, halved	4-5
Black olives (optional)	4-5
Anchovies (optional)	2 fillets
Olive oil	2 tbsp
Red wine vinegar	1 tsp
Dijon mustard	0.5 tsp
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the dressing: whisk together the olive oil, vinegar, mustard, salt, and pepper.
- Arrange the potatoes, green beans, and tomatoes on a plate.
- Add the tuna in chunks, the quartered hard-boiled egg, the olives, and anchovies if using.
- Drizzle the dressing over everything.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Protein from the tuna and egg: complete and highly bioavailable. • Omega-3 from the tuna: supports heart and brain health. • Vitamin D from the eggs. • Potassium from the tomatoes and potatoes. • Vitamin C from the tomatoes and green beans.	Good for these conditions • Heart health: tuna, olive oil, and green vegetables all associated with cardiovascular benefit. • Diabetes: a low-glycaemic, high-protein salad with minimal impact on blood sugar. • Bone health: eggs provide vitamin D and the anchovies provide calcium.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as assembled. Ensure green beans are well-cooked and tender.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut all components into very small pieces under 1.5cm. Ensure potatoes are very soft. Omit olives.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note The Nicoise salad is associated with a certain enthusiasm for French cooking that characterised the British kitchen from the 1960s onwards through Elizabeth David's influence. For clients who cooked with interest or who travelled to France, it carries pleasant associations.
Presentation tip Arrange each component separately on the plate so all elements are visible: this is the traditional Nicoise presentation. The dressing is drizzled over at the end.

Watch out for

Anchovies and olives are both high in sodium: omit or reduce for clients with hypertension. Anchovies contain fish allergens. Olives can be a choking risk for clients with swallowing difficulties.

Make it easier

Most components can be prepared ahead and kept separately in the fridge. Assemble just before serving.



Chapter 15

Sandwiches & Light Meals

Nourishing meals without ceremony

Scrambled Eggs on Toast

Sandwiches and light meals | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 3 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Parkinson's

ABOUT THIS DISH

Perfect scrambled eggs on buttered toast is one of the most useful dishes a carer can master: quick, nutritious, easy to eat, and deeply comforting. The keys are good eggs, low heat, and removing from the heat while still very slightly underdone. Overcooked, rubbery scrambled eggs are a disappointment: soft, creamy, barely-set eggs are a pleasure.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Eggs	2-3 large eggs
Unsalted butter	15g
Double cream or full-fat milk	1 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste
White or brown bread, toasted	1-2 slices
Fresh chives (optional)	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Break the eggs into a bowl with the cream. Season well with salt and white pepper. Beat lightly.
- Melt the butter in a small non-stick pan over the lowest possible heat.
- Add the egg mixture. Stir constantly with a rubber spatula, scraping the base and sides of the pan.

- Cook very slowly for 3-4 minutes until the eggs are just set but still glossy and slightly underdone. They will continue to cook from residual heat.
- Remove immediately from the heat. Serve at once on buttered toast, scattered with chives if using.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein: all essential amino acids in near-perfect proportions.
- Choline from the egg yolks: critical for brain health.
- Vitamin D: one of the few food sources.
- B vitamins including B2, B12, and folate.
- Calories from the butter and cream: valuable for enrichment.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: vitamin D and protein both contribute to bone density maintenance.
- Appetite: soft scrambled eggs are one of the most acceptable foods for clients with very poor appetite.
- Dementia: scrambled eggs on toast is one of the most universally familiar comfort foods in British culture.
- Parkinson's: soft texture requires no cutting. Easy to eat without cutlery if needed.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made on buttered toast.
6	Soft and bite-sized	The scrambled eggs are naturally appropriate. Serve on very soft bread without crusts.
5	Minced and moist	Ensure the eggs are very softly scrambled, almost liquid at the point of serving. Serve on very soft bread.
4	Puréed	Blend the softly scrambled eggs with extra cream until completely smooth. Thin with a little extra cream if needed.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Scrambled eggs on toast is one of the simplest and most universal of British comfort foods. Many clients will have eaten it for breakfast, for supper when unwell, and in hotel rooms throughout their adult lives.

Presentation tip

Serve immediately: scrambled eggs deteriorate rapidly. Soft and glossy on buttered toast, a few snipped chives on top.

Watch out for

Remove from the heat while still slightly underdone: they will continue to cook on the plate. Never walk away from scrambled eggs: they require constant attention.

Make it easier

One of the fastest dishes in the book. 5 minutes from start to finish.

Ploughman's Lunch

Sandwiches and light meals | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

The ploughman's lunch is an entirely British institution: a plate of good cheese, bread, pickle, and accompaniments, requiring no cooking whatsoever. It became popular in pubs in the post-war period but has much older roots in the working lunch of rural Britain. It is ideal for a midday meal when time is short and appetite is modest.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Good mature cheddar or double gloucester	60-80g
Crusty bread or rolls	1-2 pieces
Unsalted butter	A generous amount
Branston pickle or chutney	1-2 tbsp
Celery sticks	1-2 sticks
Apple, sliced	Half
Cherry tomatoes	A few
Pickled onion (optional)	1

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Arrange the cheese on one side of a plate or wooden board.
- Add the bread and butter.

- Spoon the pickle alongside.
- Add the celery, apple slices, and tomatoes.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cheese: one of the most concentrated sources available.
- Protein from the cheese.
- Fibre from the apple, celery, and bread.
- Vitamin C from the apple and tomatoes.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the cheese provides substantial calcium. An excellent bone-health lunch.
- Appetite: a ploughman's with its variety of colours, textures, and flavours is often more appealing than a single hot dish for clients with limited appetite.
- Dementia: the ploughman's is associated with the British pub and a relaxed, convivial lunchtime culture.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as assembled. Ensure the cheese is soft and the bread is well-buttered.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use a very soft, crustless bread. Cut the cheese into very small pieces. Mash the pickle. Omit the pickled onion and celery for clients with difficulty chewing.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The ploughman's lunch is associated with a certain relaxed British lunch culture: a pub garden in summer, a picnic, a working lunch eaten without ceremony. For many clients it is one of the most pleasurable of all informal meals.

Presentation tip

Arrange generously on a plate or small wooden board. Variety of colours and textures is the point. Do not make it look meagre.

Watch out for

Pickle is high in sodium: limit for clients with hypertension. Pickled onion can be difficult to chew: omit for clients with dental difficulties. Celery can be a choking risk if not well-chewed.

Make it easier

Requires no cooking. Can be assembled in 10 minutes from store cupboard and fridge ingredients.

Welsh Rarebit Open Sandwich

Sandwiches and light meals | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A simplified version of the Welsh rarebit from the vegetarian chapter, served open as a substantial light meal rather than a savoury starter. The addition of a sliced tomato or a fried egg on top makes it into a proper lunch.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Mature cheddar, grated	60g
English or Dijon mustard	0.5 tsp
Worcestershire sauce	A dash
Egg yolk	1
Pale ale or milk	1 tbs
Thick white bread, toasted	1-2 slices
Tomato, sliced (optional)	1 medium
Fried or poached egg (optional)	1 egg

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt the cheese slowly with the ale over very low heat, stirring. Remove from the heat.

- Beat in the mustard, Worcestershire sauce, and egg yolk. Season.
- Spread thickly on the toast. Add sliced tomato on top if using.
- Grill under a very hot grill for 3-4 minutes until golden and bubbling.
- Serve immediately, topped with a fried or poached egg if desired.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cheese.
- Protein from the cheese and optional egg.
- B vitamins from the cheese.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: substantial calcium from the cheese.
- Appetite: a warm, savoury, visually appealing lunch that tends to be eaten readily.
- Dementia: familiar and comforting.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made on toast.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use soft bread without crusts. Cut into small pieces.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

A hot cheesy open sandwich is a deeply familiar and satisfying British lunch. Simple and honest.

Presentation tip

Serve immediately, golden and bubbling. A grind of black pepper and a few watercress leaves alongside.

Watch out for

Worcestershire sauce contains gluten and anchovies. The cheese must not be overheated or it will split and go oily.

Make it easier

The cheese mixture can be made ahead and spread on toast when ready to grill.

Club Sandwich

Sandwiches and light meals | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

The club sandwich is a double-decker sandwich of toasted bread, chicken, bacon, egg, lettuce, and tomato. It originated in American clubs in the late nineteenth century and became a fixture of British hotels and good restaurants throughout the twentieth century. For clients who travelled or stayed in good hotels, it carries a particular association with comfortable, unhurried lunch.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
White bread, toasted	2-3 slices
Good mayonnaise	2 tbsp
Cooked chicken breast, sliced	60g
Back bacon, cooked	2 rashers
Egg, fried or hard-boiled	1 egg
Little gem lettuce leaves	2 leaves
Tomato, sliced	1 medium
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Toast the bread. Spread all slices with mayonnaise.
- On the first slice, layer the chicken, half the lettuce, and half the tomato. Season.

- Place the second slice on top. Layer with the bacon, egg, remaining lettuce, and tomato.
- Top with the third slice, mayonnaise side down. Press gently.
- Cut diagonally into triangles. Secure with cocktail sticks if needed. Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein from the chicken, bacon, and egg.
- B vitamins from the egg and chicken.
- Carbohydrate from the bread.
- Vitamins from the tomato and lettuce.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: substantial and visually impressive. The multi-layered presentation signals generosity.
- Dementia: strongly associated with hotel and club dining throughout the twentieth century.
- Bone health: the egg provides vitamin D.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as assembled, cut into triangles.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Deconstruct the sandwich. Cut everything into very small pieces. Serve as a deconstructed plate with plenty of mayonnaise to moisten.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The club sandwich is associated with a certain style of hotel lunch: the kind served on a white cloth with a side of chips. For clients who stayed in good hotels throughout their working lives, it carries a specific and pleasant resonance.

Presentation tip

Cut into triangles and serve on a plate with the cut surfaces visible. A few crisps or a small salad alongside.

Watch out for

The cocktail sticks must be removed or pointed out before serving. Very high in sodium from the bacon: limit for clients with hypertension.

Make it easier

Can be assembled with leftover roast chicken. No specialist ingredients required.

Tuna and Sweetcorn Sandwich

Sandwiches and light meals | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

A good tuna and sweetcorn sandwich, made with well-drained tuna, a modest amount of mayonnaise, and sweet tinned corn on good bread, is a reliable and nutritious light meal that most clients will know and enjoy. It became one of the most popular British lunchtime sandwiches from the 1970s onwards and remains a staple of everyday British eating.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Tinned tuna in spring water, well-drained	<i>Half a tin (70g)</i>
Tinned sweetcorn, drained	<i>2 tbsp</i>
Good mayonnaise	<i>1-2 tbsp</i>
Lemon juice	<i>A squeeze</i>
Salt and black pepper	<i>To taste</i>
Brown or white bread, buttered	<i>2 slices</i>
Lettuce leaf	<i>1 leaf</i>
Tomato, sliced (optional)	<i>Half</i>

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Drain the tuna very thoroughly. Flake into a bowl.
- Add the sweetcorn, mayonnaise, and lemon juice. Mix gently. Season well.
- Spread the filling onto one buttered slice of bread. Add the lettuce and tomato if using.
- Top with the second slice. Cut in half.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the tuna: lean and complete.
- Omega-3 fatty acids from the tuna.
- Carbohydrate from the bread and sweetcorn.
- Fibre from the sweetcorn.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: a lean, omega-3-rich sandwich.
- Diabetes: relatively low-glycaemic with good protein. Use wholegrain bread for a better blood sugar profile.
- Appetite: familiar, reliably pleasant, and easy to eat.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use very soft bread without crusts. Mash the sweetcorn slightly. Ensure the filling is very moist with extra mayonnaise.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Tuna and sweetcorn became one of Britain's most popular sandwich fillings from the 1970s onwards. It is associated with office lunches, school packed lunches, and the kind of everyday eating that feels familiar and satisfying.

Presentation tip

Cut in half diagonally. Serve on a plate with a few cherry tomatoes or a small green salad alongside.

Watch out for

Use tuna in spring water rather than brine to reduce sodium. Drain the tuna very thoroughly or the bread will become soggy.

Make it easier

The tuna filling can be made ahead and kept in the fridge for 24 hours. Assemble the sandwich when needed.



Chapter 16

Breakfast

The most important meal of the day

Porridge with Honey and Cream

Breakfast | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Dementia

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A bowl of proper porridge, made slowly with full-fat milk and finished with a spoonful of good honey and a swirl of cream, is one of the most nourishing and comforting starts to any day. Porridge has been made in British and Scottish kitchens for centuries and remains one of the most nutritionally excellent of all breakfasts. It is particularly valuable in a care setting for its adaptability to almost any IDDSI level.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Rolled oats (not instant)	50g
Full-fat milk	250ml
Water	100ml
Salt	A small pinch
Good honey	1-2 tsp
Double cream	1-2 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Combine the oats, milk, water, and salt in a small saucepan.

- Cook over a medium heat, stirring regularly, for 5-8 minutes until the oats have absorbed the liquid and the porridge is thick and creamy. Reduce the heat if it begins to stick.
- Taste and adjust consistency: add more milk if the porridge is too thick.
- Pour into a warmed bowl. Drizzle the honey over in a spiral. Pour the cream around the edge.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Beta-glucan fibre from the oats: the most evidence-based dietary intervention for cholesterol reduction available.
- Slow-release carbohydrate: supports stable blood sugar throughout the morning.
- Calcium from the milk and cream.
- B vitamins from the oats.
- Calories from the cream and honey: important for calorie enrichment.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: beta-glucan fibre from oats is proven to reduce LDL cholesterol.
- Diabetes: slow-release carbohydrate minimises blood sugar spikes.
- Dementia: porridge is one of the most deeply familiar of all British breakfasts.
- Dysphagia: naturally achieves IDDSI Level 5 at standard consistency.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
5	Minced and moist	Standard porridge made with rolled oats and plenty of milk. Stir vigorously to achieve a smooth cohesive consistency.
4	Puréed	Blend the cooked porridge until completely smooth. Thin with extra warm milk.
7	Regular	Serve as made with a slightly thicker, more textured consistency.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Porridge is one of the most universally familiar of all British breakfasts. Many clients will have a strong view on how it should be made. Ask, and make it to their preference.

Presentation tip

Serve in a wide warmed bowl. The honey drizzled decoratively and the cream poured around the edge.

Watch out for

Porridge retains heat intensely: check the temperature before serving. Do not serve scalding. Instant oats produce an inferior result: use rolled oats.

Make it easier

Overnight oats can be prepared the evening before: combine oats and milk in a covered bowl and refrigerate. Heat gently in the morning with extra milk.

Full English Breakfast (Adapted)

Breakfast | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health



High in sodium from the bacon and sausages: limit for clients with hypertension or heart failure.

ABOUT THIS DISH

A full English breakfast is one of the great ceremonial meals of British life. In a care setting it is not an everyday meal but an occasional occasion: a Saturday morning, a birthday, a day when the client needs lifting. Made with care and good ingredients, it is one of the most effective gestures of generosity a carer can make.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Good pork sausages	2
Back bacon rashers	2
Eggs	2 eggs
Tinned tomatoes or fresh tomatoes	Half a tin or 2 fresh
Mushrooms, sliced	60g
Unsalted butter	20g
White bread for toast	1-2 slices
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Cook the sausages in a frying pan over a medium heat for 12-15 minutes, turning regularly, until cooked through and golden.
- Add the bacon and cook for 3-4 minutes on each side.
- In a separate pan, fry the mushrooms in a little butter with seasoning until golden.
- Cook the tomatoes: halve fresh tomatoes and cook cut-side down for 3-4 minutes, or heat tinned tomatoes briefly.
- Fry or scramble the eggs to the client's preference in butter.
- Toast and butter the bread. Plate everything carefully and serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Complete protein from the eggs, sausages, and bacon. • B vitamins from the pork and eggs. • Significant calories: an important nutritional contribution for clients with poor appetite.	Good for these conditions • Appetite: one of the most effective appetite stimulants available. The combination of smells during cooking, the visual abundance of the plate, and the familiar format tend to produce excellent intake. • Dementia: the full English is one of the most culturally embedded of all British meals. • Bone health: eggs, dairy, and bacon all contribute calcium and vitamin D.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Each component should be cooked to appropriate softness.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Scramble the eggs softly. Use very well-cooked soft sausages cut small. Cut everything under 1.5cm.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note The full English carries more cultural weight in British life than almost any other meal. Making one for a client, with attention to how they like each element, is a significant gesture.

Presentation tip

Arrange each element separately on a warmed plate so all components are visible. Toast on a separate plate.

Watch out for

Very high in sodium: not appropriate for clients with heart failure or severe hypertension more than very occasionally. Have everything ready before anything hits the pan.

Make it easier

Use the oven to cook the sausages and bacon (20 minutes at 200°C) freeing the hob for the eggs and mushrooms.

Kippers with Brown Bread and Butter

Breakfast | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Kippers, smoked herring, are one of the most distinctively British of all breakfast foods and one of the most nutritionally valuable. They have been cured and smoked in Britain since at least the thirteenth century and remain associated with a serious, quality-conscious approach to breakfast. For clients who grew up eating kippers, they carry very strong nostalgic associations.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Kipper fillets (boil-in-the-bag or fresh)	<i>1 pair</i>
Unsalted butter	<i>15g</i>
Brown bread, thinly sliced	<i>2 slices</i>
Lemon wedge	<i>1</i>
Black pepper	<i>A grind</i>

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- If using boil-in-the-bag kippers, follow the packet instructions: usually 10 minutes in simmering water.

- If using fresh kippers, grill under medium heat for 4-5 minutes each side, or jug them: place in a tall heatproof jug, pour boiling water over, cover and leave for 5 minutes. This reduces the smell significantly.
- Drain and plate. Add a knob of butter on top of the hot kipper.
- Butter the brown bread generously. Serve alongside with the lemon wedge.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 fatty acids: kippers are one of the richest dietary sources of EPA and DHA.
- Vitamin D: one of the highest food sources available.
- Calcium from the edible fine bones.
- Protein: complete and easily absorbed.
- Vitamin B12: very high content.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: one of the most cardioprotective breakfast choices available.
- Bone health: the combination of vitamin D and calcium from the edible bones makes kippers one of the best bone-health breakfast foods.
- Appetite: kippers have an intense distinctive flavour that tends either to be very strongly welcomed or very strongly avoided. Check with the client first.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as cooked with brown bread and butter.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Flake the kipper very carefully, removing all skin and bones, into small pieces under 1.5cm.
5	Minced and moist	Flake very finely and mix with softened butter and lemon juice until cohesive and moist.
4	Puréed	Blend with cream cheese and lemon juice until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Kippers are strongly associated with the serious British breakfast: the kind served in good hotels, at country house weekends, on the morning of an important day.

Presentation tip

Serve on a warmed plate, brown bread and butter on a separate plate. Lemon wedge on the side.

Watch out for

Kippers have a powerful smell when grilled: the jugging method reduces this significantly. Check with the household before grilling. Warn the client about the fine bones.

Make it easier

Boil-in-the-bag kippers are excellent, widely available, and require no equipment beyond a saucepan.

Soft Poached Eggs with Smoked Salmon

Breakfast | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

Softly poached eggs with smoked salmon is one of the most elegant and nourishing of all breakfasts: the richness of the runny yolk over the tender smoked salmon, a few drops of lemon, and a grind of black pepper. It is associated with hotel breakfasts and special mornings. Made at home it signals that the carer is making an effort, which is itself a gesture of care.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Very fresh eggs	2 eggs
Good smoked salmon slices	60g
White wine vinegar	1 tsp
White or brown bread, toasted	1 slice
Unsalted butter	A knob
Lemon wedge	1
Black pepper	A grind
Fresh chives or dill	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Bring a medium saucepan of water to a gentle simmer. Add the vinegar.
- Crack each egg into a small cup. Create a gentle swirl in the water with a spoon.
- Slide the egg in gently from the cup. Poach for 3-4 minutes until the white is just set and the yolk remains runny. Remove with a slotted spoon and drain on kitchen paper.
- Toast and butter the bread. Arrange the smoked salmon on top.
- Place the poached eggs over the smoked salmon. Season with black pepper, add a squeeze of lemon, and scatter over the chives or dill.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 from the smoked salmon: supports brain and heart health.
- Complete protein from both the egg and salmon.
- Vitamin D from both the eggs and the salmon.
- Choline from the egg yolks: critical for brain health.
- Vitamin B12 from the salmon.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: a low-saturated-fat breakfast of real nutritional quality.
- Bone health: vitamin D from both fish and egg, with calcium from the bread.
- Appetite: a beautiful dish that looks considered and special. The running yolk provides both visual pleasure and a natural sauce.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. The running yolk naturally sauces everything.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Flake the salmon into small pieces. Chop the egg white small. Let the yolk run over everything.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Poached eggs with smoked salmon is associated with hotel breakfasts, Sunday morning treats, and the kind of careful cooking that says someone has made an effort.

Presentation tip

Toast on the plate, salmon draped over, poached eggs on top. A few chives, a wedge of lemon. Simple, elegant.

Watch out for

Eggs must be very fresh for poaching; older eggs spread in the water. Smoked salmon is high in sodium: limit for clients with hypertension.

Make it easier

The poaching technique takes a little practice. A non-stick egg poaching pan simplifies it entirely for daily use.



Chapter 17

Snacks & Finger Foods

Small bites, big nourishment

Cheese and Herb Scones

Snacks and finger foods | Makes 6-8 scones | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A warm, freshly baked cheese scone is one of the most comforting of all British baked goods: light, savoury, and deeply satisfying. They are quick to make, keep well, and can be eaten at any time of day. In a care kitchen they serve as a substantial and nutritious snack that can be eaten without cutlery and without effort.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Self-raising flour	225g
Salt	A pinch
English mustard powder	0.5 tsp
Unsalted butter, cold and diced	50g
Mature cheddar, grated	100g
Fresh chives or thyme, chopped	1 tbsp
Full-fat milk	130ml approximately
Egg, beaten (for glaze)	1 egg

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 220°C / 200°C fan / Gas 7.

- Combine the flour, salt, and mustard powder. Rub in the cold butter until the mixture resembles coarse breadcrumbs.
- Stir in most of the cheese and the herbs.
- Add enough milk to bring the dough together into a soft, slightly sticky dough. Do not overwork.
- Turn onto a floured surface and pat to 2-3cm thickness. Cut with a round cutter.
- Place on a baking tray. Brush with beaten egg. Scatter remaining cheese on top.
- Bake for 12-15 minutes until well-risen and golden. Eat warm.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cheese and milk: excellent for bone density.
- Protein from the cheese and egg.
- Carbohydrate from the flour: sustained energy.
- B vitamins from the cheese.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the cheese provides substantial calcium.
- Appetite: a warm cheese scone is irresistible to most clients. The smell of baking is itself an appetite stimulant.
- Dementia: scones are associated strongly with afternoon tea and the kind of domestic baking that characterised the British kitchen.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve warm with a little butter. They soften as they cool.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Allow to cool slightly. Butter generously and cut into small pieces. The scone softens naturally with butter.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Cheese scones fresh from the oven are one of those things that make a kitchen feel like a home. The smell of baking bread or scones is one of the most powerful positive sensory triggers in a care setting.

Presentation tip

Serve warm on a small plate with a little butter alongside. Do not refrigerate: they dry out quickly and are best eaten within an hour of baking.

Watch out for

Do not overwork the dough or the scones will be tough. Gluten in the flour: not appropriate for clients with coeliac disease without a gluten-free substitute.

Make it easier

The dry ingredients can be combined ahead. Add the butter and milk when needed. Bake fresh for maximum impact.

Shortbread Fingers

Snacks and finger foods | Makes 12-16 fingers | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Proper shortbread, made with nothing more than butter, flour, and sugar, is one of the most distinctively Scottish and British of all biscuits: crumbly, buttery, and deeply satisfying. It is associated strongly with Scotland, Christmas, and the kind of careful domestic baking that many elderly clients will remember from their own kitchens. It keeps exceptionally well and provides a reliable, calorie-dense snack.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Unsalted butter, softened	150g
Icing sugar, sifted	75g
Plain flour	225g
Cornflour	75g
A pinch of salt	

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 160°C / 140°C fan / Gas 3.

- Beat the softened butter and icing sugar together until pale and creamy.
- Sift the flour, cornflour, and salt together. Add to the butter mixture and bring together into a soft dough. Do not overwork.
- Press the dough into a lined baking tin approximately 1cm deep, or roll and cut into fingers.

- Prick all over with a fork. Refrigerate for 15 minutes.
- Bake for 18-22 minutes until pale golden. Do not allow to colour.
- Cut into fingers while still warm. Dust with icing sugar if desired. Cool completely on a wire rack.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Significant calories from the butter: valuable for clients at risk of malnutrition.
- Carbohydrate from the flour.
- Fat-soluble vitamins from the butter.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: shortbread is one of those snacks that most clients will eat even when their appetite is very poor. Small, not too sweet, and of a melting texture.
- Dementia: shortbread is associated strongly with Scotland, Christmas, and a tradition of domestic baking.
- Bone health: the butter provides fat-soluble vitamins.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made. Shortbread is naturally quite hard: ensure the client can manage it safely.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Allow to soften naturally at room temperature or dip briefly in warm custard to soften. Break into very small pieces.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Shortbread has an almost universal nostalgic resonance in British and particularly Scottish culture. It is associated with Christmas boxes, holiday tins, and a kind of careful domestic tradition.

Presentation tip

Serve on a small plate, dusted with icing sugar. Beside a cup of tea, it is one of the most British of all small pleasures.

Watch out for

Shortbread is hard when cold: check that the client can manage the texture safely. For clients with dental difficulties, warm slightly to soften or serve alongside something moist.

Make it easier

Shortbread keeps in an airtight tin for up to 2 weeks. Make a large batch at the start of the week.

Mini Quiches

Snacks and finger foods | Makes 4-6 mini quiches | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Mini quiches are among the most versatile and useful items in a care kitchen snack repertoire: savoury, sustaining, portable, and adaptable to whatever filling ingredients are available. The quiche lorraine, with bacon and cheese, is the most familiar version in Britain. They are ideal finger food for clients who struggle with cutlery.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Ready-made shortcrust pastry	200g
Eggs	2 eggs
Double cream	100ml
Full-fat milk	50ml
Mature cheddar, grated	50g
Back bacon, cooked and chopped (or any filling)	2 rashers
Salt, white pepper and nutmeg	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Roll the pastry thinly and cut into circles. Line small greased tartlet tins or a muffin tin. Prick the bases.

- Blind bake for 8-10 minutes until the pastry is just set.
- Whisk the eggs, cream, and milk together. Season with salt, pepper, and nutmeg.
- Divide the bacon and most of the cheese between the pastry cases.
- Pour the egg mixture over the filling, to just below the top of the pastry.
- Scatter remaining cheese on top. Bake for 15-18 minutes until the filling is just set and golden.
- Allow to cool slightly before serving warm or at room temperature.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cheese and cream.
- Protein from the eggs, cheese, and bacon.
- Fat from the cream and pastry: significant calories.
- B vitamins from the eggs.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the cheese and cream provide substantial calcium.
- Appetite: mini quiches are visually appealing, individually portioned, and require no cutlery. Very effective as a mid-morning or mid-afternoon snack.
- Dementia: quiche is a thoroughly familiar element of the British light meal and buffet table.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve warm or at room temperature. The filling should be set and tender.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Remove the pastry case. Serve the soft egg filling only in small pieces. Ensure the filling is very moist.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Quiche became fashionable in Britain from the 1970s onwards through the influence of French cooking. It has been a fixture of the British buffet table and picnic hamper ever since.

Presentation tip

Serve warm on a small plate. Two or three mini quiches alongside a small green salad make a proper light lunch.

Watch out for

The filling must be properly set before serving: a runny centre is both unpleasant and a food safety concern. High in sodium from the bacon: reduce the bacon proportion for clients with hypertension.

Make it easier

Ready-made shortcrust pastry makes this much faster. The quiches keep in the fridge for 2 days and can be reheated gently.

Warm Milk with Honey and Nutmeg

Snacks and finger foods | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 1

AT A GLANCE
Prep 2 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A cup of warm milk with honey and nutmeg is one of the oldest and most gentle of British bedtime and comfort drinks. It has been recommended for sleeplessness, anxiety, and general wellbeing for centuries. In a care setting it is particularly valuable: it provides calories and calcium in a completely frictionless form, suitable for even the most restricted IDDSI profiles, and it signals care and attentiveness.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Full-fat milk	200ml
Good honey	1-2 tsp
Ground nutmeg	A small pinch
Vanilla extract (optional)	A drop

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Pour the milk into a small saucepan. Warm over a gentle heat, stirring, until just below simmering. Do not boil.
- Add the honey and stir until dissolved.
- Pour into a warmed cup or mug. Add the nutmeg and vanilla if using.

- Serve at a comfortable temperature. Test on the wrist before serving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk: a reliable daily contribution to bone density.
- Protein from the milk.
- Vitamin D from the milk if fortified.
- Tryptophan from the milk: a precursor to serotonin and melatonin, associated with relaxation and sleep.
- Natural sugars from the honey: provide a gentle energy boost.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: warm milk provides calcium in a completely frictionless, easily absorbed form.
- Dementia: warm milk with honey is associated with bedtime routines and being cared for. A powerful comfort trigger.
- Appetite: for clients who have eaten very little, a cup of warm milk with honey provides meaningful calories with no effort required.
- Dysphagia: at IDDSI Level 1 this is suitable for virtually all swallowing profiles. Always check the care plan.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
1	Thin liquid	Serve as made. Ensure completely smooth with no honey lumps. Suitable for thin fluid IDDSI profiles.
2	Slightly thick	Add a small measured amount of prescribed thickening agent if required.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Warm milk with honey is one of the most ancient of all comfort drinks. It is associated universally with being looked after: a sick day in bed, a sleepless night, a difficult day. Offering it to a client is itself a gesture of care that most will appreciate.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed mug or cup. A small pinch of nutmeg on the surface, visible. Check the temperature carefully before handing to the client.

Watch out for

Do not overheat the milk: it should be warm and comforting, not scalding. Check the temperature on your wrist before serving. Honey should not be given to children under 1 year old but is safe for elderly clients.

Make it easier

Takes less than 5 minutes. Keep a jar of good honey in the kitchen at all times for this purpose.

Soft Cheese and Cracker Bites

Snacks and finger foods | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Parkinson's

ABOUT THIS DISH

A plate of soft cream cheese, good butter biscuits, and a few well-chosen accompaniments is one of the simplest and most nutritious of all snacks. It requires no cooking, takes 5 minutes, and provides meaningful protein, calcium, and calories. For clients who are not hungry enough for a meal, a small plate of cheese and crackers offered with care and attention can make a significant nutritional contribution.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Full-fat cream cheese or soft mild cheese	50g
Good quality crackers or oatcakes	4-5
Cucumber, thinly sliced	A few slices
Cherry tomatoes	A few
Good chutney or pickle (optional)	A small amount
Fresh chives or dill (optional)	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Remove the cream cheese from the fridge 10 minutes before serving: it spreads much more easily at room temperature.

- Arrange the crackers on a small plate.
- Place the cream cheese in a small bowl or spread it onto the crackers.
- Add the cucumber, cherry tomatoes, and chutney alongside.
- Scatter chives or dill over the cream cheese if using.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cream cheese: important for bone density.
- Protein from the cream cheese.
- Significant calories: cream cheese is calorie-dense and an effective snack for clients at risk of malnutrition.
- Vitamin C from the tomato and cucumber.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: cream cheese provides substantial calcium in a palatable and easy form.
- Appetite: a small plate of cheese and crackers requires no cutlery, no preparation effort from the client, and is generally well-received even by clients with very poor appetite.
- Dementia: cheese and crackers is associated with a certain style of British social life: drinks parties, evening snacks, the kind of informal hospitality that was a feature of mid-twentieth century British domestic life.
- Parkinson's: finger food requiring no cutlery. The cream cheese can be pre-spread on the crackers.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as assembled with whole crackers.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use soft oatcakes rather than harder crackers. Pre-spread with cream cheese and cut into small pieces.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Cheese and crackers at the end of a meal or as an afternoon snack is thoroughly British. For clients from a certain background, a proper cheese board with biscuits was a staple of social life.

Presentation tip

Arrange neatly on a small plate. The cream cheese in a small bowl, the crackers fanned alongside, the cucumber and tomatoes adding colour.

Watch out for

Crackers can be a choking risk for clients with swallowing difficulties: substitute with soft oatcakes or very soft bread for clients at IDDSI Level 6.

Make it easier

No cooking required. 5 minutes from start to finish. Keep cream cheese and crackers stocked as standard kitchen items.



Chapter 18

Puddings & Desserts

The great pleasures of the British pudding table

Rice Pudding

Puddings and desserts | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 1 hr 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Rice pudding is one of the oldest and most comforting of all British puddings: short-grain rice cooked slowly in whole milk until creamy and soft, with a golden skin forming on top. It has been made in Britain since at least the seventeenth century. For elderly clients, a bowl of warm rice pudding represents a depth of comfort and familiarity that very few other dishes can match.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Short-grain pudding rice	40g
Full-fat milk	400ml
Double cream	50ml
Caster sugar	2 tbsp
Vanilla extract	0.5 tsp
Unsalted butter	A small knob
Ground nutmeg for the top	A pinch
Jam or stewed fruit to serve	Optional

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 150°C / 130°C fan / Gas 2.

- Butter a small ovenproof dish generously.

- Combine the rice, milk, cream, sugar, and vanilla in the dish. Stir well.
- Grate a little nutmeg across the top.
- Bake for 1 hour 30 minutes, stirring once after 30 minutes, until the rice is completely tender and creamy with a golden skin on top.
- Serve warm, as it is or with a spoonful of good jam or stewed fruit.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk and cream: excellent for bone density.
- Protein from the milk.
- Carbohydrate from the rice: sustained energy.
- Significant calories from the cream and milk.
- Vitamin D from the milk if fortified.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: one of the best pudding sources of calcium in the book.
- Appetite: warm rice pudding is almost universally accepted even by clients with very poor appetite.
- Dementia: one of the most deeply nostalgic of all British puddings, associated with childhood and being looked after.
- Dysphagia: at IDDSI Level 4 when blended, rice pudding is one of the most appropriate puddings for clients with swallowing difficulties.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend the finished rice pudding until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve. Adjust consistency with extra warm milk.
5	Minced and moist	The well-cooked rice is naturally soft. Stir vigorously. Should be cohesive and moist throughout.
7	Regular	Serve as baked with the golden skin intact for clients who enjoy it.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Rice pudding is the pudding of earliest childhood for most British clients: school dinner rice pudding, grandmother's rice pudding. Simply making it and placing it on the table tends to produce an immediate warm response.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed bowl, the golden skin intact if the client enjoys it. A small spoonful of raspberry jam in the centre. Serve warm but not scalding.

Watch out for

Serve warm rather than hot: it retains heat intensely. Ensure rice is completely cooked through before serving. For dysphagia clients, ensure the blended version has no residual grains.

Make it easier

Make a large batch on a weekend morning. Reheat gently with a splash of extra milk, stirring to restore its creaminess.

Fruit Crumble with Custard

Puddings and desserts | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

The fruit crumble was born in the British wartime kitchen as a simpler, less fat-intensive alternative to the pie. It is now one of the most beloved of all British puddings: tender fruit beneath a golden buttery crumble topping, served with proper custard. It can be made with almost any fruit and is one of the most adaptable puddings in the book.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooking apples or mixed fruit	300g
Caster or soft brown sugar (for the fruit)	2-3 tbsp
Plain flour	100g
Unsalted butter, cold and diced	50g
Demerara sugar (for the crumble)	50g
Rolled oats (optional)	30g
Ground cinnamon (optional)	0.5 tsp
Custard, cream, or ice cream to serve	As desired

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan / Gas 5.

- Place the fruit in a small ovenproof dish. Toss with the sugar and a tablespoon of water.
- Make the crumble: rub the cold butter into the flour until the mixture resembles coarse breadcrumbs. Stir in the demerara sugar, oats if using, and cinnamon.
- Spread the crumble evenly over the fruit, pressing down gently.
- Bake for 30-35 minutes until golden and the fruit is bubbling at the edges.
- Rest for 5 minutes before serving with custard, cream, or ice cream.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Fibre from the fruit and oats: supports digestive health. • Vitamin C from the fruit. • Calories from the butter and sugar: important for clients needing enrichment.	Good for these conditions • Bone health: serve with custard for calcium and vitamin D. • Appetite: the smell of a crumble baking is one of the most appetising of all kitchen aromas. • Dementia: fruit crumble is associated with the domestic British kitchen across all backgrounds and generations.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked with custard.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Remove the crumble topping. Serve the stewed fruit in small pieces under 1.5cm. Add custard to moisten.
5	Minced and moist	Blend or mash the fruit until soft and cohesive. No crumble topping. Serve with poured custard.
4	Puréed	Blend the stewed fruit until completely smooth. Pass through a sieve. Serve with smooth custard separately.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Apple crumble is perhaps the single most nostalgically resonant of all British puddings. Ask the client what fruit they prefer: this question tends to produce an enthusiastic answer.
Presentation tip Serve in a wide bowl with a generous amount of custard poured alongside or over.

Watch out for

The fruit must be cooked through before serving. For clients who cannot manage the crumble topping, remove it before serving.

Make it easier

The crumble topping can be made in large batches and frozen. Scatter frozen directly onto prepared fruit and bake.

Bread and Butter Pudding

Puddings and desserts | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Bread and butter pudding is the consummate British thrift pudding: stale bread, butter, custard, and dried fruit baked together until golden and yielding. Made with good bread, proper custard, and generous butter, it is in a completely different category from the institutional version. One of the easiest puddings in the book and one of the best.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
White bread, slightly stale, crusts optional	3-4 thick slices
Unsalted butter, softened	30g
Sultanas or raisins	40g
Full-fat milk	150ml
Double cream	150ml
Eggs	2 large eggs
Caster sugar	40g
Vanilla extract	0.5 tsp
Ground nutmeg	A grating
Demerara sugar for the top	1 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 170°C / 150°C fan / Gas 3.

- Butter the bread generously on both sides. Cut into triangles or squares.
- Arrange half the bread in a buttered small ovenproof dish. Scatter over the dried fruit. Layer the remaining bread on top.
- Whisk together the milk, cream, eggs, caster sugar, and vanilla. Pour slowly over the bread. Press down gently to absorb the custard. Leave to soak for at least 15 minutes.
- Scatter the demerara sugar over the top. Grate nutmeg generously over the surface.
- Bake for 30-35 minutes until the top is golden and the custard is just set with a faint wobble. Rest for 5 minutes before serving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk and cream.
- Protein from the eggs and dairy.
- Significant calories from the cream and butter.
- Iron from the dried fruit.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: milk, cream, and eggs all contribute calcium and vitamin D.
- Appetite: one of the most effective puddings for encouraging a client with poor appetite to eat.
- Dementia: strongly associated with the British kitchen across all social backgrounds and generations.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as baked with the golden top intact.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Remove the golden top crust. Serve the soft custard-soaked interior in small pieces under 1.5cm.
5	Minced and moist	Remove all crusts before baking. Serve the very soft custard-soaked bread in small pieces.
4	Puréed	Blend the soaked bread and custard portion until completely smooth. Pass through a sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Bread and butter pudding is one of those dishes that almost every client will have a memory of. The smell during baking is one of the most powerfully evocative of any pudding in this book.

Presentation tip

Serve in the dish it was baked in. The golden top should be presented intact. A jug of cream or custard alongside.

Watch out for

The custard must be poured slowly and the bread given time to absorb it before baking. Do not overbake.

Make it easier

The pudding can be assembled the evening before and refrigerated. Bake fresh the following day.

Lemon Posset

Puddings and desserts | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Lemon posset is one of the most elegant and effortless of British puddings: double cream set with lemon juice, producing a dessert of extraordinary silkiness and clean bright flavour. It has been made in Britain since the medieval period. It requires only three ingredients and no great technique, yet the result looks and tastes like something from a fine restaurant.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Double cream	300ml
Caster sugar	75g
Lemons, zested and juiced	2 lemons
Fresh raspberries or strawberries to serve	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat the cream and sugar together, stirring, until the sugar has dissolved. Bring to a simmer and cook for 3 minutes.
- Remove from the heat. Add the lemon zest and juice and stir well. The cream will begin to thicken slightly.
- Pour into small ramekins or glasses. Allow to cool slightly, then refrigerate for at least 2 hours until set.
- Serve cold with a few fresh berries on top.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Significant calories from the cream: an excellent calorie-enrichment pudding.
- Calcium from the cream.
- Vitamin C from the lemon.
- Fat-soluble vitamins from the cream.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the cream provides calcium and fat-soluble vitamins.
- Appetite: light-tasting despite its calorie density. Effective for clients who find heavier puddings too rich.
- Cancer support: vitamin C from the lemon combined with high-calorie cream makes this a useful pudding for clients needing calorie enrichment.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Lemon posset naturally achieves IDDSI Level 4 when set correctly. It should fall slowly from a spoon and hold its shape briefly.
7	Regular	Serve set and cold, straight from the ramekin.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Lemon posset is both ancient and modern: made in British kitchens for centuries but enjoying a major revival in British restaurants since the 2000s.

Presentation tip

Serve in a small glass or white ramekin. The pale cream-coloured set posset with a few raspberries on top.

Watch out for

The posset must be refrigerated for at least 2 hours to set properly.

Make it easier

Can be made 2 days ahead and kept in the fridge. One of the most efficient puddings to prepare in advance.

Eton Mess

Puddings and desserts | Serves 2 | Summer

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Bone health

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Eton mess is one of the simplest and most celebratory of British summer puddings: crushed meringue, whipped cream, and fresh strawberries combined in a bowl with cheerful abandon. It takes its name from Eton College, where it has been served at the annual cricket match against Harrow since the 1930s. It requires no cooking, comes together in minutes, and produces a pudding of genuine freshness.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Ready-made meringue nests	2 large nests
Double cream	150ml
Ripe strawberries, hulled	150g
Icing sugar	1 tbsp
Vanilla extract	A drop

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Hull the strawberries. Slice most of them, keeping a few whole. Toss with a teaspoon of icing sugar.
- Whip the cream with the remaining icing sugar until it just holds soft peaks. Do not overwhip.
- Roughly crush the meringue into large and small pieces.
- Fold the cream, meringue pieces, and most of the strawberries together gently. Do not overmix.

- Spoon into bowls and top with the reserved whole strawberries.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Vitamin C from the strawberries.
- Calcium from the cream.
- Significant calories from the cream and meringue.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: visually striking and cheerfully presented. The combination of sweet, creamy, and fruity tends to be very well received.
- Bone health: the cream provides calcium.
- Dementia: the bright red strawberries against the white cream and meringue create vivid visual contrast that is engaging for clients with reduced visual contrast sensitivity.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with large meringue pieces.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Crush the meringue to very fine pieces. Dice the strawberries very small. The cream holds everything together.
5	Minced and moist	Use only very finely crushed meringue. Blend the strawberries to a smooth sauce. Fold into whipped cream.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Eton mess has a particular association with the English summer: cricket, garden parties, Wimbledon. For clients who attended such events it carries a specific and pleasant resonance.

Presentation tip

Serve in a wide glass or bowl so the colours are visible. A few whole strawberries on top.

Watch out for

Meringue softens quickly once combined with cream and fruit: do not assemble more than 30 minutes before serving.

Make it easier

Shop-bought meringue is entirely appropriate. Assembly takes 10 minutes.

Spotted Dick with Custard

Puddings and desserts | Serves 4 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 1 hr 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

Spotted dick is one of the most iconically named and affectionately regarded of all British steamed puddings: a suet pudding studded with currants, steamed until soft and yielding, and served with custard. It has been made in British kitchens since the Victorian era. The name itself tends to produce a smile, which is itself a small therapeutic benefit.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Self-raising flour	150g
Shredded suet	75g
Caster sugar	75g
Dried currants	100g
Lemon, zested	1 lemon
Full-fat milk	100ml approximately
Custard to serve	As made in sauces chapter

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Combine the flour, suet, sugar, currants, and lemon zest in a bowl.

- Add enough milk to bring the mixture together into a soft slightly sticky dough.
- Shape into a log. Wrap in greaseproof paper and then foil, twisting the ends to seal.
- Steam for 1 hour 30 minutes in a steamer or in a covered pan with a few centimetres of simmering water. Check the water level regularly.
- Unwrap carefully. Slice and serve with plenty of hot custard.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Carbohydrate and energy from the flour and sugar. • Calcium from the milk. • Iron from the currants. • Calories from the suet: significant for clients needing calorie enrichment.	• Appetite: deeply warming and satisfying. • Dementia: among the most powerfully nostalgic of all British pudding names. Tends to produce a strong warm response. • Bone health: serve with custard for calcium.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Slice and serve with custard.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Slice thinly and break into small pieces under 1.5cm. Moisten generously with custard.
5	Minced and moist	Crumble into very small pieces. Combine with warm custard to form a moist cohesive mixture.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The name alone is sufficient. Spotted dick is one of those dishes that produces laughter, warmth, and memory simultaneously.

Presentation tip

Slice on a board and serve on a warmed plate. A generous amount of custard poured over.

Watch out for

The pudding must be well-wrapped and the steaming water must not run dry. Allow to rest 5 minutes before unwrapping.

Make it easier

Can be made ahead and reheated by steaming for 30 minutes.

Queen of Puddings

Puddings and desserts | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Hard

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Queen of puddings is one of the most architecturally beautiful of all British puddings: a baked breadcrumb custard base topped with jam and then a crown of meringue. It appears in British cookery books from the Victorian era. Making it well requires patience and technique but the result is a pudding that signals exceptional care.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Full-fat milk	300ml
Unsalted butter	20g
Caster sugar	30g
Lemon, zested	Half
Egg yolks	3 yolks
Fresh white breadcrumbs	60g
Good raspberry or strawberry jam	3 tbsp
Egg whites	3 whites
Caster sugar (for meringue)	90g

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 160°C / 140°C fan / Gas 3.

- Heat the milk with the butter, 30g sugar, and lemon zest until just below simmering. Pour over the breadcrumbs. Leave to soak for 10 minutes.
- Beat in the egg yolks. Pour into a small buttered ovenproof dish.
- Bake for 20-25 minutes until just set. Remove and allow to cool slightly.
- Warm the jam and spread carefully over the custard base.
- Whisk the egg whites to stiff peaks. Gradually add the 90g caster sugar, whisking constantly, until the meringue is stiff and glossy.
- Spoon the meringue over the jam layer, spreading to the edges.
- Bake for 15-18 minutes until the meringue is golden and set. Serve warm.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the milk.
- Protein from the eggs.
- Carbohydrate from the breadcrumbs and sugar.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the milk and egg content provides calcium and protein.
- Appetite: arriving at the table with its crown of golden meringue tends to produce genuine pleasure.
- Dementia: associated with the most careful tradition of British domestic pudding-making.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve warm with the meringue crown intact.
5	Minced and moist	Remove the meringue. Serve the soft custard-breadcrumb base with the jam in small pieces.
4	Puréed	Blend the custard base and jam until completely smooth. Pass through a sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Queen of puddings is named for a queen and treats the client accordingly. Serving it is a statement of intention.

Presentation tip

Serve warm in the dish it was baked in. The golden meringue crown is the visual signature.

Watch out for

The meringue must be made with completely clean equipment. Do not let any yolk contaminate the whites. Serve warm.

Make it easier

The custard base can be made ahead. Top with fresh meringue and bake when ready.

Syllabub

Puddings and desserts | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Syllabub is one of the most ancient of all British puddings, known since at least the sixteenth century: cream whipped with wine, sugar, and lemon juice into a light frothy dessert. It fell out of fashion in the twentieth century but has been revived by food historians and chefs. For clients of a certain literary or culinary awareness, it will be a delightful and unexpected discovery.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Double cream	200ml
Sweet sherry, Madeira, or white wine	3 tbsp
Lemon, zested and juiced	Half a lemon
Icing sugar	2-3 tbsp
Shortbread fingers to serve	Optional

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Combine the sherry, lemon juice, and zest in a bowl. Add the icing sugar and stir until dissolved.
- Add the cream and whip together until the mixture holds soft billowy peaks. Do not overwhip.
- Taste: it should be gently sweet, lightly alcoholic, and bright with lemon.
- Spoon into glasses. Refrigerate for 30 minutes before serving.
- Serve with a shortbread finger alongside if desired.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Significant calories from the cream: an excellent calorie-enrichment pudding.
- Calcium from the cream.
- Vitamin C from the lemon.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: light in texture but high in calories. Ideal for clients who struggle to eat much volume but need calorie enrichment.
- Dementia: syllabub represents a tradition of British culinary history that predates almost everything else in this book.
- Cancer support: high-calorie, easy to eat, light in texture and flavour.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Syllabub naturally achieves IDDSI Level 4 when whipped to soft peaks.
7	Regular	Serve as whipped in a glass. Light and frothy.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Syllabub is a discovery pudding: most clients will not have encountered it recently. Tell the client what it is and when it was first made. For clients who appreciate the history of British food, this is a genuinely interesting pudding.

Presentation tip

Serve in a stemmed glass. A twist of lemon peel on top and a shortbread finger resting against the rim.

Watch out for

The cream can be overwhipped easily: stop as soon as it holds soft peaks. For clients who do not consume alcohol, substitute the sherry with sweet apple juice.

Make it easier

Can be made 2 hours ahead and kept in the fridge.



Chapter 19

IDDSI Texture-Modified

Dishes designed from the ground up for modified textures

Smooth Parsnip and Chestnut Soup

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1-2 | Autumn and winter

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

This soup is designed from the ground up for clients at IDDSI Level 4: a completely smooth, velvety bowl of parsnip and chestnut with enough depth of flavour to stand entirely on its own. Parsnips have a natural sweetness and earthiness that pairs beautifully with chestnuts, and the result is a soup of real elegance that requires no apology. It is warming, calorie-dense, and easy to fortify further with cream or butter.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Parsnips, peeled and diced	250g
Cooked chestnuts (vacuum-packed)	80g
Shallot, diced	1 large
Unsalted butter	20g
Good chicken or vegetable stock	400ml
Double cream	60ml
Ground nutmeg	A pinch
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Melt the butter in a saucepan over a medium heat. Cook the shallot for 5 minutes until soft.
- Add the parsnip and chestnuts. Stir to coat. Cook for 3 minutes.
- Add the stock. Bring to a simmer and cook for 20-25 minutes until the parsnip is completely tender.
- Add the cream. Blend until completely smooth using a stick blender or jug blender.
- Pass through a fine sieve, pressing firmly. This step is essential for IDDSI Level 4: any fibrous residue must be removed.
- Return to the pan. Season with salt, white pepper, and nutmeg. Reheat gently. Check consistency: it should fall slowly and steadily from a spoon.
- Serve in a warmed bowl at a safe temperature. Test on your wrist before serving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Fibre from the parsnip and chestnuts: supports digestive health.
- Vitamin C from the parsnips.
- Significant calories from the cream and chestnuts: important for IDDSI clients who often eat less volume.
- Potassium from the parsnips: supports heart health.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: designed specifically for IDDSI Level 4. The fine sieving step is non-negotiable.
- Appetite: the natural sweetness of parsnip and chestnut makes this one of the most appetising soups for clients with reduced taste sensitivity.
- Dementia: warm, sweet, and aromatic. The smell during cooking is inviting and comforting.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made after sieving. Should fall slowly from a spoon and hold shape briefly on a plate. Check with the IDDSI 4 spoon tilt test before serving.
5	Minced and moist	Serve before sieving, blended only. Some texture may remain.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Parsnips are deeply associated with the British winter table: roasted alongside the Sunday joint, mashed with butter, or in a warming soup. For clients, the smell of parsnips cooking tends to produce an immediate and warm response.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed bowl. A small swirl of cream on the surface and a pinch of nutmeg. Nothing that requires chewing should be added as garnish.

Watch out for

Always check the consistency against the IDDSI 4 standard before serving. The sieving step must not be skipped. Serve at a safe temperature: not scalding.

Make it easier

The soup base can be made and sieved ahead. Reheat gently with a splash of extra stock to restore consistency.

Silky Cauliflower Puree with Herb Oil

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 25 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

This is cauliflower at its most elegant: roasted for depth, blended with cream and butter to a silk-smooth puree, and finished with a bright green herb oil that is both visually striking and nutritionally valuable. It demonstrates that IDDSI Level 4 food can be genuinely beautiful. The herb oil is a simple technique from professional kitchens that adds vivid colour and fresh flavour to any smooth dish.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cauliflower, broken into florets	300g
Unsalted butter	30g
Double cream	60ml
Good vegetable or chicken stock	100ml
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Fresh flat-leaf parsley	A large handful
Olive oil (for herb oil)	4 tbsp
Salt (for herb oil)	A pinch

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 200°C / 180°C fan / Gas 6.

- Roast the cauliflower florets with a little olive oil and seasoning for 20-25 minutes until golden at the edges.
- Transfer to a saucepan. Add the butter, cream, and stock. Bring to a simmer for 5 minutes.
- Blend until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve. The puree should be silky with no fibrous residue.
- Season well. Add a little extra cream if needed to achieve correct IDDSI 4 consistency.
- Make the herb oil: blanch the parsley in boiling water for 30 seconds. Drain and squeeze dry. Blend with the olive oil and a pinch of salt until smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.
- Serve the cauliflower puree in a warmed bowl or on a plate. Drizzle the herb oil over the surface.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Vitamin C from both the cauliflower and parsley: supports immune function. • Vitamin K from the parsley: important for bone health. • Calcium from the cream and butter. • Significant calories from the cream, butter, and olive oil: critical for IDDSI clients. • Anti-inflammatory compounds from the olive oil.	• Dysphagia: designed specifically for IDDSI Level 4. Roasting the cauliflower first adds depth without compromising texture. • Bone health: the cream, butter, and parsley all contribute calcium and vitamin K. • Cancer support: cauliflower contains sulforaphane, a compound with well-studied anti-cancer properties. The herb oil adds vitamin C and K.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made, after sieving both the puree and the herb oil. The herb oil must also be smooth: no leaf fragments.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Cauliflower is one of the most familiar British vegetables and a dish of silky cauliflower puree, even unfamiliar in form, tends to be recognised and welcomed immediately on tasting.	Presentation tip This dish should look considered and beautiful. Smooth pale cream puree, a swirl of vivid green herb oil. Even at IDDSI Level 4 the plate should arrive looking like it has been made with care.
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Watch out for

Both the puree and the herb oil must be passed through a fine sieve. The herb oil must contain no leaf fragments. Check consistency before every serving.

Make it easier

Both components can be made ahead and refrigerated. Reheat the puree gently with a splash of stock. The herb oil keeps in the fridge for 3 days.

Smooth Chicken and Leek Bake

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A smooth savoury bake of chicken and leek puree, set in a small ramekin and turned out or served from the dish, demonstrates that a main course at IDDSI Level 4 can have genuine elegance and substance. This dish is inspired by the classic British chicken and leek combination but reimagined entirely for texture-modified requirements.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Cooked chicken thigh meat	120g
Leek, trimmed and sliced	1 medium
Unsalted butter	20g
Good chicken stock	100ml
Double cream	60ml
Egg	1 egg
Fresh thyme	2 sprigs
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 160°C / 140°C fan / Gas 3.

- Cook the leek gently in the butter for 8-10 minutes until completely soft. Season.
- Place the cooked chicken, leek, stock, cream, egg, and thyme leaves in a blender. Blend until completely smooth.
- Pass through a fine sieve. Season well. The mixture should be smooth and slightly pourable.
- Pour into a well-buttered ramekin. Place the ramekin in a deep baking dish. Pour boiling water around it to come halfway up the sides.
- Bake for 25-30 minutes until just set with a very slight wobble in the centre.
- Rest for 5 minutes. Serve in the ramekin or carefully turned out onto a warmed plate. Serve with a smooth sauce alongside.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein from the chicken and egg.
- Calories from the cream and butter.
- Vitamins from the leek: vitamin C, folate, and prebiotic fibre.
- B vitamins from the chicken.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: a complete main course at IDDSI Level 4. The bain-marie cooking method ensures a uniformly smooth, set texture with no hard edges.
- Appetite: the familiar flavour combination of chicken and leek in a smooth, creamy form tends to be very well received.
- Dementia: chicken and leek is one of the most evocative of all British flavour combinations.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made, turned out or from the ramekin. Serve with a smooth sauce at IDDSI 4 consistency alongside to moisten.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Chicken and leek: a combination at the heart of British cookery in soups, pies, and braises. Even in a smooth, modified form, the flavour is immediately recognisable and comforting.

Presentation tip

Turn out carefully onto a warmed white plate. A pool of smooth chicken jus or cream sauce alongside. A few drops of herb oil if available. The presentation should be as considered as any other dish in the book.

Watch out for

The texture must be completely smooth after sieving. Any lumps or fibrous material must be removed. Always serve with a sauce to ensure the dish is adequately moist throughout.

Make it easier

Can be made ahead and refrigerated. Reheat gently in the bain-marie or in a microwave with a small splash of stock.

Smooth Beef and Root Vegetable Casserole

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1 | Autumn and winter

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 2 hrs 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Bone health

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

The flavours of a classic beef stew are deeply embedded in British comfort cooking, and there is no reason why a client at IDDSI Level 4 should be denied them. This smooth beef casserole captures the deep, rich, savoury flavour of a slow-cooked stew in a completely smooth form, enriched with cream and passed to the correct IDDSI standard.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Shin of beef or braising steak, diced	150g
Carrot, diced	1 medium
Parsnip, diced	Half
Brown onion, diced	Half
Beef stock (unsalted if possible)	300ml
Tomato puree	1 tsp
Fresh thyme and bay	2 sprigs, 1 leaf
Double cream	50ml
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Brown the beef in a little oil over a high heat. Add the vegetables, tomato puree, stock, and herbs.
- Bring to a simmer, cover, and cook over a very low heat or in the oven at 150°C for 2-2.5 hours until the beef is completely tender and falling apart.
- Remove the bay leaf and thyme stems. Add the cream.
- Blend in batches until completely smooth.
- Pass through a fine sieve, pressing firmly. Repeat if any fibrous material remains.
- Reheat gently. Check consistency. Season carefully. Serve warm in a deep bowl.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the beef: excellent for muscle maintenance.
- Collagen from the slow-cooked shin: supports joint and bone health.
- Iron and zinc from the beef.
- Vitamins from the root vegetables.
- Calories from the cream.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: the long slow cooking completely breaks down the beef fibres, making it ideal for smooth blending. The result passes through a sieve cleanly.
- Appetite: deep, rich, and unmistakably savoury. The beef and vegetable flavour is comforting and familiar.
- Bone health: collagen from the long cooking and calcium from the cream.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made after double sieving. Should fall slowly from a spoon and hold shape briefly. Check consistency before every serving.
5	Minced and moist	Shred the beef very finely before blending. A less smooth version suitable for Level 5.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Beef stew in any form is one of the deepest nostalgic triggers in British home cooking. Even in a modified form, the flavour immediately signals warmth, winter, and being properly fed.

Presentation tip

Serve in a wide, warmed bowl. A small swirl of cream on the surface, a pinch of fresh thyme if the client can manage it safely as a garnish, otherwise leave plain.

Watch out for

Shin beef is the best cut for this dish as it breaks down completely. Double sieving is important: the first pass removes lumps, the second ensures complete smoothness.

Make it easier

Make a large batch of the base stew. Blend and sieve each individual portion to order. The unblended stew keeps in the fridge for 3 days.

Soft Polenta with Wild Mushroom Sauce

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 10 mins | Cook 25 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

Heart health

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Soft polenta, enriched with butter and parmesan and served with a smooth, intensely flavoured mushroom sauce, is a dish that is genuinely delicious at IDDSI Level 5 without any apology or modification. It is naturally the right consistency when made well, and the depth of the mushroom sauce provides the kind of savoury satisfaction that makes a modified meal feel like a real one.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Fine or instant polenta	60g
Full-fat milk	200ml
Good vegetable or chicken stock	100ml
Unsalted butter	20g
Parmesan, finely grated	20g
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Chestnut mushrooms, very finely diced	100g
Shallot, very finely diced	1 small
Garlic clove, crushed	1 clove
Double cream	3 tbsp
Fresh thyme	2 sprigs

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the mushroom sauce: cook the shallot and garlic in a little butter for 5 minutes. Add the finely diced mushrooms and thyme and cook over high heat until all moisture has evaporated and mushrooms are dark and concentrated.
- Add the cream and simmer for 3-4 minutes until the sauce coats a spoon. Season. For IDDSI Level 5, ensure no mushroom pieces exceed 4mm.
- Make the polenta: bring the milk and stock to a simmer. Whisk in the polenta gradually. Cook, stirring constantly, for 5-8 minutes until thick and smooth.
- Remove from the heat. Beat in the butter and parmesan. Season generously. The polenta should be soft and flowing, not stiff.
- Serve the polenta in a warmed bowl. Spoon the mushroom sauce into the centre.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Carbohydrate from the polenta: sustained energy release.
- Calcium from the milk and parmesan.
- Protein from the parmesan and cream.
- Beta-glucans from the mushrooms: supports immune function.
- Significant calories: important for IDDSI clients who often eat less volume.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: polenta is a naturally appropriate base for IDDSI Level 5. The mushroom sauce must be checked to ensure no pieces exceed 4mm.
- Appetite: the rich, earthy flavour of the mushroom sauce over soft polenta is deeply satisfying.
- Heart health: mushrooms provide beta-glucan fibre. The olive oil in the sauce adds monounsaturated fat.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
5	Minced and moist	Serve as made. Check that the mushroom sauce contains no pieces over 4mm. The polenta is naturally at IDDSI Level 5 consistency.
4	Puréed	Blend the mushroom sauce until completely smooth. Pass through a sieve. The polenta is naturally smooth.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Polenta arrived in British kitchens through Italian influence from the 1980s onwards. For clients who cooked with interest, it will be familiar. Its soft, yielding, almost porridge-like quality also resonates with British porridge culture.

Presentation tip

Serve in a wide, warmed bowl. The pale yellow polenta as the base, the dark mushroom sauce poured into the centre. Simple and elegant.

Watch out for

Polenta thickens considerably as it cools: serve immediately. The mushroom sauce must be checked for piece size before serving. The parmesan must be very finely grated or it will not melt fully into the polenta.

Make it easier

Instant polenta takes 5 minutes rather than 40. The mushroom sauce can be made ahead and reheated. Check consistency again after reheating.

Smooth Pea and Mint Soup

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1-2 | Spring and summer

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 10 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A vivid, bright green pea and mint soup is one of the most visually striking dishes in a modified kitchen and one of the quickest to make. It uses frozen peas, which are actually nutritionally superior to fresh in most seasons, and the result is a soup of real freshness and colour that is naturally appropriate for IDDSI Level 4 after sieving.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Frozen peas	250g
Good vegetable or chicken stock, hot	300ml
Fresh mint leaves	8-10 leaves
Unsalted butter	15g
Double cream	3 tbsp
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Cook the peas in the hot stock for 3-4 minutes until just tender. Do not overcook or the bright green colour will be lost.

- Add the mint leaves and the cream.
- Blend immediately until completely smooth.
- Pass through a fine sieve, pressing firmly. The colour should be a vivid, bright green.
- Season carefully with salt and white pepper. Reheat gently if needed.
- Serve in a warmed bowl at a safe temperature.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Protein from the peas: one of the best plant sources.
- Fibre from the peas: supports digestive health.
- Vitamin C: peas are a good source, and frozen peas often retain more than fresh.
- Folate: peas are one of the richest dietary sources.
- Calories from the cream: important for IDDSI clients.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: designed for IDDSI Level 4. The sieving step removes the pea skins which can cause issues at this level.
- Heart health: peas provide plant protein and fibre. A naturally low-fat dish.
- Appetite: the vivid green colour is one of the most visually stimulating of any soup in this book. Colour matters enormously in modified eating.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made after sieving. The vivid green colour should be preserved. Check consistency before serving.
3	Liquidised	Thin with extra warm stock until the soup flows freely. Check against IDDSI Level 3 standards.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Pea soup is one of the oldest British soups, known since medieval times. The fresh green version became fashionable in the 1970s and 80s and is widely recognised. The bright colour tends to produce an immediate positive response.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed white bowl so the vivid green is fully visible. A small swirl of cream on the surface and a single mint leaf if safe to use as garnish.

Watch out for

Do not overcook the peas or the colour will turn khaki. Blend and sieve immediately after cooking. The mint must be added before blending, not after, or it will not incorporate smoothly.

Make it easier

This is one of the fastest soups in the book: 10 minutes from start to finish. Keep frozen peas in the freezer at all times for this purpose.

Smoked Salmon Mousse

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 0 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Bone health

Dysphagia

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

A smoked salmon mousse is one of the most elegant dishes available at IDDSI Level 4: smooth, rich, deeply flavoured, and served cold in a small ramekin. It is naturally appropriate in consistency and requires no cooking. It can be served as a starter or as a light main course and signals real quality on the plate.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Smoked salmon	100g
Full-fat cream cheese	80g
Double cream	3 tbsp
Lemon juice	1 tbsp
Fresh dill (optional)	A little
White pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Place the smoked salmon, cream cheese, cream, and lemon juice in a food processor.
- Blend until completely smooth. Add the dill if using.
- Pass through a fine sieve for the smoothest result.
- Season with white pepper. Taste and adjust lemon juice.

- Spoon into small ramekins. Refrigerate for 30 minutes to firm slightly.
- Serve cold or at room temperature.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Omega-3 fatty acids from the smoked salmon: one of the richest dietary sources.
- Protein from the salmon and cream cheese.
- Calcium from the cream cheese.
- Vitamin D from the salmon.
- Calories from the cream and cream cheese: valuable for IDDSI clients.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: naturally appropriate at IDDSI Level 4. No cooking required. Passes easily through a sieve.
- Heart health: omega-3 from the smoked salmon is strongly cardioprotective.
- Bone health: vitamin D from the salmon and calcium from the cream cheese.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made after sieving. The mousse should hold its shape briefly in a ramekin and fall slowly from a spoon.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Smoked salmon in any form is associated with occasion and generosity. Serving a beautifully presented smoked salmon mousse to a client at IDDSI Level 4 signals that the same care and quality is being applied to their meal as to anyone else at the table.

Presentation tip

Serve in a small white ramekin with a small swirl of cream on top and a few drops of herb oil if available. The pale pink against white is naturally elegant.

Watch out for

Smoked salmon is very high in sodium: limit for clients with hypertension or CKD. Check for fish allergy. The mousse must be kept refrigerated until serving.

Make it easier

Takes 15 minutes including sieving. Can be made up to 2 days ahead and kept refrigerated.

Vanilla Panna Cotta with Berry Coulis

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Panna cotta is one of the most naturally appropriate puddings for IDDSI Level 4: set cream of a silky, smooth, melting consistency that requires no chewing and is consistently pleasant to eat. Served with a smooth fruit coulis it becomes a pudding of real elegance. The name translates as 'cooked cream' from Italian and it has been a staple of good British restaurants since the 1990s.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Double cream	200ml
Full-fat milk	100ml
Caster sugar	40g
Vanilla extract or vanilla pod	1 tsp or half a pod
Leaf gelatine	2 leaves (approx 4g)
Fresh or frozen raspberries or strawberries	100g
Icing sugar (for coulis)	1-2 tbsp
Lemon juice (for coulis)	A squeeze

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Soak the gelatine leaves in cold water for 5 minutes until soft.
- Heat the cream, milk, sugar, and vanilla together until just below simmering. Do not boil.
- Squeeze the water from the gelatine leaves and stir into the hot cream until completely dissolved.
- Strain through a fine sieve into lightly oiled small moulds or ramekins.
- Refrigerate for at least 3 hours until set.
- Make the coulis: blend the berries with icing sugar and lemon juice until smooth. Pass through a fine sieve to remove all seeds.
- To serve, turn out the panna cotta onto a plate or serve in the ramekin. Spoon the coulis alongside.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the cream and milk: important for bone density.
- Significant calories from the cream: valuable for IDDSI clients who often eat less volume.
- Vitamin C from the berry coulis.
- Antioxidants from the berries: associated with reduced cancer risk.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: naturally appropriate at IDDSI Level 4 when set correctly. The gelatine provides a soft, smooth set that melts in the mouth.
- Bone health: cream and milk provide substantial calcium.
- Cancer support: antioxidants from the berry coulis and the calcium from the dairy are both relevant in cancer care.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Panna cotta is naturally IDDSI Level 4 when set to the correct consistency. It should hold its shape briefly when turned out and melt on the tongue.
3	Liquidised	Use slightly less gelatine (1.5 leaves) to produce a softer, more flowing set.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Panna cotta became fashionable in British restaurants from the 1990s onwards. For clients who dined out regularly during this period, it will be immediately familiar and associated with good restaurants.

Presentation tip

Turn out onto a white plate. The pale cream panna cotta with the vivid berry coulis alongside is one of the most beautiful presentations in this chapter. Even at IDDSI Level 4 the plate should look considered.

Watch out for

The gelatine must be fully dissolved or the panna cotta will have an uneven set. The coulis must be sieved completely smooth: all berry seeds must be removed as these are a texture risk at IDDSI Level 4.

Make it easier

Panna cotta must be made ahead: it needs at least 3 hours to set. An ideal make-ahead pudding for a planned occasion.

Smooth Rice Pudding with Mango Coulis

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1-2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 5 mins | Cook 1 hr 30 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

The classic rice pudding of the puddings chapter can be transformed into a perfect IDDSI Level 4 dish with one additional step: blending and sieving after cooking. The result is a silky, smooth pudding with all the familiar comforting flavour, served with a vivid mango coulis that adds colour, sweetness, and vitamin C. It demonstrates that modified puddings can be genuinely special.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Short-grain pudding rice	40g
Full-fat milk	400ml
Double cream	50ml
Caster sugar	2 tbs
Vanilla extract	0.5 tsp
Ripe mango, peeled and diced, or tinned mango	100g
Icing sugar (for coulis)	1 tsp
Lemon juice (for coulis)	A squeeze

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 150°C / 130°C fan / Gas 2.

- Make the rice pudding as per the standard recipe: combine rice, milk, cream, sugar, and vanilla in a buttered dish. Bake for 1 hour 30 minutes until completely tender.
- Transfer the cooked rice pudding to a blender while warm. Blend until completely smooth.
- Pass through a fine sieve. The result should be completely smooth with no grain texture. If any grains remain, blend again and sieve again.
- Season with a little extra sugar or vanilla to taste.
- Make the coulis: blend the mango with icing sugar and lemon juice until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.
- Serve the smooth rice pudding warm in a bowl with the mango coulis drizzled over.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Calcium from the milk and cream. • Carbohydrate from the rice: sustained energy. • Vitamin C from the mango coulis. • Beta-carotene from the mango: a powerful antioxidant. • Significant calories: valuable for IDDSI clients.	• Dysphagia: smooth rice pudding after sieving is one of the most appropriate and accepted IDDSI Level 4 puddings. • Bone health: milk and cream provide excellent calcium. • Dementia: the familiar flavour of rice pudding in a smooth form is comforting and deeply recognisable.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Serve as made after double sieving to ensure no grains remain. The mango coulis must also be completely smooth and seed-free.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Rice pudding in any form is one of the most universally nostalgic of all British puddings. Even in its smooth, modified form the flavour is immediately comforting and familiar.
Presentation tip Serve in a warmed white bowl. The pale cream rice pudding with the vivid orange mango coulis drizzled over is visually striking and beautiful.
Watch out for

Sieve the rice pudding twice if necessary: grains must be completely removed for IDDSI Level 4. The mango coulis must be completely smooth. Check the temperature carefully before serving.

Make it easier

The rice pudding can be made ahead and blended when needed. Reheat gently with a splash of extra milk. The mango coulis keeps in the fridge for 3 days.

Soft Scrambled Egg with Cream Cheese

IDDSI texture-modified | Serves 1 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 5

AT A GLANCE
Prep 3 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dysphagia

Dementia

Parkinson's

ABOUT THIS DISH

Softly scrambled eggs enriched with cream cheese produce a naturally appropriate IDDSI Level 5 dish of real nutritional value and great palatability. This technique goes beyond standard scrambled eggs to achieve a consistently smooth, moist result that is easy to eat, high in protein, and genuinely enjoyable.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Eggs	2 large eggs
Full-fat cream cheese	30g
Unsalted butter	10g
Salt and white pepper	To taste
Fresh chives (optional)	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Beat the eggs with the cream cheese until completely combined and smooth.
- Melt the butter in a small non-stick pan over the very lowest heat.
- Add the egg mixture. Stir constantly with a rubber spatula, scraping the base.

- Cook very slowly for 4-5 minutes until just set, very soft, and still glossy. Remove immediately from the heat while still slightly underdone.
- Season with salt and white pepper. Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete protein from both the eggs and cream cheese.
- Calcium from the cream cheese.
- Choline from the egg yolks: critical for brain health.
- Vitamin D from the eggs.
- Significant calories from the cream cheese and butter.

Good for these conditions

- Dysphagia: naturally appropriate at IDDSI Level 5. The cream cheese ensures the eggs remain moist and cohesive throughout.
- Appetite: soft scrambled eggs with cream cheese are one of the most accepted foods at any level of appetite difficulty.
- Dementia: familiar, comforting, and immediately recognisable.
- Parkinson's: a high-quality protein meal that requires no cutting or significant chewing effort.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
5	Minced and moist	Serve as made. The eggs should be very soft, moist, and cohesive. No dry or rubbery pieces.
4	Puréed	Blend the finished scrambled egg with extra cream cheese and a little cream until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Scrambled eggs are one of the most universally comforting of all British foods. Made with cream cheese they become something slightly special: richer, creamier, and more satisfying.

Presentation tip

Serve in a warmed ramekin or small bowl. A few snipped chives on top if the client can manage them safely. Nothing that requires effort to eat.

Watch out for

Remove from the heat while slightly underdone: residual heat will finish the cooking. Overcooked scrambled eggs are rubbery and dry, which is both unpleasant and dangerous at IDDSI Level 5.

Make it easier

5 minutes from start to finish. One of the fastest and most reliable IDDSI Level 5 dishes in the book.



Chapter 20

Batch Cooking

Cook once, nourish all week

Master Batch Chicken Stock

Batch cooking | Makes 3-4 litres | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 1

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 3 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

The foundation of a batch cooking week is a large quantity of good stock. Made from roasted carcasses and aromatics, this batch stock forms the base of every soup, braise, sauce, and risotto in the week ahead. Making it once on a Sunday and freezing in measured portions is the single most impactful habit a carer can establish.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Chicken carcasses from roasts, or raw chicken wings	2-3 carcasses / 1kg wings
Brown onions, quartered	2
Carrots, broken	2 large
Celery sticks	4 sticks
Leek, sliced	1
Bay leaves	3
Black peppercorns	12
Thyme and parsley stalks	Several sprigs
Cold water	4 litres

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- If using carcasses, roast them at 200°C for 20-25 minutes until golden for a deeper flavour.
- Place all ingredients in the largest pot you have. Cover with cold water.
- Bring very slowly to a gentle simmer. Skim the foam that rises in the first 30 minutes.
- Simmer gently, uncovered, for 2.5-3 hours. Never let it boil hard.
- Strain through a fine sieve. Press on the solids. Cool completely.
- Refrigerate. Skim off the solidified fat. Portion into 300ml and 500ml freezer containers. Label with the date. Freeze for up to 3 months.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Collagen and gelatine: supports gut and joint health.
- Bone minerals: calcium, magnesium, phosphorus extracted from the carcass.
- Glycine: supports sleep and gut integrity.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the foundation of all the flavourful soups, sauces, and braises that support good appetite throughout the week.
- Dementia: the smell of stock simmering over several hours is one of the most comforting kitchen aromas.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
1	Thin liquid	Serve as a clear broth: thin, warm, and nourishing.
2-3	Slightly thick	Add a prescribed thickening agent, measured precisely.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The stock pot is one of the oldest images in the history of domestic cooking. Establishing it as a weekly habit is both practical and a gesture of genuine culinary seriousness.

Presentation tip

Label containers clearly with date and contents. A good stock should set to a soft jelly when refrigerated: a sign of quality.

Watch out for

Never boil hard. Never add salt before the stock has been reduced to its final use. Label clearly with the date: stock is perishable.

Make it easier

A slow cooker is perfect for large batch stock. Fill overnight on low. Strain and portion in the morning.

Batch Bolognese Sauce

Batch cooking | Makes 8-10 portions | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 2 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

A large batch of proper Bolognese sauce, made slowly with good mince, wine, and milk, is one of the most useful things in a care kitchen freezer. It forms the base of pasta dishes, shepherd's pie, stuffed peppers, lasagne, and much more. Made once and frozen in portions, it provides the foundation for 8-10 quick, quality meals.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Beef mince (20% fat)	500g
Pork mince	250g
Brown onions, finely diced	2 large
Carrots, finely diced	2 medium
Celery sticks, finely diced	3 sticks
Garlic cloves, crushed	4 cloves
Tomato puree	2 tbsp
Tinned plum tomatoes	2 x 400g tins
Red wine	200ml
Full-fat milk	100ml
Bay leaves and thyme	2 bay leaves, 4 sprigs
Olive oil	2 tbsp
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Heat olive oil in a large, heavy-based pot. Cook the onion, carrot, and celery over a medium heat for 15 minutes until deeply softened.
- Add the garlic and tomato puree. Cook for 3 minutes.
- Add the beef and pork mince. Cook over high heat, breaking up constantly, until all moisture has evaporated and the meat is deeply caramelised.
- Add the wine and allow to bubble for 5 minutes. Add the milk and stir well.
- Add the tomatoes, herbs, and seasoning. Bring to a gentle simmer.
- Cook uncovered over the lowest possible heat for 1.5-2 hours, stirring occasionally, until rich and thick.
- Cool completely. Portion into individual servings. Refrigerate for up to 4 days or freeze for up to 3 months.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Complete protein from the beef and pork. • Iron and zinc from the red meat. • Lycopene from the cooked tomatoes: associated with reduced cancer risk. • Vitamin B12 from the meat. • Collagen from the long cooking.	Good for these conditions • Appetite: a rich, deeply flavoured Bolognese with pasta is one of the most reliably eaten dishes in any kitchen. • Dementia: the smell of Bolognese cooking is one of the most universally recognised cooking aromas. • Cancer support: lycopene from the cooked tomatoes and iron from the meat are both relevant in cancer care.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made with pasta or mashed potato.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Ensure mince pieces are small. The sauce keeps everything moist.
5	Minced and moist	The mince is already finely textured. Mix with extra sauce to ensure cohesion throughout.
4	Puréed	Blend the sauce until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve. Serve with smooth mashed potato.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Bolognese became one of the most popular dishes in the British domestic kitchen from the 1970s onwards. It is associated with family cooking, weeknight suppers, and the kind of reliable, substantial food that most clients will have made many times themselves.

Presentation tip

From the freezer to the plate, the quality should be indistinguishable from freshly made.

Watch out for

Cool completely before freezing. Defrost overnight in the fridge, not at room temperature. Reheat thoroughly until piping hot throughout.

Make it easier

This is the ultimate batch cooking recipe: one 2-hour session produces the foundation for 8-10 meals. Label each frozen portion with the date and contents.

Batch Root Vegetable Soup

Batch cooking | Makes 6-8 portions | Autumn and winter

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Heart health

Dementia

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A large batch of smooth root vegetable soup, made with whatever combination of roots is available, is one of the most nutritionally dense and adaptable things a carer can have in the freezer. It is naturally appropriate for IDDSI Level 4 after sieving and can be enriched with cream or butter for clients needing additional calories.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Mixed root vegetables: carrot, parsnip, swede, celeriac	1kg total
Brown onions, diced	2 large
Garlic cloves, crushed	3 cloves
Unsalted butter or olive oil	3 tbsp
Good chicken or vegetable stock	1.5 litres
Ground cumin or coriander (optional)	1 tsp
Double cream (optional, for enrichment)	100ml
Salt and white pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Cook the onions in the butter over a medium heat for 10 minutes until soft. Add the garlic and spices if using.
- Add all the peeled and diced root vegetables. Stir to coat.
- Add the stock. Bring to a simmer and cook for 30-35 minutes until all vegetables are completely tender.
- Blend in batches until completely smooth. Add the cream if using.
- Pass through a fine sieve for IDDSI Level 4. For regular serving, sieve is optional.
- Season well. Cool completely. Portion into individual servings.
- Refrigerate for up to 4 days or freeze for up to 3 months.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Beta-carotene from the carrots and parsnips: a powerful antioxidant and vitamin A precursor.
- Fibre from the root vegetables.
- Vitamin C from the vegetables.
- Calories from the cream and butter if added.
- Potassium: note caution for CKD clients.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: a smooth, sweet root vegetable soup is one of the most accepted dishes across all levels of appetite difficulty.
- Heart health: root vegetables and olive oil are both associated with cardiovascular benefit.
- Dementia: the warmth, sweetness, and familiar smell of root vegetable soup is deeply comforting.
- Dysphagia: smooth after sieving to IDDSI Level 4.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Sieve after blending. Check consistency before each serving. Enrich with cream for additional calories.
7	Regular	Serve blended but not sieved for a smooth, slightly textured result.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Root vegetable soup is associated with autumn and winter kitchens, warmth, and careful nourishing cooking. It is one of those dishes that most clients will not be able to identify precisely but will respond to warmly.

Presentation tip

From the freezer: defrost overnight, reheat gently, check consistency, and serve in a warmed bowl with a swirl of cream.

Watch out for

Label all frozen portions clearly with date and contents. High in potassium from the root vegetables: limit for clients with CKD.

Make it easier

One large batch produces 6-8 individual portions that can be defrosted and served in minutes. The most efficient soup in the book.

Batch Tomato and Lentil Sauce

Batch cooking | Makes 6-8 portions | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 45 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Diabetes

Cancer support

Appetite/nutrition

ABOUT THIS DISH

A large batch of rich tomato and red lentil sauce is one of the most nutritionally valuable and versatile items a care kitchen freezer can hold. The lentils dissolve into the sauce during cooking, thickening it naturally and adding protein, fibre, and iron without altering the familiar tomato flavour. It serves as a pasta sauce, a base for shakshuka, a filling for baked potatoes, and much more.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Red split lentils	200g
Brown onions, finely diced	2 large
Garlic cloves, crushed	4 cloves
Tinned plum tomatoes	3 x 400g tins
Good vegetable stock	500ml
Tomato puree	2 tbsp
Olive oil	3 tbsp
Smoked paprika	1 tsp
Ground cumin	1 tsp
Salt and black pepper	To taste

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Cook the onions in the olive oil over a medium heat for 10-12 minutes until deeply softened.
- Add the garlic, tomato puree, paprika, and cumin. Cook for 3 minutes.
- Rinse the lentils and add to the pan with the tinned tomatoes and stock.
- Bring to a simmer and cook for 30-35 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the lentils have completely dissolved into the sauce.
- Season well. Cool completely. Portion into individual servings.
- Refrigerate for up to 4 days or freeze for up to 3 months.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Plant protein from the lentils: one of the richest plant sources.
- Iron from the lentils and tomatoes.
- Lycopene from the cooked tomatoes.
- Fibre: lentils are extraordinarily rich in both soluble and insoluble fibre.
- Folate from the lentils.

Good for these conditions

- Heart health: lentils are one of the most evidence-based dietary choices for cardiovascular health. Combined with olive oil and tomatoes this is a deeply cardioprotective sauce.
- Diabetes: lentils have a very low glycaemic index and are one of the best foods for blood sugar management.
- Cancer support: lycopene from the cooked tomatoes and the anti-inflammatory compounds in the spices.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Blend until completely smooth and pass through a fine sieve. The dissolved lentils create a naturally thick smooth sauce.
7	Regular	Serve as made with pasta or rice. The lentils are fully dissolved.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

A rich, savoury tomato sauce is one of the most universally comforting foods across all British backgrounds. The lentils are invisible in the finished sauce.

Presentation tip

From the freezer: defrost, reheat thoroughly, serve with pasta, rice, or as a base for further dishes.

Watch out for

Lentils continue to absorb liquid as the sauce cools and reheats: add a splash of stock when reheating to restore the correct consistency.

Make it easier

One of the most efficient batch cooking recipes in the book: simple ingredients, minimal technique, extraordinary nutritional return.

Batch Braised Lamb Shoulder Portions

Batch cooking | Makes 4-5 portions | All year

DIFFICULTY
Easy

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 4 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Dementia

Appetite/nutrition

Bone health

ABOUT THIS DISH

A whole lamb shoulder braised until falling tender, then portioned and frozen, provides 4-5 ready-made main courses of the highest quality. Each portion reheats to the same tenderness as when first cooked. This is the batch cooking principle at its finest: one afternoon of patient cooking that provides a week of excellent meals.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Lamb shoulder, bone-in	1.2-1.5kg
Brown onions, roughly diced	2
Carrots, roughly diced	2
Celery sticks	3 sticks
Garlic cloves, crushed	4 cloves
Rosemary and thyme	Several sprigs
Good chicken or lamb stock	400ml
Tomato puree	1 tbsp
Salt and black pepper	Generous seasoning

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 160°C / 140°C fan / Gas 3.

- Season the lamb generously. Brown all over in a heavy casserole over high heat.
- Add the vegetables, garlic, herbs, tomato puree, and stock.
- Cover tightly with a double layer of foil and the lid. Braise for 3.5-4 hours until completely tender.
- Remove the lamb. Strain the cooking juices. Skim the fat. Reduce the juices to concentrate the flavour if needed.
- Shred the lamb into generous portions. Place in freezer containers. Pour the reduced cooking juices over each portion to cover.
- Cool completely. Label clearly. Freeze for up to 3 months.
- To serve: defrost overnight. Reheat gently in a covered pan with extra stock if needed until piping hot.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Complete protein from the lamb: excellent for muscle maintenance. • Collagen from the slow cooking: supports joint health. • Iron and zinc from the lamb. • B vitamins including B12.	• Dementia: the smell of reheating lamb is deeply comforting and often stimulates appetite. • Appetite: rich, falling-tender lamb in its own deeply flavoured jus is one of the most reliably eaten main courses in elderly care. • Bone health: collagen from the slow-cooked lamb contributes to joint and bone support.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve shredded with the cooking juices and accompaniments.
6	Soft and bite-sized	The slow-cooked lamb shreds naturally into very small tender pieces. Moisten generously with the reheated cooking juices.
5	Minced and moist	Shred very finely. Mix with the cooking juices until completely moist.
4	Puréed	Blend the shredded lamb with the cooking juices and a little cream until completely smooth. Pass through a fine sieve.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Slow-roasted lamb is one of the most deeply nostalgic of all British Sunday lunch experiences. Reheated from a batch cook, it should be indistinguishable from freshly made.

Presentation tip

Serve with mashed potato, green vegetables, and the reheated cooking juices as a gravy.

Watch out for

The lamb must be completely covered by the cooking juices before freezing or it will dry out. Reheat thoroughly: the internal temperature must reach 75°C.

Make it easier

The most efficient meat batch cook in the book. One afternoon produces 4-5 excellent main courses.



Chapter 21

Celebration and Occasion

The meals that mark the moments that matter

Classic Roast Turkey with All the Trimmings

Celebration and occasion | Serves 4-6 | Winter

DIFFICULTY
Hard

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 45 mins | Cook 3 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Cancer support

ABOUT THIS DISH

Christmas dinner is the most significant meal in the British calendar and the single most important occasion meal a carer may be asked to produce. For many elderly clients living alone or in a care setting, a proper Christmas dinner, made with care and served at a properly laid table, is one of the most profound gestures of belonging and being valued that exists. This recipe walks through the full production: turkey, roast potatoes, stuffing, bread sauce, and gravy.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Turkey crown or small whole turkey	2-3kg crown / 4-5kg whole
Unsalted butter, softened	80g
Fresh thyme and rosemary	Several sprigs
Garlic cloves	4 cloves
Lemon	1
Salt and black pepper	Generous seasoning
Maris Piper potatoes, peeled	1kg
Goose fat or vegetable oil	4 tbsp
Pork sausage meat	300g
Fresh sage, finely chopped	8 leaves
Breadcrumbs	50g

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 200°C / 180°C fan / Gas 6 for the initial blast.

- Remove the turkey from the fridge 1 hour before cooking. Rub all over with softened butter, under the skin where possible. Season very generously. Stuff the cavity with the lemon, garlic, and herbs.
- Roast at 200°C for 20 minutes to colour the skin, then reduce to 170°C. Allow 20 minutes per 500g for a crown, 25 minutes per 500g for a whole bird, plus 30 minutes resting.
- Make the stuffing: combine the sausage meat, breadcrumbs, and sage. Season well. Roll into a log, wrap in streaky bacon if available, and roast alongside the turkey for the final 40 minutes.
- Parboil the potatoes for 8 minutes. Drain, shake to fluff the edges. Roast in very hot goose fat for 45-50 minutes, turning once, until deeply golden.
- Make the gravy: drain the tin, deglaze with stock, reduce to a glossy consistency.
- Rest the turkey for a minimum of 30 minutes before carving.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Complete lean protein from the turkey: excellent for muscle maintenance.
- B vitamins, selenium, and zinc from the turkey.
- Carbohydrate from the roast potatoes.
- Iron from the sausage meat stuffing.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: Christmas dinner, properly made and properly presented, is one of the most powerful appetite stimulants of the entire year.
- Dementia: Christmas dinner is among the most deeply embedded of all British cultural memories. The smells, the sounds, and the ritual of the table are all powerful positive triggers.
- Cancer support: high-quality lean protein from the turkey supports tissue maintenance.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve carved, with all trimmings and plenty of gravy.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use the dark leg meat rather than breast, which is drier. Cut into very small pieces and moisten generously with gravy. Mashed potato in place of roast.
5	Minced and moist	Finely shred the dark turkey meat. Combine with gravy until very moist. Smooth stuffing can be made without sausage skin.

4	Puréed	Blend the turkey and gravy until completely smooth. Each element of the plate should be separately puréed and presented distinctly.
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CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

There is no occasion more deeply embedded in British cultural life than Christmas dinner. For elderly clients, whether they have family present or not, receiving a proper Christmas dinner made with love is one of the most significant things a carer can do. Set the table properly. Use the good plates. Light a candle if available.

Presentation tip

The whole bird brought to the table before carving is one of the great theatrical moments of the year. If serving a crown, place it on a carving board surrounded by the accompaniments. The visual abundance of a properly set Christmas table matters enormously.

Watch out for

The turkey must be cooked to a core temperature of 75°C. Use a probe thermometer. Rest fully before carving or the juices will run out. Do not stuff the cavity of a whole turkey as this slows the cooking unevenly.

Make it easier

A turkey crown is significantly easier to manage than a whole bird: better proportions, faster cooking, easier carving. For one or two clients, a crown is the right choice.

Celebration Birthday Cake

Celebration and occasion | Serves 8-10 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 30 mins | Cook 35 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A proper birthday cake, made from scratch, is one of the most significant gestures a carer can make. It transforms a birthday from an ordinary day into a celebration. This is a classic Victoria sponge: two golden butter sponges sandwiched with jam and buttercream and dusted with icing sugar. It is the most recognised and beloved of all British celebration cakes and the most reliably successful.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Unsalted butter, softened	225g
Caster sugar	225g
Eggs, at room temperature	4 large eggs
Self-raising flour	225g
Baking powder	1 tsp
Vanilla extract	1 tsp
Full-fat milk	2-3 tbsp
Good raspberry or strawberry jam	4 tbsp
Unsalted butter (for buttercream)	150g
Icing sugar, sifted (for buttercream)	300g
Vanilla extract (for buttercream)	0.5 tsp
Icing sugar for dusting	2 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 180°C / 160°C fan / Gas 4.

- Grease and line two 20cm round cake tins.
- Beat the softened butter and caster sugar together until pale, light, and very fluffy, at least 5 minutes.
- Beat in the eggs one at a time, adding a spoonful of flour with each egg to prevent curdling.
- Fold in the remaining flour, baking powder, and vanilla gently. Add enough milk to achieve a dropping consistency.
- Divide between the two tins and bake for 25-30 minutes until risen, golden, and a skewer comes out clean. Cool completely.
- Make the buttercream: beat the butter until very pale. Gradually add the icing sugar and vanilla. Beat until fluffy.
- Spread jam on one sponge. Spread buttercream generously on the other. Sandwich together. Dust the top with icing sugar.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients	Good for these conditions
• Significant calories: one slice provides meaningful calorie enrichment. • Protein from the eggs. • Carbohydrate from the flour and sugar.	• Appetite: a birthday cake presented with candles and a genuine celebration tends to produce extraordinary appetite response even in clients who otherwise eat very little. • Dementia: a birthday, marked properly with a cake and candles, provides a powerful positive anchor of identity, recognition, and being valued.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve a generous slice. The buttercream keeps everything moist.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut into very small pieces. The buttercream and jam moisten the sponge. Remove any very dry edges.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

A birthday cake with candles is one of the most universally recognised markers of being celebrated and valued. For clients who may not have family present to mark the occasion, the carer making and presenting a birthday cake is an act of care that should never be underestimated.

Presentation tip

Place candles on the top. Light them. Sing. Present the cake on a plate or cake stand, not on a baking tray. The ceremony is as important as the cake.

Watch out for

The butter and eggs must be at room temperature before baking or the mixture will curdle. The cake must be completely cool before applying buttercream or it will melt.

Make it easier

The sponges can be baked the day before and stored in an airtight container. Fill and decorate on the day.

Christmas Pudding with Brandy Butter

Celebration and occasion | Serves 6-8 | Winter

DIFFICULTY
Hard

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 1 hr | Cook 8 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Christmas pudding is one of the most ancient and ceremonial of all British foods: a rich, dark, spiced pudding made weeks or months ahead and steamed for hours on Christmas Day before being brought to the table aflame. For elderly clients, it is inseparable from Christmas itself. A homemade Christmas pudding, served with proper brandy butter, is one of the most powerful gestures of occasion a carer can make.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Sultanas	150g
Raisins	150g
Currants	100g
Mixed peel	50g
Dark stout or brandy	100ml
Self-raising flour	75g
Shredded suet	75g
Fresh breadcrumbs	75g
Dark muscovado sugar	100g
Mixed spice and cinnamon	1 tsp each
Eggs	2 eggs

Unsalted butter (for brandy butter)	100g
Icing sugar (for brandy butter)	150g
Brandy (for brandy butter)	2-3 tbsp

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Soak all the dried fruit in the stout or brandy overnight.
- Combine the flour, suet, breadcrumbs, sugar, and spices. Add the soaked fruit and eggs. Mix thoroughly.
- Spoon into a greased 1-litre pudding basin. Cover with a double layer of greaseproof paper and foil, tied securely.
- Steam for 6-8 hours, topping up the water regularly.
- Cool completely. Store in a cool place for up to 3 months. Steam again for 2-3 hours before serving.
- Make the brandy butter: beat the butter until very pale. Beat in the icing sugar and brandy gradually. Refrigerate.
- To serve: turn out onto a warm plate. Pour over a warmed measure of brandy and flame if desired.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Iron from the dried fruit: useful for clients at risk of anaemia.
- Fibre from the dried fruit.
- Significant calories from the suet and butter.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: Christmas pudding is so deeply associated with celebration and occasion that even clients with very poor appetite tend to eat it with pleasure.
- Dementia: Christmas pudding carries more cultural weight than almost any other food in British life. The smell during steaming, the flame on serving, and the brandy butter are all powerful nostalgic triggers.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve a slice with brandy butter melting over.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Break into very small pieces. The Christmas pudding softens significantly with brandy butter. Serve in small spoonfuls.
5	Minced and moist	Crumble very finely. Combine with softened brandy butter and a splash of cream until cohesive and moist.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Christmas pudding is perhaps the single most culturally loaded food in the British calendar. The ritual of making it on Stir-up Sunday, the silver coin, the brandy flame: these are memories that go very deep. Making it from scratch for a client is an act of extraordinary care.

Presentation tip

Turned out onto a warm plate, the dark domed pudding with brandy butter melting down the sides. If flaming, dim the lights for maximum effect.

Watch out for

Keep the water topped up during steaming: a dry pudding basin is a fire risk. The flame should be brief. Brandy butter is very rich: a small amount alongside is sufficient.

Make it easier

A good quality ready-made Christmas pudding is an acceptable alternative if time does not allow for making from scratch. Heat as directed and serve with homemade brandy butter, which takes 10 minutes.

Proper Afternoon Tea

Celebration and occasion | Serves 2 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 45 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A proper British afternoon tea is one of the most civilised and joyful of all domestic occasions: sandwiches, scones with clotted cream and jam, and a slice of something sweet, served on proper plates with good tea in proper cups. In a care setting it transforms an ordinary afternoon into an event. It requires planning and some preparation but the effect on a client's wellbeing and mood is profound.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
White bread, thinly sliced	4-6 slices
Good quality butter, softened	A generous amount
Cucumber, very thinly sliced	Half
Smoked salmon (optional)	60g
Egg mayonnaise (see salads chapter)	3 tbsp
Self-raising flour (for scones)	225g
Butter (for scones)	55g cold
Caster sugar (for scones)	2 tbsp
Full-fat milk (for scones)	150ml approximately
Clotted cream	A generous pot
Good strawberry or raspberry jam	A small jar
A slice of Victoria sponge or lemon drizzle cake	Per person

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Make the scones: rub the cold butter into the flour and sugar until it resembles breadcrumbs. Add enough milk to bring together into a soft dough. Pat to 2cm thickness. Cut with a round cutter. Brush with milk. Bake at 220°C for 12-14 minutes until well-risen and golden.
- Make the sandwiches: butter the bread very generously. Fill with cucumber and smoked salmon, or egg mayonnaise. Remove crusts. Cut into fingers or triangles.
- Arrange everything on tiered plates if available, or on a large plate: sandwiches on the bottom, scones in the middle, cake at the top.
- Brew a pot of good tea. Use proper cups, not mugs. Set the table properly with a cloth if available.
- Serve the scones warm. Clotted cream and jam in small dishes alongside.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Calcium from the clotted cream, butter, and milk in the scones. • Protein from the sandwiches. • Carbohydrate from the scones and bread. • Significant calories: afternoon tea is an excellent calorie enrichment opportunity.	Good for these conditions • Bone health: cream, butter, and milk all provide calcium. Afternoon tea is one of the most effective ways to deliver dairy calories in a pleasant form. • Appetite: afternoon tea is served in small pieces across multiple courses and tends to produce excellent intake even in clients with poor appetite. • Dementia: afternoon tea is one of the most culturally embedded of all British social rituals. The ritual of laying the table, brewing the tea, and presenting the tiered plates is itself therapeutic.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as presented.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Use very soft crustless bread. Cut sandwiches very small. Serve scones with cream and jam but cut into small pieces. Soft sponge cake with cream.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Afternoon tea is one of the most powerful triggers of social memory and identity in British culture. For clients who took tea seriously throughout their lives, whether at home or in hotels, setting a proper tea table is an act of deep respect and recognition.

Presentation tip

Use the best china available. A cloth on the table. Proper cups and saucers, not mugs. A small vase of flowers if possible. The presentation is the point: afternoon tea is entirely an occasion.

Watch out for

Scones must be eaten warm: they become heavy and doughy when cold. Brew the tea properly: warmed pot, measured leaves or bags, correct brewing time. The quality of the tea matters.

Make it easier

The scones can be prepared up to the cutting stage and refrigerated overnight. Bake fresh on the day. The sandwiches should be made no more than 2 hours ahead and kept covered with a damp cloth.

Easter Simnel Cake

Celebration and occasion | Serves 8-10 | Spring

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 40 mins | Cook 2 hrs

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Simnel cake is the traditional British Easter cake: a light fruit cake with a layer of marzipan baked through the centre and another on top, decorated with eleven balls of marzipan representing the apostles. It has been made in Britain since at least the medieval period and is one of the most distinctively British of all seasonal bakes. For clients of a certain background, it will be immediately recognised and associated with Easter celebrations.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Unsalted butter, softened	175g
Golden caster sugar	175g
Eggs	3 large eggs
Self-raising flour	175g
Mixed spice	1 tsp
Mixed dried fruit: sultanas, currants, raisins	300g
Mixed peel	50g
Lemon, zested	1 lemon
Good quality marzipan	500g
Apricot jam (for glazing)	2 tbs

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

Preheat the oven to 150°C / 130°C fan / Gas 2.

- Grease and double-line a 20cm round tin.
- Beat the butter and sugar until pale and fluffy. Beat in the eggs one at a time.
- Fold in the flour and spice. Stir in the dried fruit, peel, and lemon zest.
- Roll a third of the marzipan into a 20cm circle.
- Spoon half the cake mixture into the tin. Lay the marzipan circle on top. Spoon the remaining mixture over.
- Bake for 2-2.5 hours until a skewer comes out clean. Cool completely.
- Brush the top with warmed apricot jam. Roll out half the remaining marzipan and lay on top. Roll eleven small balls from the rest and arrange around the edge.
- Toast lightly under the grill or with a blowtorch until golden.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Significant calories from the marzipan, butter, and fruit. • Iron from the dried fruit. • Fibre from the dried fruit.	Good for these conditions • Appetite: a slice of simnel cake with a cup of tea provides meaningful calorie enrichment. • Dementia: Easter is a major landmark in the British calendar and simnel cake is immediately associated with it by clients of a certain generation.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve a generous slice with a cup of tea.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut into very small pieces. The marzipan softens the cake and keeps it moist. Remove any very dry edges.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Simnel cake is associated with Easter, with Sunday school, with a certain tradition of seasonal British baking that has meaning beyond the food itself. For clients of a certain religious background it carries particular significance.
Presentation tip The toasted marzipan top is the visual signature of the simnel cake. Present on a cake stand or plate with a few spring flowers alongside if available.

Watch out for

The long, slow baking is important: do not be tempted to increase the temperature. Check with a skewer after 2 hours. The cake keeps well in an airtight tin for 2 weeks.

Make it easier

The cake improves with keeping: make it a week ahead. The marzipan top can be applied and toasted on the day of serving.

New Year's Eve Smoked Salmon Blinis

Celebration and occasion | Makes 12-16 blinis | Winter

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 7

AT A GLANCE
Prep 20 mins | Cook 20 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Heart health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

Blinis with smoked salmon and soured cream are the quintessential British celebration canapé of the late twentieth century, appearing on every New Year's Eve, Christmas party, and special occasion table. They are small, elegant, require no cutlery, and are deeply associated with festivity and celebration. Making them for a client on New Year's Eve is a genuine gesture of inclusion and occasion.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Buckwheat flour or plain flour	100g
Egg	1
Full-fat milk	150ml
Dried yeast	0.5 tsp
Salt	A pinch
Unsalted butter (for frying)	20g
Good smoked salmon	100g
Soured cream or creme fraiche	4 tbsp
Fresh dill	A little
Black pepper	A grind
Lemon wedge	1

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Mix the flour, yeast, and salt. Make a well and add the egg and milk. Whisk until smooth. Leave in a warm place for 30 minutes to rest and rise slightly.
- Heat a non-stick pan over a medium heat. Add a little butter.
- Drop tablespoons of batter into the pan. Cook for 2 minutes until bubbles form on the surface. Flip and cook for 1 further minute until golden.
- Keep warm in a low oven. Repeat until all the batter is used.
- Top each blini with a small spoonful of soured cream, a piece of smoked salmon, a tiny sprig of dill, and a grind of black pepper.
- Serve immediately.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients • Omega-3 from the smoked salmon. • Protein from the salmon and egg. • Vitamin D from the salmon. • Calcium from the soured cream.	Good for these conditions • Heart health: smoked salmon is one of the most cardioprotective foods available. • Appetite: blinis are small, elegant, and require no cutlery. The festive context tends to produce excellent appetite even in clients who otherwise eat sparingly. • Dementia: smoked salmon blinis are strongly associated with New Year's Eve and celebration. The festivity of the occasion is itself therapeutic.
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TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve as made, topped and presented.
6	Soft and bite-sized	Cut each blini into very small pieces. The soured cream keeps everything moist. Ensure smoked salmon is cut very small.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note Smoked salmon blinis appeared on virtually every British celebration table from the 1980s onwards. For clients who entertained or attended parties throughout their adult lives, they are inseparably associated with the best occasions.
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Presentation tip

Arrange on a white plate or board. The soured cream, salmon, and dill together are visually striking. Serve immediately from the pan for maximum freshness.

Watch out for

Blinis must be served warm and fresh: they deteriorate quickly. Smoked salmon is very high in sodium: limit for clients with hypertension. Check for fish allergy.

Make it easier

The batter can be made ahead and rested. The blinis themselves take less than 5 minutes to cook once the batter is ready.

Champagne and Elderflower Jelly

Celebration and occasion | Serves 4 | Spring and summer

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 4

AT A GLANCE
Prep 15 mins | Cook 5 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

Dysphagia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A sparkling champagne and elderflower jelly is one of the most elegant and unexpected of all celebration puddings. It is naturally appropriate for IDDSI Level 4, requires no cooking in the traditional sense, and the result is a pudding of extraordinary lightness and festivity that works as well at a celebration lunch as at a formal dinner. Elderflower and champagne is a quintessentially English summer combination.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Prosecco or champagne (or sparkling apple juice)	300ml
Elderflower cordial	50ml
Cold water	100ml
Caster sugar	2 tbsp
Leaf gelatine	4 leaves (approx 8g)
Fresh berries or edible flowers to serve	A few

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Soak the gelatine leaves in cold water for 5 minutes.

- Heat the water and sugar together until the sugar dissolves. Remove from the heat.
- Squeeze the water from the gelatine leaves and stir into the warm sugar syrup until completely dissolved.
- Allow to cool to room temperature. Gently stir in the elderflower cordial and prosecco. Do not stir vigorously or the bubbles will be lost.
- Pour into lightly oiled small moulds or glasses. Refrigerate for at least 4 hours until set.
- To serve: turn out or serve in the glass. Add a few fresh berries alongside.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Minimal calories: a light pudding suitable after a rich meal.
- Vitamin C from the berries.
- The elderflower cordial provides a small amount of sugar.

Good for these conditions

- Appetite: the visual of a sparkling jelly with berries is one of the most celebratory presentations in this book.
- Dementia: champagne and elderflower are strongly associated with summer occasions and celebrations: weddings, garden parties, and summer lunches.
- Dysphagia: a jelly set to the correct IDDSI Level 4 standard is a naturally appropriate celebration pudding. Avoid any berry garnishes that would require chewing for IDDSI clients.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
4	Puréed	Jelly at the correct gelatine ratio naturally achieves IDDSI Level 4. It should melt on the tongue and hold its shape briefly when turned out. Do not use berry garnishes for IDDSI clients.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

Champagne and elderflower is associated with the very best of English summer celebrations. For clients who attended weddings, garden parties, and summer occasions throughout their adult lives, the combination carries an immediate and pleasant nostalgic charge.

Presentation tip

Turn out onto a small white plate or serve in a champagne flute or wide wine glass. The palest gold, gently sparkling. A few fresh raspberries or strawberries alongside for clients who can manage them.

Watch out for

The gelatine must be completely dissolved or the jelly will have an uneven set. Do not stir vigorously once the prosecco is added. For IDDSI Level 4 clients, no berry garnishes.

Make it easier

Must be made at least 4 hours ahead and ideally overnight. An ideal make-ahead celebration pudding.

Traditional Trifle

Celebration and occasion | Serves 4-6 | All year

DIFFICULTY
Medium

IDDSI LEVEL
Level 6

AT A GLANCE
Prep 30 mins | Cook 15 mins

HEALTH CONDITION TAGS

Bone health

Appetite/nutrition

Dementia

ABOUT THIS DISH

A proper British trifle is one of the most celebratory and generous of all desserts: sponge soaked in sherry, fresh or tinned fruit, set jelly, a deep layer of proper custard, and thick whipped cream on top. It has appeared on British celebration tables since the eighteenth century. For elderly clients, a trifle in a glass bowl in the centre of the table is one of the most powerful visual signals of occasion and abundance.

INGREDIENTS

Ingredient	Amount (1 person)
Trifle sponges or stale sponge cake	6-8 sponges
Good sherry or fruit juice	100ml
Tinned peaches, raspberries, or mixed fruit	1 x 400g tin
Raspberry or strawberry jelly (set to wobbling)	1 packet set in 400ml
Proper custard (see sauces chapter)	400ml
Double cream	300ml
Icing sugar	1 tbsp
Flaked almonds, cherries, or berries to decorate	A little

Quantities are for one person. Scale as needed. Most soups freeze well.

METHOD

- Break the sponges into the base of a trifle bowl. Pour the sherry or juice over and leave to soak for 10 minutes.
- Drain the fruit and arrange over the sponge.
- Pour the just-setting jelly over the fruit. Refrigerate until the jelly is set.
- Pour the cooled custard over the set jelly. Refrigerate until the custard is set.
- Whip the cream with the icing sugar to soft peaks. Spread generously over the custard.
- Decorate with flaked almonds, cherries, or berries.

WHY THIS DISH IS GOOD FOR YOUR CLIENT

Key nutrients

- Calcium from the custard and cream.
- Protein from the custard egg content.
- Significant calories from the cream, custard, and sponge.
- Vitamin C from the fruit.

Good for these conditions

- Bone health: the generous custard and cream provide excellent calcium.
- Appetite: trifle is one of the most visually abundant and celebratory of all British puddings. Presenting it in a glass bowl so the layers are visible is enormously appetising.
- Dementia: trifle is one of the most deeply embedded of all British celebration puddings, associated with Christmas, birthdays, and family gatherings.

TEXTURE ADAPTATION AND IDDSI GUIDANCE

Level	Texture	Adaptation required
7	Regular	Serve a generous portion ensuring all layers are represented.
6	Soft and bite-sized	All components of trifle are naturally soft. Ensure the sponge is very well soaked. The jelly, custard, and cream are all appropriate at Level 6.
5	Minced and moist	Ensure the sponge is very thoroughly soaked until it has broken down completely into the sherry and juice.

CARER TIPS

Nostalgia note

The trifle bowl in the centre of the table is one of the most powerful visual signals of celebration in British domestic life. Many clients will have a clear memory of a parent's or grandmother's trifle as the high point of a Christmas or birthday meal.

Presentation tip

Always serve in a glass bowl so the layers are visible. This is the whole point of a trifle. Bring to the table whole before serving. The visual impact is as important as the taste.

Watch out for

The jelly must be completely set before adding the custard, and the custard must be completely set before adding the cream. Rushing these steps produces a collapsed, muddy trifle. Allow each layer sufficient time.

Make it easier

The trifle must be made ahead: at least 4 hours for each layer to set. An ideal make-ahead celebration pudding that improves overnight.

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